FRIDAY, AUGUST 21, 2026

REG.NO. MCS/067/2018 - 20 RNI REGN. NO. 1543/57

The Indian EXPRESS

MUMBAI, LATE CITY, 22 PAGES

JOURNALISM of COURAGE

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The Editorial Page: Modi-ism must evolve into institution-centred nation-building 10

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MARATHI PROFICIENCY AMONG TAXI, AUTORICKSHAW DRIVERS

Crackdown begins: Notices, roadside tests & heated exchanges on Day 1

An RTO officer said the assessment was based on 15 to 16 questions. AKASH PATIL MORE PHOTOS, PAGE 4

Apoorva Agashe & Ishika Gupta
Mumbai, August 20

AT DADAR'S Swaminarayan Temple on Thursday, the usual bustle of taxis picking up passengers gave way to roadside Marathi tests, with RTO officials stopping drivers and asking them to respond in Marathi to everyday requests about destinations, fares, travel time, UPI payments and routes. By the end of the first day of the crackdown, 8,217 drivers had been tested across Maharashtra, with 1,268 notices issued to those found lacking the required Marathi knowledge, including 604 notices among 3,995 drivers tested across the Mumbai Metropolitan Region.

The figures marked the first day of enforcement of the Maharashtra Transport Department's requirement that taxi and autorickshaw drivers demonstrate a working knowledge of Marathi. Flying squads were deployed across Mumbai and the Mumbai Metropolitan Region.

An RTO officer said the assessment was based on 15 to 16 questions. "The process is very simple. We have a list of 15 to 16 questions based on which we are analysing whether the driver knows Marathi. If he fails, then we are issuing notice to him," the officer said.

The exercise, officials stressed, is not meant to test fluency. The idea is to determine whether a driver can understand and respond to the basic Marathi needed while dealing with passengers. "The questions which are issued by the government help to analyse

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

The huddle in the South

(From left) Chief Ministers D K Shivakumar (Karnataka), N Chandrababu Naidu (Andhra Pradesh), C Joseph Vijay (Tamil Nadu) and V D Satheesan (Kerala) at the 31st Southern Zonal Council meeting in Chengalpattu, near Chennai, Thursday. ANI FULL REPORT, PAGE 8

Anti-national, for vote bank: Shah slams CWC decision on two-stanza Vande Mataram

Jatin Anand
New Delhi, August 20

A DAY after the Congress decided to sing only the first two stanzas of Vande Mataram at its programmes, Union Home Minister Amit Shah launched a scathing attack on the party, calling its decision "astonishing" and "anti-national".

He said the Congress Working Committee decision only confirmed its "policy of vote-bank appeasement" and was a violation of the law enacted by Parliament on the rendition of the full national song.

Posting a video clip on X in which he is seen speaking to news agency ANI, Shah said, "The Congress Working Committee has taken an astonishing and anti-national decision.

Home Minister Amit Shah at the Southern Zonal Council meet in Chengalpattu, Thursday. ANI

Following their 1937 resolution, they have decided to sing only two stanzas of the great song Vande Mataram. I want to remind the entire country that in 1937, the Congress, for the sake of Muslim appeasement, laid the foundation for the partition of the country by breaking Vande Mataram

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Unease in section of Cong, Singhvi draws distinction between 'public and private'

Before CWC decision, full song sung on I-Day in three Cong state govt functions

Manoj C G
New Delhi, August 20

A DAY after the Congress Working Committee (CWC) reaffirmed that only the first two stanzas of Vande Mataram would be sung at party events, there is a growing sense of unease in sections of the party that believe the leadership should have handled the matter with more nuance.

Noted lawyer and the Congress's legal wing head Abhishek Manu Singhvi told *The Indian Express* that he had given the party leadership his legal opinion, interpreting the law "as it stands today", and drew a distinction between public and private functions. This comes barely a week after Vande Mataram was sung in its entirety during the official Independence Day events in Congress-ruled Himachal Pradesh, Karnataka, and Telangana, as well as Jharkhand, where the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

EXPLAINED

VANDE MATARAM: RELIGIOUS IMAGERY, POLITICAL DEBATE

PAGE 13

AMID ROW OVER CAMPUS REGULATIONS

UGC equity rules being reconsidered: Centre to SC

Political dilemma in UP and Bihar over regulations against caste discrimination

Ananthakrishnan G & Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, August 20

THE CENTRE told the Supreme Court Thursday that it is reconsidering the University Grants Commission (UGC) regulations aimed at preventing caste discrimination in higher education institutions.

Notified on January 13 but stayed by the Supreme Court on January 29, the UGC (Promotion of Equity in Higher Education Institutions) Regulations, 2026 snowballed into a political issue after it drew objections from general category groups over their perceived exclusion and from sections of Dalit and OBC communities opposed to the court stay and any rollback.

"It is being reconsidered," Solicitor General Tushar Mehta told a three-judge bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant. The bench was hearing a clutch of petitions that primarily challenge the definition of "caste-based discrimination" in the regulations.

In the eye of the storm is regulation 3(1)(c), which defines caste-based discrimination as discrimination on the basis of caste or tribe against members of the Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes and Other Backward Classes.

Petitioners have argued that this excludes general category students and faculty from specific protection against caste-based discrimination. At the same time, the regulations' broader definition of

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

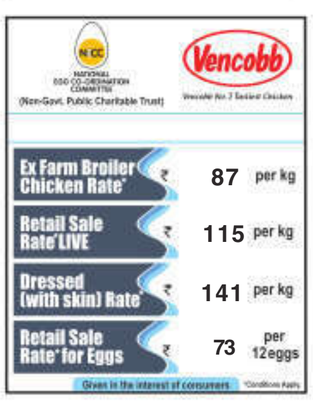
E. EXPLAINED

At centre of row

Regulation 3(1)(c) is the one being contested. It defines caste-based discrimination as discrimination on the basis of caste or tribe against members of the SCs, STs and OBCs. Petitioners say this excludes general category students and faculty from the protection umbrella. The regulations, notified in January, were stayed by the Supreme Court which revived the 2012 regulations until further orders.

NATION PAGE 12

DELHI PROTEST: SC NAMES 5-MEMBER PANEL TO PROBE 'POLICE EXCESSES'



SIR FORMS OF 4 OUT OF 10 VOTERS COULD NOT BE COLLECTED IN 25 SEATS – ALL URBAN

PAGE 7

Business as Usual
By EP UNNY

DAY AFTER PROTESTERS CALL OFF STIR

HC stays Soren govt cancellation of state civil services exams and appointments

3.5 lakh appeared, 7,011 shortlisted for mains; 864 got interview calls; 342 joined

Shubham Tigga
Ranchi, August 20

THE JHARKHAND High Court on Thursday stayed the state government's decision to cancel the 11th-13th Jharkhand Combined Civil Services examinations and a Food Safety Officer recruitment exam, observing that "a regular appointment cannot be disturbed/terminated without following principles of natural justice."

The development comes a day after those protesting alleged irregularities in government exams called off their agitation, based on the Hemant Soren government's promise to cancel these and some other examinations.

In his order on Thursday, Justice Deepak Roshan stayed the operation of the government notification cancelling the appointments of 342 officers and ordered their reinstatement. The court passed a similar order regarding the Food Safety Officer (FSO) 2024 recruitment exams for 56 posts, which was among the 22 recruitment exams the government had cancelled to bring an end to the agitation.

The Court observed that "a regular appointment cannot be disturbed/terminated without

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

EXPRESS exclusive

Maharashtra panel suggests BNS amendment for social media defamation

Move comes 11 years after apex court struck down Section 66A of IT Act

Mohamed Thaver
Mumbai, August 20

ELEVEN YEARS after the Supreme Court struck down Section 66A of the Information Technology Act, a Maharashtra government committee has recommended a state amendment to the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) to specifically cover defamatory social media posts, along with safeguards against its misuse, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The committee, set up in May to examine legal options for dealing with defamatory content online, has submitted its recommendations to the state Law and Judiciary Department.

According to sources, the committee has settled on a state amendment to the BNS, which sits on the Concurrent List. That route requires the state legislature to pass the amendment, after which it goes to the Centre and then to the President for assent before it can take effect. Amending the Maharashtra Police Act or seeking a change to the IT Act was considered and dropped.

"The BNS amendment route was preferred as it would be vetted at multiple levels and have a stronger footing if challenged in courts as compared to amending the state law. The IT Act is a central law and hence cannot be amended only at state level," the source said.

The BNS already defines defamation as making or publishing any imputation about a person, by words spoken or intended to be read, by signs or by visible representations, intending or knowing it will harm that person's reputation. It makes no specific mention of online content.

Section 66A criminalised sending messages through a computer or communication device that were considered grossly offensive or menacing, among other categories. It was invoked in cases involving comments, shared information and opinions posted online, and became the centre of a long argument over how far the state could police internet speech. On March 24, 2015, in Shreya Singhal vs Union of India, the Supreme Court struck it down as unconstitutional for violating the right to free speech under Article 19(1)(a).

The court held the provision

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

'WHERE WILL PEOPLE PLAY FOOTBALL?'

HC halts further steps on Bandra football ground conversion

The Neville D'Souza Football Ground at Bandra Reclamation. EXPRESS MORE REPORTS, PAGE 4

Omkar Gokhale
Mumbai, August 20

OBSERVING THAT open spaces must be protected, the Bombay High Court Thursday directed the BMC to not take any further steps on the plan to convert Neville D'Souza Football Ground at Bandra Reclamation into an exhibition or convention centre.

The court's directive came two days after the BMC's general body cleared a proposal to convert the gound into an exhibition or convention centre.

"You tell us where the people will be playing football now? Some space has to be left opon otherwise, the next generation will forget Maidani Khel (field sports) and the grounds,"

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

• WITH SURVEY STAFF NOT ALLOWED TO ENTER SOME GATED SOCIETIES, STATISTICS MINISTRY PLANS 'DIARY-BASED DATA COLLECTION'

RWAs a barrier, Govt may let high-income households compile own spending data

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, August 20

TWO YEARS ago, the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) and some Resident Welfare Associations (RWAs) had squared off: the latter felt the government's surveys asked difficult questions and sought private details, while the ministry was worried by the rising unresponsiveness from high-income households living in gated societies. Now, the ministry is considering letting these families compile their own data.

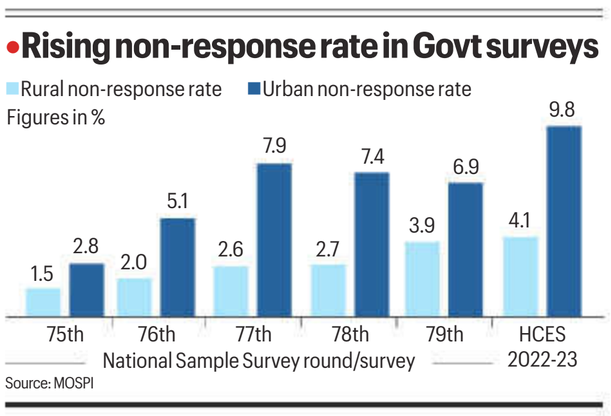
PAGE 1 anchor

With the next edition of the Household Consumption Expenditure Survey (HCES) expected to begin in mid-2027 and continue for about a year, the ministry is looking at the adoption of "diary-based data collection" for high-income households living in gated societies, instead of a door-to-door survey by field officials.

In this method, households note down the information themselves, as and when the relevant activity occurs. In the case of the HCES, this would mean jotting down how much is spent in a month on different goods and services, ranging from food items to haircuts.

The most recent HCES, conducted from August 2023 to July 2024, saw 2.6 lakh households being surveyed from across the country, barring a few inaccessible villages in the Andaman and Nicobar Islands. The survey sought responses for a total of 405 goods and services.

While it is called "diary-based data collection", households may not have to actually note down their expenses in a physical diary. The ministry, which now uses tablets to record responses to its surveys, may employ a system where such households can enter their consumption expenditure details on an online portal, sources said.



"This is at a planning stage, but the thought is to use the diary method only for richer households who live in gated societies on a pilot basis before the 2027-28 consumption expenditure survey begins," said an official aware of the deliberations.

"It is an open secret that participation of richer households living in societies and RWAs in our surveys is reducing. The diary method is used in other countries, so maybe we can give it a try too," the official said.

The overall urban non-response rate during the 2022-23 HCES jumped to 9.8%, from 2.8% in the 75th round of the National Sample Survey, conducted from July 2017 to June 2018. In rural areas, the non-response rate increased to 4.1% from 1.5% during the same period. For the most affluent urban and rural respondents, the non-response rate was 11% and 3.9%, respectively. In the 2011-12 survey, the corresponding figures were 3.3% and 1.3%.

'Recall error' problem

While a diary-based system is "always better", the problem for MoSPI will be how two data sets compiled through different methods will be "stitched together", said Pronab Sen, India's first chief statistician.

Data collected through surveys suffer from what is called a "recall error" — people can make errors in remembering their expenditure details. The diary method minimises this problem as households can write down the information as and when they make the purchase.

With lower literacy rates in the low-income group, only higher-income households may be able to correctly follow the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Vadodara court convicts 5 for teen's rape in 2024

Aditi Raja
Vadodara, August 20

A SPECIAL POCSO Court in Vadodara on Thursday convicted five men in connection with the gangrape of a 16-year-old girl during Navratri festivities on October 4, 2024.

The court will hear arguments for the quantum of sentence on August 25.

District Government Pleader Anil Desai told *The Indian Express* that a special team of prosecutors — comprising Nayan Sukhadwala from Surat and senior advocate Shailesh Patel from Vadodara, had successfully proven the police case.

"The scientific evidence gathered by the police with the help of forensic experts... played a crucial factor in securing the conviction. Right from the chargesheet to end of trial, the case had been water tight," Desai said. Police had filed a 6,000-page chargesheet within a fortnight of the incident.

"The district police and the Crime Branch gathered vital clues. We were able to present 315 documentary and material pieces of evidence, which clinched the fate of accused," he said.

Sukhadwala said circumstantial evidence had been a vital link to establish the sequence of events.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

UGC equity rules

"discrimination" covers unfair or differential treatment on the ground of caste against any stakeholder.

The issue has also acquired a political dimension in Bihar and Uttar Pradesh. The rules initially triggered protests among sections of the upper castes who argued that the explicit reference to SCs, STs and OBCs amounted to exclusion of general category students.

Although the Supreme Court stayed the regulations days after the notification and revived the 2012 framework, there is concern within the BJP that the issue may lead to disquiet among Dalit communities, particularly in UP where Assembly elections are due next year. Some among the Dalits are also opposed to bringing the OBCs under the protective umbrella.

Within the BJP, one reason for the party's defeat in the recent Bankipur Assembly bypoll in Bihar was attributed to upper caste dissatisfaction over the UGC issue.

Staying the regulations on January 29, a bench led by the CJI said the issue raised important questions that, if left unexamined, could have "very sweeping consequences" and "divide society".

The bench, which issued notices to the Centre and the UGC, also directed that the "2012 Regulations will continue in force till further orders".

It said that "upon a prima facie consideration, it appears to us that some of the provisions of the Impugned Regulations suffer from certain ambiguities, and the possibility of their misuse cannot be ruled out".

Petitioners Mritunjay Tiwari, advocate Vineet Jindal and Rahul Dewan have primarily challenged section 3(1)(c) of the regulations.

The regulations stem from a 2019 petition filed in the Supreme Court by the mothers of Payal Tadvi and Rohith Vemula, who died by suicide over alleged caste-based discrimination in 2019 and 2016, respectively. They had sought the enforcement of robust anti-discrimination mechanisms across higher education institutions.

Staying the notified regulations on January 29, the court put forward a set of questions:

- Whether Clause 3 (1) (c) "bears a reasonable and rational nexus to subserve the object and purpose of the 2026 UGC Regulations, particularly in light of the fact that no distinct or special procedural mechanism has been prescribed to address caste-based discrimination, as opposed to the exhaustive and inclusive definition of "Discrimination" provided under Clause 3(e)".
- Would the introduction of the term "caste-based discrimination... have any bearing on the existing constitutional and statutory sub-classification of the Most Backward Castes within the Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and Other Backward Classes, and whether the (new rules) provide adequate and effective protection and safeguards to such Extremely Backward Castes against discrimination and structural disadvantage".
- Whether the inclusion of the expression "segregation... in the context of allocation of hostels, classrooms, mentorship groups, or similar academic or residential arrangements, albeit on transparent and non-discriminatory criteria, would amount to a "separate yet equal" classification, thereby infringing the constitutional guarantees of equality and fraternity under Articles 14, 15 as well as the Preamble to the Constitution".
- Whether the omission of the term "Ragging" as a specific form of discrimination constitutes "a regressive and exclusionary legislative omission? If so, whether such omission is violative of unequal treatment of victims of discrimination by creating an asymmetry in access to justice and thus falls foul of Articles 14 and 21 of the Constitution".

-WITH LALMANI VERMA

Spending data

diary method. This segregation of methods creates a problem: data collected from the former group through door-to-door surveys would have higher recall errors than diary-based data supplied by the latter group.

This problem is not insignificant as India's survey samples are dominated by the low-income group.

So, while the diary approach is "not a bad idea", Sen warned that "you can't wish away the recall error" which separates the two different sets of data.

Saying that the ministry is looking into the matter, a source said: "This is something we are thinking about —how the data compiled by the diary method can be integrated with the main survey".

The HCES gives a measure of how much people spend on various goods and services, tracking the change in consumption patterns across different levels of consumers in rural and urban areas. It is key to understanding not just household consumption behaviour, but also standards of living, well-being and inequality.

The share of expenditure on different items is also used to update the Consumer Price Index (CPI) basket, which forms the basis of one of the most important economic indicators, the headline retail inflation.

It is this measure of change in prices that the Reserve Bank of India looks at while deciding on interest rates. The central bank's CPI inflation target is 4% in a band of 2-6%.

In the past, the HCES was conducted every five years. However, after an overhaul of the methods, two back-to-back surveys were conducted in 2022-23 and 2023-24. Going forward, the ministry intends to conduct the HCES every three years or so.

MoSPI vs RWAs

Concerned by the falling participation of high-income households in its surveys, MoSPI held a "brainstorming session" with representatives from more than 75 organisations and housing societies from across the country in September 2024, hoping to find solutions to the issues it faced — from survey staff not being allowed to enter gated societies, to the lack of awareness on why these surveys are important for policy purposes, often leading to refusal to provide information.

With the government looking to make its policies increasingly data and evidence driven, a rise in non-response rates can lead to inappropriate conclusions being drawn and decisions not leading to desired results.

A rise in non-response rates can curtail the sample size of surveys. If these non-responses are from a certain segment, the final composition of the sample may be different from what was intended, leading to incorrect estimates from the exercise.

On the other hand, RWAs voiced concern on the sensitive and private nature of some questions, and the apprehension that the details may be shared with other government departments. MoSPI has assured that data privacy is of paramount importance, and the data is anonymised.

They also cited the inability to remember details, and the discomfort in answering certain questions in front of family members — like expenditure on alcohol and cigarette consumption. RWAs cited security issues as a reason for not permitting survey staff inside gated societies.

MoSPI's field officers already follow an elaborate procedure to gain access to gated societies, including informing the district collector, local bodies, and the police station for necessary permission and support.

Sometimes, according to sources, residents just say that they don't want to participate in a survey. For instance, residents of an affluent society in Gurugram refused to take part in MoSPI's Time Use Survey. Similar incidents have also been reported from high-rises in Bengaluru, Kolkata, Udaipur, Mumbai and Bhopal, among others, over the years for various surveys, including the HCES, the government's flagship Periodic Labour Force Survey, the Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises, and the Urban Framework Survey.

While the survey work was finally completed in some cases, the ministry had to "substitute" the original residential society with a similar one in other cases, said sources.

Jharkhand HC

following principles of natural justice," noting that "till now, there is no material with the respondents to show as to which candidates are involved in corruption or else; inasmuch as, the Investigating Agency is already in action."

The court was hearing a petition challenging the government's blanket cancellation of these appointments on the ground that those impacted had not been given sufficient opportunity to be heard.

"The court has directed that all those whose appointments were cancelled be reinstated and paid their salaries. The state has also been asked to file a supplementary counter-affidavit explaining the basis on which the examination and appointments were cancelled. The court has also ordered that their dues be paid," advocate Arpan Ekka, who represented the petitioners in the high court, told The Indian Express.

The court directed the petitioners to file an undertaking stating that "the final order passed by the trial court in connected criminal case shall be binding on them and the Government would be free to take appropriate action in accordance with law."

The 11th, 12th and 13th Jharkhand Combined Civil Services Examination took place in the same year – 2024. Around 3.5 lakh candidates appeared, and 7,011 were shortlisted for the mains. As many as 864 candidates cleared the mains and were called for an interview. Eventually, 342 candidates joined their respective postings after appointment letters were distributed to them at an event held at Morabadi Ground in Ranchi on November 28, 2025.

Though data on the number of applicants for the FSO exam was not immediately available, 149 had reached the interview stage before 56 were selected.

Ashutosh Kumar, one of the petitioners and a serving deputy collector, said all 342 officers appointed through the 11th–13th Jharkhand Combined Civil Services Examination had challenged the decision. The state has been given until September 15 to file its counter-affidavit.

The Jharkhand government had cancelled 22 recruitment examinations via a notification on August 18. This came after a 26-day protest and hunger strike over alleged irregularities in government exams.

The protests began on July 25 in Ranchi, seeking government action over alleged irregularities in various examinations conducted by the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) and Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC).

As the agitation gathered steam and pressure mounted, Chief Minister Soren announced the cancellation, prompting the protesters to call off their agitation on Wednesday. However, his government found itself facing a fresh challenge: of tackling those who had cleared the exams and were either supposed to get government jobs or had already joined.

The petitions related to the 11th–13th Jharkhand Combined Civil Services Examination and the Food Safety Officer recruitment exams are among a series of legal challenges against the government's decision. The petitions challenge the government's power to cancel recruitments and appointments of those who have already joined government service through a blanket notification. The Senior Additional Advocate General representing the state was unavailable for comment.

Shah

into two parts. From there, the two-nation theory gained strength and eventually, the country was partitioned and Pakistan was born."

"In the 150th year of Vande Mataram's composition, the Narendra Modi government has corrected that historic mistake, and tried to strengthen national integration by singing the entire song, the immortal work of Bankim Babu. The decision to sing it in full in all government functions has been given legal form as well."

"Yesterday, the Congress decided to violate it. This decision by the Congress only confirms its extreme policy of appeasement. For vote bank appeasement, they have not only insulted the immortal work of the late Bankim Babu, but also millions of martyrs who went to the gallows for the country's independence while chanting Vande Mataram, and spent many years in jail," he said.

"Today, Congress is accepting its party resolution of 1937 and rejecting the Act of Parliament. I am quite astonished that under the leadership of Rahul Gandhi, Congress is once again vigorously promoting the politics of appeasement in this country. I want to appeal to the people of this country. Once this country made the mistake of letting Vande Mataram be divided into two parts, and we suffered grave consequences," he said.

"Now the people of the country should unite and raise their voices against this decision of the Congress, that politics of appeasement will no longer work in this country. This is a free country. Eighty years after independence, the people will not tolerate any opposition to what Narendra Modi government has corrected, regarding the decision Congress made in 1937. BJP strongly condemns this decision of Congress, and we will vigorously oppose it among the public and in legislative assemblies," Shah said.

BJP president Nitin Nabin accused the Congress of having formalised its "insult" of the national song "into a resolution".

Referring to the row over what BJP claimed was a bid by Congress leader Sonia Gandhi to stop the full rendition of Vande Mataram at Congress headquarters on Independence Day, Nabin said on X, "When, just a few days ago, this same insult had been exposed in the conduct of an individual, the Congress had dismissed it as a coincidence. Today, that very insult has become the Congress's policy. This insult to the sacred invocation of 'Bharat Mata' is contempt for those thousands of martyrs who sacrificed their lives for the nation, keeping this very song alive in their consciousness."

"This isn't merely a political defence but proof of the hunger for that vote bank before which Congress has repeatedly pawned nation's self-respect. Congress has now become new Muslim League of today," he said.

CWC

party is a junior ally in the JMM-led government. The Congress-led government in Kerala skipped the rendition of the national song altogether.

"It was a wide ball. The party could have left it rather than having a go at it," said a CWC member, while another member said, "There are more important issues that are playing out. The aspirations of students, chanda chori (allegations of donation theft at Ram Temple), the government seems to be on the backfoot. We should not have played to the BJP's strength."

Yet another CWC member said the Congress did not oppose the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026, in Parliament as the House was in turmoil at the time. The Lok Sabha cleared the Bill in about 15 minutes on July 30 amid protests from Congress and SP MPs. DMK was the only Opposition party to participate in the discussion.

"We did not oppose the Bill in Parliament because the House was then in turmoil and the Bill was passed in the din. But it is also a fact that we did not oppose the Bill outside Parliament, as we spoke against delimitation or the FCRA amendment Bill. Now, we are saying all this," said the Congress leader.

On Wednesday, CWC cited a 1937 CWC resolution to argue that the leading lights of the freedom movement, including Mahatma Gandhi and Rabindranath Tagore, had backed limiting public rendition of Vande Mataram to its first two stanzas.

Defending the decision, CWC member Kanhaiya Kumar told *The Indian Express*, "We had to take a clear-cut stand. Otherwise, there would have been confusion among the rank and file. We have to defend the legacy of the freedom movement as it is our legacy." Singhvi said there was a distinction between public and private functions and that the amended law was silent on rendition of Vande Mataram in a "particular way".

"The law talks about national official functions ... it does not say anything about private functions in your house, hotel, or institution. Moreover, the law is about obstructing the singing of the national song, preventing the singing or causing disturbance to any assembly engaged in such singing," said the Rajya Sabha MP.

"The Congress is talking about its internal party functions and not government functions. There is a deliberate attempt by the BJP to conflate patriotism into a six-stanza test and spread misinformation against the Congress. The Congress was the one which elevated Vande Mataram to the national song status and gave it a status equal to the national anthem," Singhvi said. Asked about Kerala skipping the rendition of Vande Mataram at the government's official I-Day function, he said, "Individual state governments can take their decisions."

BNS

vague and overbroad, and said it did not require the communication to have a tendency to cause an immediate threat to public safety or tranquility. It also did not distinguish between information sent to a large audience and a message sent to one person. Terms such as "grossly offensive", "annoying" and "inconvenient" could cover speech that neither affected a person's reputation nor amounted to an offence under penal law.

"Hence, the drafting will be done in a way that these shortcomings pointed out by the SC in the past will be taken into consideration," an official said.

Sources said the safeguards were considered important because attempts by other states to legislate on social-media content have drawn criticism and legal challenge on the ground that they resembled Section 66A and could meet the same fate.

In 2020, Kerala amended its Police Act through an ordinance to criminalise communication that was threatening, abusive, humiliating or defamatory, punishable with up to three years in prison, a fine of up to Rs 10,000, or both. It was withdrawn after opposition and petitions in court.

Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis announced the committee on the floor of the Assembly in May, replying to an issue raised by BJP MLA Rahul Kul. Fadnavis said there was a growing trend of people using social media platforms to defame others without evidence or proof.

The Government Resolution constituting the panel was issued on May 8, 2026. Headed by the state DGP, it includes secretaries from the Law and Judiciary, IT, and Women and Child Development departments, and the Additional Director General of Police, Maharashtra Cyber. Its mandate was to examine existing provisions and explore new legislation or amendments to deal with social-media defamation in the wake of the Section 66A verdict. It was given three months to report and was authorised to call in experts.

The Law and Judiciary Department will now give its opinion, after which the proposal goes to the state government. Even if the state legislature clears the amendment, it cannot come into force until the Centre examines it and the President gives assent.

Bandra

the HC Bench orally remarked to the BMC lawyer on the issue of converting its use to an expo centre.

The court directed the authorities to not take any further steps on the proposal until the next hearing on the challenge by Mumbai Football Association (MFA) scheduled on September 18.

The MFA challenged the civic improvements' committee's recommendation for conversion and alleged the decision would take away one of the city's key football venues.

The BMC stated that its general body has taken a decision only to publish a notice to invite suggestions and objections from stakeholders over the issue and the change of reservation will come into effect only after the state government passes an order in that regard.

After the MFA on Wednesday informed it about the August 18 decision clearing the proposal, the HC said it will deal with it on Thursday.

On Thursday, the court noted that it was "unfortunate" that the oral assurance made by the BMC lawyer on August 10 that there would be no further action on the recommendation of the improvements committee was not communicated to BMC Commissioner Ashwini Bhide by its law officers.

On August 10, the BMC lawyer had orally assured that no final decision would be taken until the complete procedure, including BMC's sanction, stakeholders' suggestions and objections, was followed, which would take some time.

"We have a bigger problem. We have an issue of the majesty of law being at stake. If the elected people or authorities are going to jeer at the courts, then that's something very bad. So, we are now going to do something suo motu (on its own), unless you turn back the clock to August 10," a bench of Acting Chief Justice Ravindra V Ghuge and Justice Gautam A Ankhad orally remarked on Thursday, adding that the statement was made on instructions of BMC's officer present in the court on August 10.

Senior advocate Zal Andhyarujina for MFA argued the "situation was slightly worse" as general body was not made aware about August 10 arrangement and when the question was raised, it was conveyed there was no stay from the HC and therefore the authorities decided to "go ahead" and pass resolution.

After the court sought to know if the BMC can keep the decision in abeyance till further hearing, Senior advocate Girish Godbole representing it told the bench that under the Municipal Act, it was not possible for the Commissioner to request the "supreme" general body to suspend or recall the resolution, passed based on the agenda of the meeting circulated last month.

Godbole, after having a discussion with the BMC Commissioner, told the bench she was not apprised of the August 10 hearing developments and the petitioner's communication was not brought to her notice by the law officer and therefore the general body passed a resolution on August 18.

The HC termed this to be "unfortunate" and issued notices to respondent authorities.

"Considering the above stated factors, we direct that the Corporation and other Respondents (State, MHADA) would refrain from initiating any further steps with regard to the August 18 general body resolution and the football ground at issue until further hearing and orders in this matter," it noted in the order.

Marathi proficiency

whether the driver has knowledge to carry out the business. He should be able to answer the questions of the passengers. It is not expected that the driver will have proficiency in the language," the officer said.

For some drivers, the first day exposed the difference between attending a Marathi class and being confident enough to use the language.

Taxi driver Arvind Mourya, who had attended the classes, was served a notice. "I have attended the classes, but I am not very confident to speak. I will take YouTube classes and speak the language. After one month they will check my proficiency in the language and I am sure I will be able to crack it," he said.

Another driver, Iqbal Ahmed, said his work schedule had prevented him from attending the classes. "We are all drivers and have a busy schedule due to which I was unable to attend the classes, but now that I have been served notice I will learn the language," he said.

The checks also led to a heated exchange with one taxi driver, who insisted that he knew Marathi but questioned why the exercise was being conducted. During the argument, he accused officials of bringing "politics" into the language issue and repeatedly questioned the need for the checks.

Officials and others at the spot attempted to calm him down as the exchange continued.

The Transport Department says the requirement is intended to ensure that taxi and autorickshaw drivers can understand passengers and communicate with them in Marathi.

The government had earlier undertaken a 105-day training and assessment programme, beginning May 1, across 59 RTOs, sub RTOs and language training centres. More than 4,500 teachers from the Konkan Marathi Sahitya Parishad and Mumbai Marathi Sahitya Sangh trained drivers in basic conversational Marathi.

The four-session training focused on everyday interactions with passengers, including destinations, fares, directions and routine questions.

In Mumbai, nearly 1.25 lakh drivers completed the programme, but 7,750 failed the assessment and have to reappear, while more than 14,000 had not completed the training.

Drivers served notices during the crackdown have been given one month to learn Marathi. After that, they will have to demonstrate that they have met the requirement. Failure can result in suspension of their badge for three months, while continued non-compliance can lead to suspension of their driving licence, officials said.

Transport Minister Pratap Sarnaik said the flying squads will continue checking the Marathi language proficiency of auto-rickshaw and taxi drivers across the state till September 30.

"Practical knowledge of Marathi is mandatory for auto and taxi drivers, and the rule will be strictly implemented from August 20. Our objective is not to take away anyone's livelihood, but to ensure that drivers can communicate with passengers in basic Marathi. Drivers who lack the required knowledge will first be given one month to learn the language. If they fail to comply, their badge will be suspended for up to three months. Continued refusal to learn Marathi can lead to cancellation of the badge and licence. New badges will also be issued only after RTO officials verify the driver's practical Marathi knowledge through direct interaction and video recording. The crackdown will continue till September 30," Sarnaik said.

Gangster shot dead in Hisar court complex as two men fire 14 rounds; one arrested

Express News Service
Chandigarh, August 20

GANGSTER VINOD Pannu alias Kana was shot dead by two men who opened indiscriminate fire in the Hisar district court complex on Thursday afternoon, police said. One person accompanying Kana sustained bullet injury in the incident that took place near the main gate of the court, they said.

The incident took place around 2.30 pm when Kana and his associates were leaving the complex after a court hearing. The assailants, who were lying in wait, fired 14 rounds in quick succession, before fleeing on a motorcycle. As gunshots echoed, lawyers and litigants ran for cover.

On getting information, police reached the spot and shifted the injured men to a government hospital, where doctors declared Kana dead. Doctors said the other injured person is out of danger.

Superintendent of Police Siddhant Jain told reporters that the one accused has been apprehended along with the weapon used in the crime. The police are investigating if the killing was the result of an inter-gang rivalry.

He said five to six teams have been constituted and an investigation is underway regarding the motives behind the incident, the sequence of events, and the roles of other individuals involved. The police are collecting evidence from the crime scene and further legal action is being taken in accordance with the law, said the SP.

Assistant SP Mayank Mudgil refused to reveal the identity of the arrested accused saying he is being interrogated.

A resident of Thurana village in Hansi district, Pannu had 31 criminal cases, including those of murder, registered against him. His activities spanned various regions, including Delhi-NCR, police said. His record included the murder of Sanjay alias Bittu Sharma, the nephew of Lalit Sharma, who serves as the personal assistant to Hisar MLA Savitri Jindal. Kana was arrested from Jhajjar in 2017. A reward of Rs 7 lakh was reportedly announced for Kana at the time of his arrest.

Following the incident, heavy police deployment was made at the spot and the area was cordoned off.

Hisar Bar Association president Pradeep Bajia termed the incident as a "total failure" of security. He said the court premises are supposed to have tight security and questioned how the attackers managed to enter and open fire.

CRPF forms core group to review self-harm cases after a spate of suicides

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, August 20

ALARMED BY the rise in suicides among its ranks, the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) has formed a high-level core group to conduct monthly reviews of such self-harm cases and strengthen institutional prevention measures.

This decision follows a meeting at the CRPF headquarters earlier this month, in which senior officers discussed the need for a structured mechanism to examine such incidents, identify recurring risk factors, and improve support systems.

Deaths by suicide among CRPF personnel touched a five-year high in 2025. As many as 59 such deaths were reported last year, according to official data. According to the data, 57 CRPF personnel died by suicide in 2021, 43 in 2022, 57 in 2023, 46 in 2024 and 59 in 2025. Nineteen such deaths were reported till May 30 this year.

The figures from 2021 to May 2026 also indicate that several of these deaths took place while the personnel were on duty.

Last week, the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) took note of this and sought reports from the Ministry of Home Affairs and the CRPF Director General.

According to an officer, the core group will be headed by CRPF Director General GP Singh.

POSED AS A TRANSGENDER

Man enters flat to 'bless' woman, rapes her: Police

Accused held from Kalwa in Thane & remanded in police custody until Monday

Manish Kumar Pathak
Mumbai, August 20

A MAN allegedly posing as a transgender and dressed in women's clothes entered a Powai woman's home on the pretext of performing a ritual to bless her with a child, allegedly raped her and fled after taking Rs 2,000, police said.

The accused, identified as Anil Shinde (30), was arrested from Kalwa later the same night. Police traced the autorickshaw he had boarded after leaving the building.

According to police, the woman lives in Powai with her husband and an elderly relative. The couple have been married for nearly five years and do not have children, police added.

On Wednesday afternoon, Shinde allegedly arrived at the flat dressed as a woman and claimed to be a transgender. The elderly relative opened the door.

Police said Shinde placed his hand on the elderly woman's head and pretended to bless her. During the interaction, she told him that a young woman in the family had been married for several years but had not conceived. Shinde allegedly offered to perform a ritual to bless her with a child.

He then entered the flat and spoke to the woman for a few minutes before asking her to lie down on the bed. According to police, under the guise of performing the ritual, he initially touched her head and then allegedly touched her inappropriately before raping her.

Police said before leaving, Shinde allegedly told her that she would soon be blessed with a child and demanded money. She gave him Rs 2,000, following which he left.

About an hour later, the woman realised what had happened and informed her husband, who was at work.

The couple approached Powai police station later in the evening, following which police registered a case of rape.

Investigators examined CCTV footage from the building and surrounding areas and spotted the accused boarding an autorickshaw.

Police traced the vehicle using its registration number and questioned the driver, who told them where he had dropped the passenger.

Police detained him later on Wednesday night. During questioning, police established that he was a man and not a transgender, as he had allegedly claimed.

Shinde was arrested and produced before a court on Thursday. He was remanded in police custody until Monday.

Police are investigating whether the accused had used a similar modus operandi in other cases, officials said.

Malvani Cave-In

A crane clears debris after a dilapidated house collapsed in the densely populated Malvani locality in Malad on Thursday. Some passersby were injured after debris fell on them. SANKHADEEP BANERJEE

IMMERSION OF PoP IDOLS DURING GANESHOTSAV

Up to 6-feet ones in artificial tanks, above that in natural bodies: HC

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 20

THE BOMBAY High Court on Thursday clarified that till it passes judgment on pleas against the use and immersion of Plaster of Paris (PoP) idols in natural water sources, the earlier order of July 24, 2025, that mandated PoP idols less than 6 feet in height to be immersed in artificial tanks across Maharashtra, will be in force.

This would pave the way for the immersion of larger idols in natural water bodies during the Ganeshotsav beginning from September 14, with due precautions to be taken under the state's policy, subject to the court's final verdict.

The clarification came nearly a week after a bench of Justices Ajey S Gadkari and Kamal R Khata, while closing the hearing on August 14, had noted that the June 9, 2025 order that lifted the ban on the manufacture and sale of PoP idols, but did not allow their immersion without the court's leave, would 'remain in force' as an interim arrangement.

However, as the August 14 written order was not made available until Wednesday night, the state government, through Advocate General Milind Sathe, approached the bench seeking clarification.

It sought that July 24, 2025 order was required to be kept in force till the verdict was passed, considering the upcoming Ganeshotsav next month.

The government said while it would not be possible to avoid use and immersions of PoP idols for this year's Ganeshotsav, but such idols would be gradually phased out over next few years.

The petitioners had claimed that while the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) had said guidelines banning the immersion of such idols in natural water bodies were 'advisory in nature', they were binding on the government.

Petitioners claimed despite directives, idols lesser than 6-feet height were being immersed across the state.

CHURCHGATE-BORIVALI LOCAL

62-yr-old dies after being pushed from moving local train

Third commuter death on Mumbai locals this year over altercations

Ishika Gupta & Manish Kumar Pathak
Mumbai, August 20

A 62-YEAR-OLD man died after he was allegedly pushed by another commuter from a moving Churchgate-Borivali local following a quarrel over seating in the Divyangjan coach, reserved for passengers with disabilities, on Thursday, making it the third death on Mumbai's suburban railway this year following passenger altercations.

The incident took place around 1.22 pm when the train was passing between Mahim and Bandra stations. According to the Railway Protection Force (RPF), an argument broke out between both passengers over seating, following which the accused allegedly pushed the victim from the moving train.

The victim, identified as Kejitan Pal Denis Piris, a resident of Santacruz East, suffered serious injuries in the fall. He was taken to Bhabha Hospital in Bandra West about an hour later, where he subsequently died, officials said.

The accused, identified as 48-year-old Amajad Safriddin Shaikh, was taken into custody by the Bandra railway police. The accused, who lived near Bahauddin dargah in Churchgate, had boarded the train at Lower Parel and was travelling towards Borivali. The victim boarded the train at Mahim and allegedly asked the accused to vacate the seat for him, leading to an argument. The accused allegedly pushed the victim, causing him to lose his balance and fall out of the compartment onto the railway tracks. He suffered severe head injuries, said senior inspector Shahji Nikam of Bandra GRP. The victim worked as a plumber.

The Government Railway Police (GRP) registered a case under Section 103(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, which deals with murder.

The death comes amid a series of violent incidents on Mumbai's suburban network in which ordinary commuter disputes have escalated into fatal attacks.

In June, 22-year-old Mayank Lohar was allegedly stabbed inside a first-class compartment of a Churchgate-Nallasopara local following an argument over keeping the train door open during heavy rain. It was the second stabbing on the suburban network this year.

Earlier, in February, 32-year-old lecturer Alok Singh was stabbed during an altercation while attempting to alight at Malad station.

Mumbai's suburban railway carries an estimated 7.5-8 million passengers daily, with trains routinely operating under severe crowding during peak hours. Transport and behavioural studies have linked overcrowding, restricted personal space and commuter stress to heightened frustration and conflict.

• TRAIN RAGE

JUNE: 22-year-old Mayank Lohar allegedly stabbed inside first-class compartment of Churchgate-Nallasopara local following argument over keeping train door open during heavy rain

FEB: 32-year-old lecturer Alok Singh stabbed during an altercation while attempting to alight at Malad station

Eleventh arrest in fake admission racket

Mumbai: Powai police have arrested a 21-year-old SIM card vendor from Andheri in connection with a fake admission racket in which 10 engineers were arrested earlier for allegedly cheating students and their parents across the country on the promise of securing engineering seats under management and NRI quotas. The latest accused, identified as Abu Ishtiyak Saif, 21, a resident of Versova, Andheri, is the 11th accused in the case. ENS

Maharashtra forms committee to preserve singer Mukesh's legacy

Mumbai: The state government has constituted the 'Late Singer Mukesh Gaurav Samiti' to commemorate the legacy of legendary singer Mukesh, with a focus on promoting his music and creating platforms.

The committee will seek to provide opportunities for emerging singers and artists through cultural programmes commemorating Mukesh's contribution to Indian music, ahead of August 27, which marks the 50th death anniversary of the iconic singer. ENS

Driver dies by suicide after jumping from parking level at CSMIA

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 20

A 53-YEAR-OLD man allegedly died by suicide after jumping from a parking level at Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport (CSMIA) on Thursday.

Police are suspecting that his prolonged health condition may have contributed to the extreme step.

The deceased was identified as Pramod Gangaram Jadhav, who had been working as a government driver for the past 25 years of the Bombay High Court.

He was staying in Worli village along with his wife and daughter.

According to police, Jadhav had been suffering from an infection in both kidneys for the past six months, and his condition was deteriorating. Jadhav left his home for work at around 8.30 am on Thursday and reached CSMIA at around 10 am.

Two vehicles were regularly stationed at the airport to pick up senior government officers (working in judiciary department) who arrive in the city for official work and he worked as the driver of one of them, said police.

At around 11.40 am, Jadhav allegedly went to the P10 level of the airport parking area and jumped over the railing towards the P4 East side.

He sustained severe injuries in his head and other parts of the body.

He was rushed to the hospital but declared dead, said officer.

The Sahar police registered an accidental death report in connection with the incident. Police are conducting inquiries to ascertain the circumstances leading to Jadhav's death.

INDIAN INSTITUTE OF SCIENCE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH PUNE
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RECRUITMENT FOR REGULAR NON-TEACHING POSITION

Institute invites **Online applications** from the eligible candidates for the regular position of **Assistant Executive Engineer (Electrical)** [Un-reserved, Pay Level-10]

For detailed advertisement visit **www.iiserpune.ac.in** and click on the link **"Opportunities" → "Non- teaching / Project"**. Last date of submission of online applications is **11/09/ 2026.**

Amendments, if any, shall be notified only on the Institute website.

Advt. No.: 69/2026 dated 20/08/2026 **Registrar**

WONDER HOME FINANCE
Zindagi Ki Perfect Shuruat

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WONDER Corp. Office: 620, 6th Floor, North Block, World Trade Park, Malviya Nagar, JLN Road, Jaipur- 302017, TEL: 0141 - 4750000

Demand Notice Under Section 13(2) of Securitisation Act of 2002

As the Loan Account Became NPA therefore the Authorised Officer (AO) Under section 13 (2) of Securitisation And Reconstruction of Financial Assets And Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 had issued 60 day demand notice to the borrower as given in the table. According to the Notice if the Borrower does not deposit the amount within 60 days, the amount will be recovered from Auction of the security as given below. As the demand Notice send to the borrower/guarantor has not been served, copy of demand notice has also been affixed on the secured assets as given below. Therefore you the borrower is informed to deposit the loan amount along with future interest and recovery expense within 60 days, otherwise under the provisins of section 13(4) and 14 of the said Act, the AO is free to take possession of the Security as given below.

Name of the Borrower/ Co-Borrower / Mortgagor / Guarantor / Loan A/c No.	Date and Amount c/ Demand Notice Under Sec. 13(2)	Description of Mortgaged Property
(Loan A/c No.) LN21067HE25-26035123 Smt. Pranita Mahesh Lande (Applicant), Sh. Mahesh Madhukar Lande (Co-Applicant& Mortgagor)	14-08-26 Rs. 23,60,363/- Rupees Twenty Three Lakh Sixty Thousand Three Hundred Sixty Three As On 10.08.2026	All That Part And Parcel Of The Property Of Sh. Mahesh Madhukar Lande Situated At Plot No.49 South Part, Gat No.90/2P, At Satara, Taluka & Distt. Aurangabad, Maharashtra- 431102 Admeasuring About 1000.00 Sq. Feet

Date: 20.08.2026
Place: AURANGABAD, Maharashtra
Authorised Officer
Wonder Home Finance Ltd.

PUBLISHED IN THE GAZETTE OF INDIA,
EXTRAORDINARY PART-II
SECTION 3, SUB SECTION (ii)
GOVERNMENT OF INDIA
MINISTRY OF ROAD TRANSPORT AND HIGHWAYS

NOTIFICATION

New Delhi, the 7th August, 2026

S.O. 4408(E).— In exercise of powers conferred by sub-section (1) of section 3A of the National Highways Act, 1956 (48 of 1956) (hereinafter referred to as the said Act), the Central Government, after being satisfied that for the public purpose, the land, the brief description of which is given in the Schedule below, is required for building (widening/four laning etc.) maintenance, management and operation of Mumbai Vadodara Expressway spur NH NE-4, in the stretch of land from Km. 45.400 to Km. 58.820 (Maharashtra Section), in District, Thane in the state of Maharashtra, hereby declares its intention to acquire such land.

Any person interested in the said land may, within twenty-one days from the date of publication of this notification in the Official Gazette, object to the use of such land for the aforesaid purpose under sub-section (1) of section 3C of the said Act.

Every such objection shall be made to the Competent Authority, namely, the Sub Divisional Officer, Kalyan in writing and shall set out the grounds thereof and the Competent Authority shall give the objector an opportunity of being heard, either in person or by a legal practitioner, and may, after hearing all such objections and after making such further enquiry, if any, as the Competent Authority thinks necessary, by order, either allow or disallow the objections.

Any order made by the Competent Authority under sub-section (2) of section 3C of the said Act shall be final.

The land plans and other details of the land to be acquired under their notification are available and can be inspected by the interested person at the aforesaid office of the Competent Authority.

The dates of hearing are schedule village wise as details in below table.

Place: Competent Authority & Sub Divisional Officer, Mohan Pride Cultural Welfare Centre, 2nd Floor, Near Poddar International School, Khadakpada, Kalyan (W)-421301.

Sr. No.	Village Name	Taluka	Date	Time
1.	Balyani	Kalyan	15/09/2026	03.00 PM

The land maps and details of the land is respect of the lands include in the above notification are available in office of competent Authority.

Date: 14/08/2026
Place: Kalyan
Competent Authority & Sub Divisional Officer, Kalyan Division, Kalyan, District Thane

SCHEDULE

Brief Description of the land to be acquired with or without structure falling within in the stretch of land from Km. 45.400 to Km. 58.820 (Maharashtra Section) Mumbai Vadodara Expressway spur NH NE-4, in the state of Maharashtra.

[F. No. NHAI/PIU/Surat (Expressway)/3A1]
SHAIKH AMINKHAN, Director

District: Thane
https://egazette.gov.in/(Search by Gazette Id: CG-DL-E-08082026-275311)
Publication Date : 07/08/2026

CWC
Logistics Driving Progress

केन्द्रीय भंडारण निगम
(एक नवरत्न सीपीएसई)
CENTRAL WAREHOUSING CORPORATION
(A NAVRATNA CPSE)

No. CWC/B&C/AGM/2026 Dated: 24th August, 2026

NOTICE

64th Annual General Meeting of the Central Warehousing Corporation will be held at 11.00 hours on 25.09.2026 at the Main Auditorium of NCUI Auditorium & Convention Centre, 3, August Kranti Marg, Siri Institutional Area, Block A, Nipccd Campus, Hauz Khas, New Delhi- 110016. Detailed notice in this regard is sent to all shareholders to their registered address by speed post. Participants have to send duly filled Proxy form (having hologram) (Original-1)/copy of Resolution through post/courier to the office of Secretary, Central Warehousing Corporation, 4/1, Siri Institutional Area, August Kranti Marg, Hauz Khas, New Delhi on or before 17.00 hours on 20.09.2026. Proxy-1 & Resolutions issued prior to the date of notice i.e. 24.08.2026 and received after 20.09.2026 will not be accepted.
For detailed information please log on to www.cewacor.nic.in

Secretary, CWC

NAVY CHILDREN SCHOOL
Naval Station Karanja, Uran, Navi Mumbai
A CBSE- affiliated school under the aegis of the Navy Education Society
CBSE Affiliation No. 1180029
Website: www.ncskaranja.nesnavy.in • Mobile: 8169321519
Email: prin.ncs.kaj@gmail.com

WALK-IN-INTERVIEW FOR THE ADHOC VACANCY AT NCS KARANJA FOR THE ACADEMIC YEAR (2026-27)

NCS Karanja invites applications from eligible candidate for engagement on adhoc basis for the following teaching, non-core subject teaching and non-teaching post:

Sr. No.	Vacancy	Age	Qualification & Eligibility Criteria
	Teaching	21-50 years as on 01 July 2026	For detailed information, please visit the school website. www.ncskaranja.nesnavy.in or Contact on 8169321519
1	PGT (Mathematics)		
2	Lab Assistant		
	Non core subject teacher & Non teaching staff / Administrative staff		
3	Dance Teacher		
4	Yoga Teacher		
5	Art & Craft		
6	Watchman		

Application Process:- Candidates may download the prescribed application form from the school website. The duly filled-in application form, along with all required supporting documents, must be forwarded by email to **recruitmentncskaranja@gmail.com** and also submitted in hard copy along with supporting documents through Registered Post / Speed Post. The application must reach Navy Children School Karanja on or before **27 August 2026.** Incomplete applications or applications received after the due date will be summarily rejected and will not be considered. Candidates are advised to ensure that they fulfil all the prescribed eligibility criteria before submitting their applications.

For further details, please visit: www.ncskaranja.nesnavy.in
Contact No.: 8169321519

OIL AND NATURAL GAS CORPORATION LIMITED
CIN: L74899DL1993GOI054155
Registered Office: Plot No. 5A-5B, Nelson Mandela Marg, Vasant Kunj, New Delhi-110070, Website : www.ongcindia.com, E-mail: secretariat@ongc.co.in Tel : 011-26754073/4085
ONGC

NOTICE OF LOSS OF SHARE CERTIFICATE

NOTICE is hereby given that the equity Share Certificate(s) of the following shareholder have been reported as lost/ misplaced which are already transferred to IEPF Authority:

Name of Share Holder (S/ Shri)	Folio No.	No. of shares	Share Certificate Number	Distinctive Nos.
Mohan Singh	23675	1836 1836 3672	1185 476346	247737-249572 4277992797-4277994632

The request has been lodged by Kapoori Devi (the legal heir) for claiming these shares from IEPF Authority. Any person(s) who has/ have any claim in respect of the said certificate(s) can lodge such claim with the supporting documents with the Company within 7 days of the publication of this notice, after which no claim will be entertained by the Company. Further, public is hereby warned against purchasing or dealing in any way with the above-mentioned share certificate(s). Any person dealing with the above share certificate(s) shall be doing so, solely at his/ her risk as to costs and consequences, the Company shall in no way be held responsible for such dealing(s).

New Delhi
20.08.2026
For Oil and Natural Gas Corporation Ltd
(Shashi Bhushan Singh)
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer

कार्यालय प्राचार्य, पं. रामसुमेर शुक्ल राजकीय मेडिकल कॉलेज, रुद्रपुर (ऊ.सिंह नगर)
E-Mail : principalgmcrudrapur@gmail.com कार्यालय दूरभाष : 05944-299245
Web : www.gmcrudrapur.com Ins. gmcrudrapur

पत्रांक संख्या : जी.एम.सी./08/ विज्ञापन / 2610 दिनांक 20 अगस्त 2026

WALK-IN-INTERVIEW

A **"Walk-in Interview"** for various faculty positions of **Pt. Ram Sumer Shukla Smriti Government Medical College, Rudrapur** (Udham Singh Nagar) is scheduled on dated **25 Aug 2026 (Tuesday) from 10.30A.M** onwards in the **"Office of the Principal" Government Medical College, Rudrapur (US Nagar).** The appointments will be made on contractual basis for three years (Extendable on yearly basis) or till regular appointments are made, whichever is earlier. The details of vacancy position in various departments are being uploaded in the website **www.gmcrudrapur.com** and **www.medicaleducation.uk.gov.in.**

Principal,
(Government Medical College, Rudrapur)

ANJUMAN-I-ISLAM'S
AKBAR PEERBHOY COLLEGE OF EDUCATION, VASHI
Plot No. 15, Sector 10/A, Vashi, Navi Mumbai - 400 703.

MINORITY INSTITUTION

APPLICATIONS ARE INVITED FOR THE FOLLOWING POSTS FROM THE ACADEMIC YEAR 2026-27
UN-AIDED

Sr. No.	Cadre	Subjects	Total No. of Posts	Category
01	ASSISTANT PROFESSOR	Education / Perspective and Pedagogy Fine Arts / Health and Physical Education	06	06 OPEN

The above posts are open to all, however candidates from any category can apply for the post.
Candidates having knowledge of Marathi will be preferred.
"Qualification, Pay Scales and other requirement are prescribed by the UGC Notification dated 18th July, 2018, Government of Maharashtra Resolution No. Misc-2018/C.R.56/18/UNI-1, dated 08th March, 2019 and University Circular No. TAAS/(CT)/ICD/2018-19/1241, dated 26th March, 2019 & revised from time to time."
The Government resolution and circular are available on the website mu.ac.in
Applicants who are already employed must send their application through proper channel. Applicants are required to account for breaks, if any in their academic career.
Application with full details should reach the **HON. GENERAL SECRETARY, ANJUMAN-I-ISLAM, AKBAR PEERBHOY COLLEGE OF EDUCATION, PLOT NO. 15, SECTOR 10/ A, VASHI, NAVI MUMBAI – 400 703,Or by email - principal@akbarpeerbhoyvashi.org** within 15 days from the date of publication of this advertisement. **This is University approved advertisement.**

Sd/-
HON. PRESIDENT

NEVILLE D'SOUZA FOOTBALL GROUND ROW

BMC changed reservations of 17 city plots in four years, civic records show

Pratip Acharya
Mumbai, August 20

EVEN AS the BMC faces scrutiny over the proposed change in reservation of Neville D'Souza ground, civic records show that the reservation of 17 land parcels across Mumbai has been altered in the last four years, including plots earmarked for gardens, recreation spaces, the Byculla zoo, a portion of the Mahalaxmi Racecourse and salt pan land.

Significantly, 14 of these changes were made between 2023 and 2025, when the BMC had no elected general body and civic administration was being run by appointed officials after municipal elections were deferred in 2022.

The details, provided by the civic administration to Congress leader and senior corporator Ashraf Azmi after he sought the information, show that eight of the 17 plots were originally reserved for gardens, recreation areas or natural open spaces. Other plots were reserved for public amenities such as schools, hospitals, municipal offices, transport depots and asphalt plants.

The DP framework also allows reservations to be modified when required. However, Azmi alleged that the frequency and nature of the changes raised questions, particularly as several plots are located in commercially valuable parts of the city.

"The civic data clearly shows that these decisions were taken in an arbitrary manner. If the administration wants to change the reservation of these plots so frequently, then what is the point of having a DP module?" Azmi told The Indian Express.

"Mumbai is a space-starved city and citizens need more open spaces for their well-being. Instead of creating space for citizens, the administration is giving these land parcels away," he said. Azmi said he had first sought the details from the civic administration in April.

Among the prominent changes is a portion of the Mahalaxmi Racecourse, whose reservation was changed to a commercial zone in October 2024. A plot in Byculla reserved for the extension of the Veer mata Jijabai Bhosale Botanical Udyan and Zoo was changed to a residential zone in February 2024.

A salt pan parcel in Mazgaon was changed in April 2026 for a VVPAT storage facility and government office. In Dahisar, a recreational plot was changed in January 2026 to make way for a community hall. In Nahur, land earlier reserved as a recreation ground was changed to an aviary or bird park in April 2025.

Azmi questioned the changes involving the Racecourse and zoo land.

"The government has been saying that the Racecourse ground will be opened to the public as an accessible open space and no development will be allowed there. But the reservation says otherwise. Similarly, land reserved for expanding the zoo is being reserved for housing projects. With whose permission were these done and who does the administration want to benefit?" he asked.

A senior official from the BMC's Development Plan department, however, said a change in reservation did not automatically mean that the land would be handed over to a private party.

"Reservation of land parcels are altered from time to time to ensure the city's overall land bank is equally distributed. If required, the reservation of any land parcel could also be altered in the long run," the official said.

14 of these changes were made between 2023 and 2025, when BMC had no elected general body

BMC's plan to change the reservation of Neville D'Souza ground is facing scrutiny. FILE

• OVER 4 YEARS

17 Land reservations changed

8 Originally reserved for gardens, recreation and open spaces

Schools, hospitals, municipal offices, transport depots and asphalt plants: Other reservations

CHANGES

Mahalaxmi Racecourse: Commercial zone, October 2024

Byculla zoo extension land: Residential zone, February 2024

Mazgaon salt pan: VVPAT storage facility and government office, April 2026

Nahur recreation ground: Aviary/bird park, April 2025

Aaditya announces protest to 'save open spaces' on Aug 23

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 20

SHIV SENA (UBT) MLA Aaditya Thackeray Thursday announced a joint "Save Open Spaces" protest in Mumbai Sunday, alleging that the BJP-led government and the BMC are handing over valuable public land to politically connected organisations and private interests.

The announcement came after BMC cleared a proposal to change reservation of Neville D'Souza football ground in Bandra Reclamation to a convention centre.

The protest will be held at 5 pm at the football ground and will bring together Opposition parties, resident groups and citizen forums. Thackeray urged Mumbaikars to join the campaign carrying the national flag.

Thackeray made the announcement after visiting the Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Sports Complex in Andheri West, which the BMC is reportedly considering allotting to Shri Vile Parle Kelavani Mandal (SVKM), led by BJP MLC Amrish Patel.

He alleged that public plots were being transferred or monetised at rates below their potential value, and accused Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis of facilitating such deals for political allies. Thackeray flagged Mumbai's bus depots and other vacant plots, alleging attempts to change their use. He said his party had approached the court over the issue.

On the Andheri sports complex, Thackeray claimed the plot, developed for public recreation with sports facilities, walking and cycling tracks and an urban forest, was once valued at over Rs 500 crore but was now proposed to be allotted for Rs 21 lakh a year, along with two MHADA plots. He also alleged that Neville D'Souza ground and a sports plot in Mulund faced changes in use.

Calling the developments a "land grab scam", Thackeray said opposition parties, residents and citizen groups would unite to protect Mumbai's remaining open spaces.

Sena UBT's Aaditya Thackeray addresses media at Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Sports Complex. SANKHADEEP BANERJEE

• BRIEFLY

FESTIVE SEASON NEARS: An artist gives finishing touches to a Ganesh idol at a workshop in Belapur, on Thursday. NARENDRA VASKAR

Man booked for driving on wrong side flees in police car, rams vehicles

A MAN booked for allegedly driving on the wrong side of the road in South Mumbai reportedly fled from the spot in a Mumbai police vehicle and rammed several vehicles while escaping. The incident occurred after the man was intercepted for allegedly driving recklessly on the wrong side of the road while travelling from Tardeo towards South Mumbai. The Gamdevi police have registered an FIR against him. The incident took a dramatic turn when the accused allegedly fled from the spot in a Mumbai police vehicle but rammed several vehicles while escaping. Police said the circumstances surrounding how the accused gained access to the police vehicle and his subsequent escape were being investigated. Repeated calls to South Zone (traffic) DCP Hemraj Rajput went unanswered.

Committee on use of AI smart goggles

THE MAHARASHTRA government Thursday formed a one-member committee under the Additional Director General Maharashtra Cyber to prepare a Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) for use of smart glasses. The GR issued by the state Home department mentioned that due to the use of Artificial Intelligence (AI)-based smart goggles, smart glasses, and other wearable devices, threats to national security, state security, and citizens' privacy have arisen through photos, videos, live streaming, and data collection.

Free school bags for Class 1 to 8 children

AFTER TEXTBOOKS and uniforms, the Maharashtra government will now provide free school bags to students studying in Classes 1 to 8 in government-run schools across the state. The school education department has approved an expenditure of Rs 174.19 crore for the initiative. According to the GR issued in this regard the initiative is part of its broader effort to provide educational materials to students in order to improve enrolments, attendance and access to quality education in local body schools.

Proposing to reach settlement with Raut: Rane

BJP MP Narayan Rane Thursday told a special court that he was proposing to reach a settlement with Rajya Sabha MP Shiv Sena (UBT) Sanjay Raut in connection with a defamation case. Raut has filed a criminal defamation against the former Union minister for allegedly making false remarks against him in 2023. Raut's lawyer said that he is yet to receive a proposal. **ENS**

GHATKOPAR DEATH

Mother-in-law planned murder before woman returned in June: Police

Mohamed Thaver
Mumbai, August 20

THE MOTHER-IN-LAW of Sapna Ghanji had allegedly planned to murder her when she learnt that her daughter-in-law was returning from Dubai in June and her husband was not accompanying her, police probing the murder of the 35-year-old Ghatkopar woman said.

Sapna was allegedly murdered at her Ghatkopar residence on Sunday at the behest of her mother-in-law Dhanlaxmi Ghanji (65), who allegedly paid Rs 3 lakh to a former maid and her family to carry out the crime. Five persons have been arrested.

According to police, the accused decided to act on Sunday after the domestic help working at Sapna's residence found her under the influence of alcohol and alerted the others.

Pant Nagar senior police inspector Lata Sutar said Dhanlaxmi was allegedly upset over Sapna's earlier domestic violence complaint against her in-laws and was also angered by her drinking habits and suspected her of having an extra-marital affair.

"Hence when she learnt that her son and Sapna's husband Pramod was not accompanying her from Dubai, she had begun thinking of getting rid of her and got her former domestic help involved in the crime," Sutar said.

Police are also investigating whether Dhanlaxmi had arranged for her former domestic maid, Mangala Jadhav, to work at Sapna's residence in the same building to facilitate the murder.

Police said Mangala, who came to work on Sunday, found Sapna intoxicated and allegedly informed the others. Dhanlaxmi and Mangala's husband, daughter and son then allegedly entered Sapna's house and murdered her, police said.

Sapna, whose family is from Nalasopara, married Pramod in 2013 and had a son. She had registered a domestic violence case against her in-laws at Nalasopara police station in 2024 following a dispute. Her husband and in-laws later apologised and she returned to live with them in Ghatkopar.

Earlier this year, Sapna travelled to Dubai with her husband and son. She returned to India with her son in June, while Pramod stayed back in Dubai for work.

'Respond in Marathi': Day 1 of Crackdown

DEEPAK JOSHI

TRANSPORT DEPARTMENT'S mandate that taxi and autorickshaw drivers demonstrate a working knowledge of Marathi was enforced from Thursday

FLYING SQUADS were deployed across Mumbai and the Mumbai Metropolitan Region

ON THE first day of crackdown, RTO officials stopped drivers and asked them to respond in Marathi to everyday requests about destinations, fares, travel time, UPI payments and routes

DEEPAK JOSHI

AKASH PATIL

BMC death data throws up major mismatch in dengue & malaria figures

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 20

A SHARP discrepancy has emerged in BMC's recording of malaria and dengue deaths, with civic death records showing substantially higher numbers than those reported through its disease surveillance system, according to data obtained under the Right to Information (RTI) Act.

The RTI response, obtained by activist Chetan Kothari, shows that 93 malaria deaths and 201 dengue deaths were recorded in 2024 in a BMC table based on International Classification of Diseases (ICD) coding. However, the civic body's disease-wise figures for the same year show only seven malaria and five dengue deaths.

The gap is visible in earlier years as well. Malaria deaths in the disease-wise data stood at one each in 2021 and 2022 and two in 2023, against corresponding death-record figures that were substantially higher. Dengue deaths were five, seven and 14 respectively in the disease-wise data for these three years.

The discrepancy continues in provisional 2025 data. The BMC's table, based on coding of available death forms, records 196 malaria and 169 dengue deaths. The civic body has cautioned that the 2025 figures are provisional.

"We are still analysing the data for communicable disease. The discrepancy is being examined as part of a revision of the data, with cross-checking underway to identify errors. The figures therefore need to be viewed with this caveat," said BMC Executive Health Officer Dr Daksha Shah.

The data also highlights the growing burden of non-communicable diseases. Cancer accounted for 10,004 deaths in the provisional 2025 figures, followed by heart attack at 9,453. In 2024, heart attack was the leading cause among the listed categories, with 16,805 deaths, while cancer accounted for 9,978.

Tuberculosis deaths rose from 3,031 in 2024 to 3,472 in 2025, an increase of 14.5 per cent. Brain stroke deaths increased from 1,726 to 2,173, a rise of nearly 26 per cent.

Shah said the BMC was strengthening cancer care and screening for diabetes and hypertension. It has also introduced yoga centres and dietitian services for lifestyle management.

On tuberculosis, Shah said newer treatment approaches had helped increase the BMC's reported cure rate from around 40 per cent to 80 per cent over the past seven to eight years.

• 2024 FIGURES

MALARIA DEATHS	DENGUE DEATHS
93	201

(BMC table based on International Classification of Diseases (ICD) coding)

MALARIA	DENGUE
7	5

(BMC's disease-wise figures)

BMC to set up 3 plants to treat construction, demolition waste

Nayonika Bose
Mumbai, August 20

TO FILL the civic lacunae in treating Mumbai's mounting construction and demolition (C&D) waste, the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) is eyeing to establish three new C&D waste treatment plants across the city to augment its treatment capacity by 2,000 tonnes per day. The civic authority on Thursday floated an Expression of Interest (EoI) inviting agencies to design, finance, construct as well as operate C&D debris treatment plants with capacity to treat at least 600 metric tonnes of waste daily.

According to civic authorities, a treatment facility will be developed in eastern and western suburbs as well as the island city division each.

Mumbai generates over 8,000 tonnes of C&D waste every day. Construction and demolition (C&D) waste is used to refer to the concrete, dust, building material, debris and rubble generated from construction, repair and demolition of any structure.

Despite the massive quantity of C&D waste generated, the BMC has the capacity to treat only 1,200 tonnes of C&D waste everyday of which 600 tonnes of waste is treated at its Dahisar treatment facility, while the remaining 600 tonnes is treated at another civic-run facility at Shilphata.

In the absence of a robust treatment mechanism, developers and contractors across the city typically dump the waste into open spaces, drains as well as protected lands including mangrove zones.

The BMC on Thursday invited EoI from agencies to develop three new C&D treatment plants to treat a cumulative of 2,000 tonnes of waste every day.

Speaking to The Indian Express, Ashwini Bhide - Mumbai's municipal commissioner - said, "We need facilities wherein such waste can be segregated and re-use them," adding that the civic body has also developed a portal where developers will be mandated to enlist the total C&D waste generated on their site and also how it will be discarded.

The BMC's latest plan comes as a part of the implementation of the Construction and Demolition Waste Management Rules, 2025, effective from April 1, 2026. "The proposed plants will be integrated with the Mumbai Debris Control and Tracking System (MDCTS), which will digitally connect waste generators, transporters, VTMS/GPS-enabled vehicles, authorised facilities, weighbridges and final disposal/recycling receipts," said Kiran Dighavkar, Deputy Municipal Commissioner on Thursday.

At present, the civic body is also working to develop a new C&D debris processing plant at the Deonar dumpsite which is proposed to have a capacity to recycle 1,000 metric tonnes of waste daily.

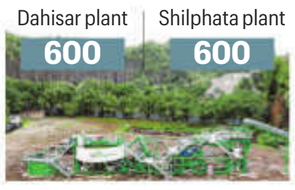
• WASTE TREATMENT

8,000 tonnes
Total C&D waste generated in Mumbai daily

1,000 metric tonnes
Daily capacity of proposed plant in Deonar

Current daily capacity to treat (tonnes)

Dahisar plant	Shilphata plant
600	600



IN THE PIPELINE

- New plants in eastern, western suburbs and island city
- Capacity from 600 tonnes to 2,000 tonnes per day
- Agency to be roped in to design, finance, construct, develop and operate the plants
- Debris will be recycled into M-Sand, road sub-base material, paver blocks, kerb stones and other BIS-compliant construction material

ADVERTORIAL

YEIDA FUTURE IS HERE | 25 YEIDA

YEIDA

Building Viksit Bharat@2047 through SAPTA DHARA - the 7 streams of development

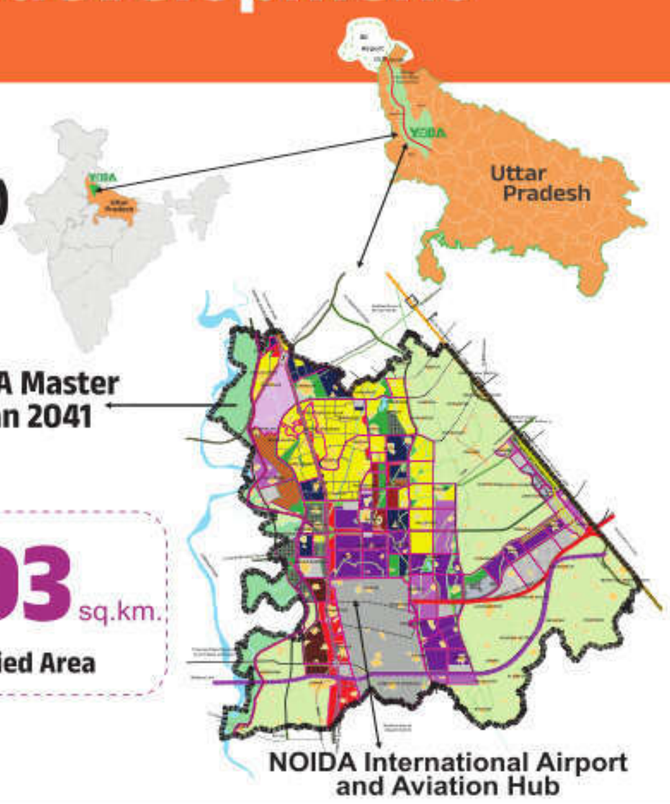
Sapta Dhara is a seven-pillar vision of the Prime Minister of India for building a Viksit Bharat by 2047.

It emphasizes manufacturing, agriculture, technology, connectivity, defence self-reliance, green growth, and cultural influence.

The initiative aims to make India a global hub for innovation and production.

YEIDA is working on a comprehensive roadmap for a prosperous and developed India by 2047.

Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority (YEIDA)



6 Districts — **3,352** sq.km. YEIDA Notified Area

2 Phases — **759** sq.km. Phase-1 Notified Area | **2,593** sq.km. Phase-2 Notified Area

Twenty-five years ago, the Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority (YEIDA) began with a vision of planned development along one of Uttar Pradesh's most important emerging corridors. Today, that vision is taking shape as a powerful ecosystem where industry, infrastructure, mobility, technology, commerce and urban development converge.

Strategically located between the National Capital Region and the major industrial and commercial centres of western Uttar Pradesh, YEIDA has emerged as one of the country's most promising growth destinations. Its location provides access to Noida, Greater Noida, Delhi-NCR, Agra and the wider northern Indian market, while its expanding network of expressways, rail links and aviation infrastructure is creating a compelling proposition for investors and enterprises.

The transformation is already reflected in the numbers. Between 1 April 2017 and 28 February 2026, YEIDA allotted 2,282 industrial plots covering 2,730.85 acres, attracting investments of Rs 50,546.68 crore and generating an estimated 3,91,212 employment opportunities. These are not merely numbers of investment; they represent the emergence of a new industrial and employment landscape.

1. Gati Shakti and Connectivity

Expanding Seamless, High - speed multi-modal infrastructure

Noida International Airport

India's New Global Gateway situated at the Doorsteps of YEIDA

Spread over 11,742 acres, the airport became operational for commercial passenger services on 15 June 2026, making it NCR's second major airport. Phase 1 has an annual passenger-handling capacity of 12 million, with the larger airport designed for substantial future expansion. IndiGo already connects 16+ destinations (Amritsar, Bengaluru, Bareilly, Bhopal, Chandigarh, Dehradun, Dharamshala, Hyderabad, Jaipur, Jammu, Jodhpur, Kishangarh (Ajmer), Lucknow, Pantnagar, Navi Mumbai, Srinagar) from here.

AVIATION HUB

The airport has earmarked 40 acres for a dedicated Maintenance, Repair and Overhaul (MRO) facility, supporting its emergence as a major aviation services hub.

A Corridor Designed for Seamless Connectivity

Connectivity is at the heart of YEIDA's growth story.

The 165.5 km, six-lane Yamuna Expressway (expandable to eight lanes) provides the principal north-south spine linking Greater Noida with Agra. The region is further strengthened by the Eastern Peripheral Expressway, connecting the corridor with Palwal, Manesar, Ghaziabad, Baghpat, and Meerut. A dedicated road link connects the airport with the Delhi-Mumbai Expressway, while the planned Palwal-Khurja Expressway will further expand regional connectivity. A 130 metre-wide road links Greater Noida with the YEIDA region, with a network of wide internal roads providing additional access to industrial and urban sectors. The multimodal network goes beyond roads: the Eastern Dedicated Freight Corridor, with connectivity through New Chola and planned airport-DFC linkages, will facilitate efficient movement of industrial cargo. The region is also set to benefit from the Orbital Rail, the proposed RRTS-cum-Metro, and the planned high-speed rail corridor between Delhi and Varanasi, with a station at Noida International Airport. YEIDA has also proposed metro connectivity linking the region with Greater Noida, Noida, and Delhi.

Logistics Park: The proposed 364-acre park at Tappal-Bajna Urban Centre is being planned as a strategic logistics hub to meet growing cargo requirements, particularly for Noida International Airport. Designed to leverage air, rail, and road connectivity, it will support industrial growth and serve an extended regional catchment across Uttar Pradesh, Haryana, Rajasthan, and Delhi.

FROM MANUFACTURING TO MARKETS - FASTER

Turning connectivity into commerce

The airport's dedicated cargo infrastructure gives YEIDA a decisive edge for high-value, time-sensitive and export-oriented industry.

Operated by AISATS, the cargo facility opens with an initial handling capacity of 200,000 metric tonnes a year — scalable to 1.5 million tonnes. Digital cargo systems, warehousing and logistics infrastructure are built to serve e-commerce, freight forwarders and time-sensitive supply chains across electronics, medical devices, apparel and handicrafts.

MANUFACTURE HERE → MOVE FASTER → REACH MARKETS FURTHER

Combined with expressway connectivity and the wider NCR market, YEIDA's cargo capability compresses the distance between the factory floor and the global customer.

2. MANUFACTURING POWER

Building Complete value chains from design to production to make India a trusted global supply chain hub. YEIDA's industrial strategy is built around specialised clusters rather than a one-size-fits-all industrial model

Apparel Park: The 175 acre Apparel Park is being developed as a dedicated production-and-export ecosystem, with provision for around 100 units and a Common Facility Centre offering testing, design, training, R&D and marketing support.

MSME Park: The 288 acre MSME Park is designed to support a diverse base of small and medium enterprises.

Handicraft Park: The 123 acre Handicraft Park provides a dedicated ecosystem for handicrafts and related manufacturing.

Toy Park: The 100-acre Toy Park in Sector 33 has provision for a Common Facility Centre, green spaces, transportation and commercial facilities, with plots ranging from 1,000 to 10,500 sq. metres.

Japanese, Singapore, Taiwan and Korean City

YEIDA's international orientation is reflected in the 500-acre Japanese City in Sector 5A and the 500-acre Korean City in Sector 4A and Singapore City in Sector-7, and 300-acre in Taiwan City in Sector-6, located approximately 4 km and 5 km respectively from Noida International Airport, creating dedicated spaces for global businesses, investment, and international collaboration.

Medical Devices Park:

The 350-acre park is a specialised hub for indigenous medical-device manufacturing, targeting cancer-care and radiotherapy equipment, radiology and imaging, anaesthetics, cardio-respiratory devices, renal-care equipment, and implantable electronic devices. 124 plots allotted in Phase 1 to companies making products from orthopaedic implants and X-ray machines to ventilators, oxygen concentrators, and anaesthesia equipment.

3. TECHNOLOGY & INNOVATION

Focusing on Advanced Technology

SEMICONDUCTORS: BUILDING THE TECHNOLOGY BACKBONE

The Semiconductor Park with a 1000 acre land bank across Sector 28 & 10 is designed for the manufacturing & fabrication of semiconductors and semiconductor devices supported by high capacity power, water and sewage infrastructure. Existing investments and allotments involve India Chip Private Limited (JV of Foxconn and HCL Group), to set up an Outsourced Semiconductor Assembly and Test (OSAT) facility at Sector-28, YEIDA. The advanced OSAT facility is expected to be operational by 2028.

ELECTRONICS MANUFACTURING CLUSTER PARK (EMC)

Building the Technology Backbone ELECTRONICS MANUFACTURING CLUSTER (EMC) PARK Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority is developing ELECTRONICS MANUFACTURING CLUSTER (EMC) PARK in Sector-10 YEIDA that provides integrated infrastructure for electronics manufacturers-rather than functioning as a standard industrial estate. It includes industrial plots, flatted factories, common facility centres, internal roads, utility services, skill development centres, employee accommodation, and commercial spaces, so manufacturers can set up operations quickly while sharing infrastructure and supply-chain connectivity. The total area of the EMC Park is 206.40 acre. The big allotments in EMC Park are M/s Havells India Ltd. (Anchor Unit), M/s Polynomous Industries Pvt. Ltd. & M/s Ascent K Circuit Pvt. Ltd.

DATA CENTRE PARK

The Data Centre Park in Sector 28 adds another dimension to the digital economy. A 50 acre park, with two plots totalling 10 acres already allotted, is strategically located close to the aviation hub.

SOFTWARE/IT PARK:

The Software/IT Park, spread over 60 acres, is planned with 19 plots and dedicated infrastructure, including high-capacity power, water supply and a 60-MLD STP.

Its proximity to the aviation hub is intended to support technology-driven businesses and services.

4. AGRICULTURE AND FOOD PARK

Moving Beyond Basic Crop Production Toward Advanced Food Processing And Farm Modernization

430 acre of land reserved in sector 24 for agriculture food park, food processing unit and Herbal products unit.

A modern mandi for marketing of agriculture produce coming up in sector 36

5. GREEN ECONOMY

Promoting renewable energy

YEIDA is operating 3 hydrogen buses under green hydrogen based mobility project.

YEIDA is operating 25 electric buses to be expanded to 100 within short period.

YEIDA Under green economy has allotted 200 acre to SAEL Solar Pvt. Ltd., in sector-8 Integrated Batteries India Pvt. Ltd., CESC Green power Ltd. and other for production of solar panel and solar module.

6. SOFT POWER

Leveraging India's cultural footprint

Heritage and Tourism

YEIDA is developing heritage city of Phase-1, approx 753-acre. The Project is envisaged as a destination of national and international importance, anchored around the life, philosophy, heritage and cultural traditions associated with Lord Shri Krishna and the Braj region, while simultaneously addressing infrastructure requirements related to tourism, public congregation, mobility, healthcare, hospitality and allied institutional uses within the Vrindavan–Mathura influence zone.

International Film City

The proposed 230-acre International Film City in Sector 21, located just 4 km from Noida International Airport, is being developed as an integrated media and entertainment ecosystem covering pre-production, production, post-production, and film tourism.

AVGC-XR (Animation, Visual Effects, Gaming, Comics, and Extended Reality)

The Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority (YEIDA) is initiating work on a plan to develop an AVGC-XR (Animation, Visual Effects, Gaming, Comics and Extended Reality) Park near the Noida International Airport (Jewar) and the International Film City. The AVGC-XR Park is proposed to have the following potential activities: Animation Studios, Visual Effects (VFX) Studios, Game Development and Game Design Centres, Motion Capture Studios, Virtual Production Facilities, Artificial Intelligence (AI)-based Content Creation Centres, Extended Reality (XR), Virtual Reality (VR) and Augmented Reality (AR) Labs, Digital Media and Immersive Content Development Centres. The YEIDA AVGC-XR Park will play a significant role in establishing India as a global hub in the fields of animation, VFX, gaming, comics and XR technologies.

7. RAKSHA SHAKTI

YEIDA has approved a 100 - acre land for manufacture of advance defense equipments such as drones, RADARS, smart sensors and other logistical tools that will also include research & development, engineering, production & servicing of military material and facilities.

16+ DESTINATIONS & GROWING — IndiGo has progressively connected Noida International Airport to major regional and metro hubs since commercial operations began.

1.5M MT CARGO CAPACITY, SCALED UP — Dedicated air-cargo facility operated by AISATS - starting at 200,000 MT annually, built to scale for e-commerce and export-led industry.

2 EXPRESSWAYS TO THE NCR — Yamuna Expressway and Eastern Peripheral Expressway link the region to Delhi, Agra, Meerut and the wider northern market.

FROM CONNECTIVITY TO CAPABILITY.
FROM CAPABILITY TO OPPORTUNITY.

YEIDA is building more than an industrial corridor. It is creating an integrated economic ecosystem where people can arrive, businesses can invest, industries can manufacture, cargo can move and products can reach markets faster the foundations of a globally competitive investment destination.

Viksit Bharat @2047 | YEIDA — Shaping Progress. Creating Opportunities | www.yamunaexpresswayauthority.com

Mumbai CP says that he is on the chair through merit

Apoorva Agashe
Mumbai, August 18

SENIOR JOURNALIST and author Prabhakar Pawar has chronicled the history and evolution of Mumbai's police commissioners in his latest book, The History of Police Commissioners. The book was recently launched in the presence of Mumbai Police Commissioner Deven Bharti, bringing together insights into the city's policing legacy and the officers who have shaped its law-and-order machinery over the years. The book was launched by Rajya Sabha MP and Shiv Sena UBT leader Sanjay Raut, CP Deven Bharti and former Mumbai CP MN Singh.

The books focuses around the CP's who have served in Mumbai's jurisdiction beginning from the Britishers era to the present.

During the launch former CP MN Singh said that officers had to make tough decisions , " I was the CP we were behind the underworld, our job was to maintain the law and order situation of the city. We had to make tough decisions. I had stressed Balasaheb Thackeray during my tenure but he never held a grudge against me and had called me to have it before I retired. Now that I am retired I can say that the government must not interfere in the postings of police officials and it should be on merit." Singh, the former CP said.

During the launch of the book 'The History of Police Commissioners'. AKASH PATIL

CP Deven Bharti said that he is there on merit. "I have been in the force since 2002, I have learnt a lot of things from my seniors. Pawar has a unique style of analyzing the situation and writing about the daily happenings. We often forget the contributions of hawaldars who have a good network due to which we are able to maintain law and order. A good leader is good because of the team and from my experience I can say that I am here on merit."

R&R colonies in crumbling homes and financial woes

Sabah Virani
Mumbai, August 20

THE ONES who gave up their lives and livelihoods 20 years ago to make way for important infrastructure projects, now live in crumbling homes, trapped in a state of financial scarcity and administrative paralysis. They are project affected people.

"Although we were shifted into 18 buildings in 2005, almost every home has cracks and leaks," said Chandrashekar Devendra from the Charishma Colony in Chembur. "Promises of water connections, proper roads, grills in our homes, sewerage lines, none have materialized."

These were the stories of the residents of Mumbai's first R&R colonies that emerged on Thursday at a launch of a report by the non profit YUVA on the aftermath of the exercise of rehousing. The policy was introduced in the late 90s under the Slum Rehabilitation Scheme, as the city prepared for the churn of lakhs of people it would need to displace.

"When the built structures and basic infrastructure is of poor quality, what happens when it starts crumbling midway through its stated lifespan? Who shoulders the responsibility of its upkeep?" asked Marina Joseph from YUVA.

The nonprofit surveyed 38 cooperative housing societies, encompassing 53 buildings, in Chembur in late 2025. These buildings are approximately 20 years old, built largely by the SRA (although some were approved by the MMRDA), and then transferred to the BMC or MMRDA to shift those affected by their projects.

At the launch of a report by the non profit YUVA on the aftermath of the exercise of rehousing. AKASH PATIL

The report recommended to define a timeline for the repairs and redevelopment, and declare the public layouts within the preview of the BMC

The report said, "The audited financial statements of three societies showed that the maintenance charge arrears had been increasing year-on-year, indicating the inability of several tenants/owners to pay these monthly amounts."

To make it worse, several homes in the buildings are vacant and not allotted to people, leaving them neglected, open to misuse, and giving no maintenance charges.

"The layouts spoken about here are among the city's first R&R colonies, after which things have improved a lot," said Vishram Patil, former head of the Social Development Cell of the MMRDA till 2020.

Among the many recommendations of the report, are to increase defect liability periods onto the builders for the buildings, define a timeline for the repairs and their redevelopment, and declare the public layouts within the preview of the BMC.

HC: 'Valuable public lands can't be thrown out clandestinely for forced redevelopment'

Omkar Gokhale
Mumbai, August 20

THE BOMBAY High Court questioned how municipal land that washermen have traditionally used for nearly 170 years at Mahalaxmi's historic Dhobighat could be brought into a slum rehabilitation project without first protecting their legally recognised rights or ensuring their rehabilitation.

Calling the situation "peculiar" and "alarming", a bench of Justices Girish S Kulkarni and Neela K Gokhale said it was a matter of "serious concern" whether the land could be used for redevelopment when the rights of the washermen had been "substantially crystallised".

"Valuable public lands cannot be just thrown out" of the public pool in a "clandestine manner" for "forced redevelopment", the court observed.

The court was hearing pleas filed by Nagendra Kanojiya and others, represented by advocate Amogh Singh. The petitioners said washermen had been using the land since 1851 as part of the Dhobighat heritage precinct and that 720 rassiholders had been recognised by the BMC.

According to the petitioners, 7,724.61 sq m of municipal land used as a non-slum drying area was being included in an SRA project for residents of Sai Baba Nagar Cooperative Housing Society. The project is being undertaken by Resonant Realtors Projects Pvt Ltd, formerly Omkar Realtors.

The petitioners alleged they were being ousted without rehabilitation benefits and would instead be offered mechanised drying machines after completion of the project. They also claimed the FSI generated from the non-slum land was being used for the SRA scheme.

Questioning the move, the bench asked how the washermen's rights could be "extinguished in such a manner", particularly when the land was located in a "very prime area" adjoining the Mahalaxmi Race Course.

The matter will be heard next on September 1.

The Brihanmumbai Electric Supply & Transport Undertaking
(OF THE BRIHANMUMBAI MAHANAGARPALIKA)

TENDER NOTICE

E-tender is invited for the supply of following item.

(1) Tender for Supply of 250 kVA & 500 kVA Truck Mounted Diesel Generator Sets along with accessories and Comprehensive Annual Maintenance Contract (AMC) for Five (05) Years.

Note: For more details, log on to website **https://mahatenders.gov.in**

PRO/AAM(M)/57/2026 GENERAL MANAGER

KAMARAJAR PORT LIMITED
(A Company of Chennai Port Authority)
No.17, Rajaji Salai, Chennai - 600 001
CIN: U45203TN1999PLC043322

NOTICE INVITING GLOBAL e-TENDER
TENDER No: KPL/PPD/CT-2/PPP/2026

Kamarajar Port invites online tender in a single stage, two-cover system (RFQ cum RFP) from reputed firms for "Development of Second Container Terminal at Kamarajar Port Limited under PPP Mode on Design, Build, Finance, Operate and Transfer (DBFOT) Basis" for a Concession period of **40 (forty) years** at an estimated value of **4288.26 Crore.**

The bid documents can be downloaded from Central Public Procurement (CPP) portal (www.eprocure.gov.in) from **20.08.2026.**

General Manager (CS&BD)

Uttar Gujarat Vij Company Limited
CIN – U40102GJ2003SGC042906
Regd. & Corporate Office, Visnagar Road, Mehsana, Gujarat -384001
Toll free number 19121 OR 1800233155335 www.ugvcl.com

Tender Notice
Invitation of Tender Notice No.
UGVCL/TECH-PROJECT/26-27/ROBUST-GWFCM/HT-UG/FT/14 to 18

Uttar Gujarat Vij Company Limited (UGVCL) invites bid for Site survey, designing, engineering, procurement, supply, loading, transportation, unloading, insurance, delivery at site, handling, storage, installation, testing, commissioning including documentation of all items/material required to complete works for turnkey based contract for conversion of existing 11 KV HT Line Network in to Under Ground Cable Network with ring main system at various locations of Patan City-1 Subdivision of Patan Divison, Patan City-2 Subdivision of Mehsana Circle, Palanpur Head Quarter of Banaskantha District of Palapur Circle, Modasa Head Quarter of Arvalli District of Himmatnagar Circle, Himmatnagar Head Quarter of Sabarkantha District of Himmatnagar Circle under UGVCL with GIS Mapping / Geo Urja Mapping (Developed by GUVNL) and Asset Tagging under ROBUSTGWFCM respectively through **online tendering** on **www.ugvcl.com** & **https://tender.nprocure.com**. Interested Vendors are requested to locate the same from above mentioned websites. Note: Be in touch with our website till opening of tender.

Chief Engineer (Op)
R&C Office Mehsana

MAHATRANSCO
2nd Call RFx (E-TENDER) NOTICE

MSETCL invites online bids from reputed and registered contractors of appropriate class with MSETCL. Please visit Mahatransco website **https://srmetender.mahatransco.in** for following work.

RFx (Tender) No.	Name of work	Estimated cost in Rs.	EMD (Rs.)	Tender fee incl. GST(Rs.)
7000041000	2nd Call for Procurement of Various Types of Spare (relays) of Converter Transformer (298.6 MVA) at HVDC Terminal Station, Chandrapur and Padghe under Nagpur and Vashi Zone.	INR 4,11,30,413/- (including taxes)	INR 4,11,304.13/-	INR 5900/-

1	Date of download of RFx (e tender) documents	From - 21.08.2026 from 00.00 hrs. to 01.09.2026 up to 10.00 hrs.
2	Date of submission of RFx (e tender)	01.09.2026 up to 10.00 hrs.
3	Date of technical bid opening	01.09.2026 at 11.00 hrs. (If possible)
4	Date of commercial bid opening	01.09.2026 at 13.00 hrs. (If possible)

Contact Person: The Executive Engineer (ADM),
HVDC RS (O&M) Circle, Padghe, Mob. No: 9011021483
For further details visit our website:
https://srmetender.mahatransco.in

Sd/-
Superintending Engineer
HVDC RS O&M Circle, Padghe

Rajasthan Skill and Livelihoods Development Corp.
Kaushal Bhawan, J-8-B, Jhalana Institutional Area, Jaipur-302004

Notice Inviting RFP for Selection of Service provider for providing services of the Migration Support Centre to Rajasthan Skill and Livelihoods Development Corporation (RSLDC) under DDU-GKY

Rajasthan Skill and Livelihoods Development Corporation (RSLDC) invites proposals from eligible organizations agencies against RFP for Selection of Service provider for providing services of the Migration Support Centre under Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Grameen Kaushalya Yojana (DDUGKY). The last date for submission of online proposal is 07-Sept.-2026 till 18:00 Hrs on **https://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in/ nicgep/app** and submit original hard copy of Bid security Demand Draft to RSLDC office by 08-Sept.-2026 till 12:00 Hrs. For further details of RFP and Process visit and RSLDC website- **https://livelihoods.rajasthan.gov.in/rsldc/#/home/dptHome, https://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in/nicgep/app and https://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in/sppp/index.php.**

Raj.Samwad/C/26/10366 Managing Director, RSLDC

KONKAN RAILWAY CORPORATION LIMITED
(A Government of India Undertaking)

NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER

Konkan Railway Corporation Ltd., invites **Open Tender in Single Packet System** through E-Tendering on IREPS portal from eligible contractors for the following work. **Name of Work**: Renovation and upgradation of Executive club at Konkan Rail Vihar, Seawoods (West), Nerul, Navi Mumbai [Composite work (All Civil + Electrical + Signal and Telecom)]. **Tender Notice No.: KR/W/09/2026/06**. **Advertised Cost of the work**: Rs.1,59,66,960/- (exclusive of GST). **Closing Date/Time**: 11.09.2026 up to 15:00 hrs for submission of online Offers/Bids. **Completion Period**: 3 (Three) Months from the date of issue of LOA. Manual offers shall not be accepted. Please visit **www.ireps.gov.in** website for details/participation. Corrigendum/addendum will be hosted in this website only.

MAHATMA PHULE RENEWABLE ENERGY & INFRASTRUCTURE TECHNOLOGY LIMITED
MAHAPREIT (Subsidiary of MPBCDC, a Government of Maharashtra undertaking)

TENDER NOTICE

MAHAPREIT invites Request for Proposals (RFP) for the Selection of Project Management Unit (PMU) cum Transaction Advisor for Solarization under Captive /Group Captive Model of All India Institute of Medical Science, Nagpur, Maharashtra. The RFP documents can be viewed and downloaded from the official websites **https://mahapreit.in** and **https://www.mahatenders.gov.in/ The last date for submission of bids is 08/09/2026.**

Chief General Manager (SEP)
MAHAPREIT, Mumbai

CENTRAL UNIVERSITY OF RAJASTHAN

Advt. No. CURAJ/R/F.178/Rectt./2026/6631 Date : 20.08.2026

Online applications are invited for the following **02 Non-Teaching** positions:

Executive Engineer (Direct Recruitment)
Training & Placement Officer (Contractual Basis)

Applications are invited till **21 September, 2026 (11:59 PM)**

For more information visit: **www.curaj.ac.in**

Registrar

KONKAN RAILWAY CORPORATION LIMITED
(A Government of India Undertaking)

E- AUCTION NOTIFICATION

Konkan Railway Corporation Ltd Announces E- Auction of Commercial Contracts, published on IREPS e- tendering system as per the following schedule.

Sr. No.	Name of Contract	No. of Contracts / Lots	Date and Time of E-auction
1	Display of Advertisements inside train - Madgaon - Mangaluru Central - Madgaon (10107 / 10108) Memu train and Diva – Sawantwadi Road passenger (10105 / 10106)	02	27.08.2026 at 11:00 hrs
2	Display of Advertisements exterior train – Diva – Sawantwadi Road passenger (10105 / 10106), Diva – Ratnagiri passenger (50104 / 50103), Konkan Kanya Exp (20112 - 20111), Mandovi Express (10104 - 10103)	03	28.08.2026 at 11:00 hrs
3	Advertisements through Hoardings near Road Under Bridge / Road Over Bridge - Maharashtra	07	29.08.2026 at 11:00 hrs
4	Advertisement at Railway stations through Advertisement Boards, Hoardings at stations at Ratnagiri, Sawantwadi Road, Madgaon, Thivim, Karmali, Karwar, Mulki, Udupi & Video Wall at Thivim.	09	01.09.2026 at 11:00 hrs
5	Advertisement at Railway stations through Advertisement Boards on Foot Over Bridge's at Thivim & Karmali, Video Screen in Station Premises at Karmali & Advertisement on Compound boundary wall at Madgaon	04	02.09.2026 at 11:00 hrs
6	Installation of Digi Lockers at stations Chiplun, Kankavli, Kudal, Karmali, Gokarna Road, Honnavar, Bhatkal and Surathkal	08	28.08.2026 at 11:00 hrs
7	Installation of Fare Repeater at stations at Mangaon, Kolad, Adavali, Vilavade, Udupi, Thivim, Madgaon, Honnavar, Ankola	09	31.08.2026 at 11:00 hrs
8	Leasing of SLR – Train No. 11004, 20112, 10104, 10215, 22907, 56615- II	06	02.09.2026 at 11:00 hrs
9	Pay Parking at Kudal & Gokarna Road	02	31.08.2026 at 11:00 hrs
10	Pradhan Mantri Bhartiya Jan Aushadi Kendra (PMBJK) at Madgaon	01	31.08.2026 at 11:00 hrs
11	Parcel Scanner at Madgaon	01	31.08.2026 at 11:00 hrs
12	Pay and Use Toilet facility at Mangaon, Chiplun, Kundapura, Mookambika Road Byndoor, Thivim, Thivim-2, Karwar, Karmali	08	03.09.2026 at 11:00 hrs
13	Bike Packing Contract at Ratnagiri & Udupi	02	01.09.2026 at 11:00 hrs
14	Operation and Management of AC Lounge at Gokarna Road	01	01.09.2026 at 11:00 hrs

For queries please contact : 1. Shri. Pravin Daware, Mob. No.: 9004470597. 2. Shri. Vinay Gaonkar, Mob. No.: 9004476129. 3. Shri. Madhukumar Shetty, Mob.No.: 9004476082. For more details, please visit the website at **www.ireps.gov.in**

KONKAN RAILWAY CORPORATION LIMITED
(A Government of India Undertaking)

NOTICE INVITING OPEN-E-TENDER

The Konkan Railway Corporation Limited has invited open tender through **www.ireps.gov.in** system.

Sr. No.: 1. Name of Work: Manual CTR Work on Main Line Points & Crossings between Loliem – Harwada with 60 Kg Turnouts and Weldable CMS Crossings under the jurisdiction of Divisional Engineer, Madgaon in Karwar Region over Konkan Railway in Karnataka State (Computer No: 69729). **Tender No: KR/KW/OL/W/2026/25-CB-RT-1**. **Cost of the work in akhs (Excluding GST)**: Rs.77.90 lakhs (excluding GST). **Closing Date & Time**: 10.09.2026 at 15:00 Hrs.

Sr. No.: 2. Name of Work: Deweeding in Madgaon and Verna yard - AMC contract for 2 years under SSE/P.way/Madgaon Section (Computer No.73176). **Tender No: KR-KW-OL-W-2026-23-RB-RT2**. **Cost of the work in lakhs (Excluding GST)**: Rs.27.72 lakhs (excluding GST). **Closing Date & Time**: 04.09.2026 at 15:00 Hrs.

For further details, contact Office of Sr.Divisional Engineer, Konkan Railway Corporation Ltd.Karwar, Karnataka. For more details (**https://www.ireps.gov.in**)

NAVI MUMBAI INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT

NOTICE INVITING EXPRESSION OF INTEREST FOR CONSTRUCTION OF PROPOSED GA HANGAR – NO 3 AT NAVI MUMBAI INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT

Navi Mumbai International Airport Limited ("NMIAL") has been granted the right to develop, operate and maintain the Navi Mumbai International Airport ("NMIA") on DBFOT basis. NMIAL proposes to undertake the construction of the proposed general aviation (GA) Hangar's.

The scope of works includes, but not limited to, the engineering, supply, fabrication, erection & installation, integration, interfacing, testing, commissioning, obtaining all requisite statutory approvals / licenses, warranty support, rectification of defects, obligations during Warranty Period/ defect rectification period, of the proposed GA Hangar's at NMIA.

NMIAL invites responses to the Expression of Interest ("EOI") from qualified, experienced and reputed contractors for above mentioned Works for NMIA.

Interested applicants may download and submit their response to the EOI by registering on the NMIAL e-portal: https://nmiairport.abcprocure.com

For further details and instructions, please visit the E-tenders section: www.nmiairport.co.in

The deadline for submission of the response to EOI is 27th August 2026, 17:00 hrs IST.

Note: NMIAL reserves the right to reject any response to EOI or change / cancel the tender process at any time without prior notice or without assigning any reason whatsoever.

NAVI MUMBAI INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT LTD.
Email: nmial.tenders@adani.com
Website: www.nmiairport.co.in

CHITTARANJAN LOCOMOTIVE WORKS
CORRIGENDUM

No. GMA/GS/1521(CMP)(4)-Pt.III, Dated: 19.08.2026. The date of interview for engagement of CMP (specialists) at CLW as notified vide Notification no. GMA/GS/1521 (CMP) (4) Pt.III dtd. 31.07.2026 **is rescheduled on 27.08.2026** instead of 25.08.2026. Other contents stipulated in the notification dated 31.07.2026 remain unchanged.

Sr. Personnel Officer/Gaz for CPO/CLW/CRJ.
PR2/466
"Like us on: www.facebook.com/clwrailways"

WESTERN RAILWAY- VADODARA DIVISION

CONSTRUCTION OF TRACK MACHINE SIDINGS & TMC REST HOUSE

Sealed Tenders for and on behalf of the President of India are invited by Divisional Railway Manager (W A/C), Western Railway, Pratapnagar, Vadodara-390 004 for the following works. **Sr. No. 1: Tender No. DRM BRC 073 of 2026-27. Name of Work:** Vadodara Division :- Construction of Track Machine Sidings at Chavaj, TKWL, Gothaj and other Stations as per Requirement, Construction of TMC Rest House at Vasad Jn., Chhotaudaipur and Ektanagar, and Improvement of Allied Facilities at Existing Track Machine Sidings over Vadodara Division (Re-invited) (R-1). **Approximate Cost of the work (in ₹):** 12,89,83,300.09 **Bid Security to be deposited (in ₹):** 25,79,700.00, **Date and time for submission of tender and opening of tender:** Tender is to be submitted on **10-09-2026** before 15:00 Hrs. and is to be opened on same date at 15:30 Hrs. **Website particulars and notice for location where complete details can be seen & Address of the office from where the tender form can be purchased:** Website @ **www.ireps.gov.in** Divisional Railway Manager (W A/C), Western Railway, Pratapnagar, Vadodara-4. BRC-208

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SOUTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
Follow us on @SCRailwayindia
Details of the Tender Notices of S.C. Railway can be seen on our website: www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in

TENDER NOTICE No. : 04-GS-SC-II-26-OT, Dated : 31-07-2026. PUB/577

On behalf of the President of India, **Dy. CE/GS/HYB, South Central Railway, Secunderabad** invites Open Tenders for the following works through **e-procurement** up to **15:00 hours of 16-09-2026.**

Tender No. : 04-GS-SC-II-26-OT. **Name of the work : Hyderabad division : Gati Shakti :** Malkajgiri Yard Re-Modeling - Earth work, bridge work and other miscellaneous works.

Advertised Value : Rs.11,17,70,750.67. **Earnest Money Deposit :** Rs.22,35,400.00.

For further details visit the website **www.ireps.gov.in**

Dy. Chief Engineer / Gati Shakti / Hyderabad.
A671

For further tender conditions / details and for downloading the tender documents, Please visit website at https://www.ireps.gov.in or www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in

The Indian EXPRESS **Classifieds**
FROM ANYTHING TO EVERYTHING.

RECRUITMENT

SITUATION VACANT

OTHERS

Applications are invited for the JRF position in an ANRF-funded project at the Department of ECE, Faculty of Technology, University of Delhi. Visit the University website under Work with DU - Advertisement - Department. Email your CV and supporting documents to drsamantaray@fot.du.ac.in by August 23, 2026.
0050295801-1

PART TIME JOB

STAY Buzy work with flexi time, only work with Govt. Register Company. Age above 45 to 75. 9321362047.
0071051214-3

Required Retired/ VRS Seniors Age 40+ to work with Govt Registered Company. Wonderful Package, Promotions , Foreign Conventions + Many. Call# 9324802959.
0071032563-6

BUSINESS

POULTRY

AMIR Broiler, Small: Rs. 138/-, Big: Rs. 122/- Contact.: Phone: +91-8828895000/ 8080432388/ 022-25251901/ 022-23860517.
0071022495-1

VENCOBB ExFarm Price (Pune Yesterday) : Rs. 87/- kg (Live) Suggested Retail Price : Rs. 159/- kg (Dressed, without Skin).
0071023620-1

ZORABIAN Today's Ex-Farm Live Broiler Rate Rs. 92/- Retail Market Rate Rs. 124/- Mobile : 8879050887/ 9372663242 Office : 022-26604937/ 38/ 39.
0071025907-1

Mumbai Eggs Association Today Suggestive Farm-gate eggs price for today 21/08/2026 Rs. 555/- per 100 Eggs : 9820057700 / 9820351822/ 7303390009.
0071050099-1

S.K. Patel Small: 138/-, Big: 120/-. 8082040343/ 24460095/ 24459098. To subscribe to paper rate & purchase rate. 9320460095/ 9930193010
0071051718-1

NECC Mumbai Zone suggestive farm-gate egg price for today 21/08/2026 is Rs. 550/- per 100 eggs (for the information of trade & industry)
0071054146-1

EDUCATION

EDUCATIONAL

PASS directly "Khardikar Classes" VII Fail...? Direct X. XI fail...? Direct XII. Regular/ Distance BA, B.Com., B.Sc. Admision open. Dombivali- 9820627580/ 9820904646.
0071027225-3

PROPERTY

ESTATE & PROPERTY

Agricultural/ farm/ commercial /Industrial lands at Manori, Mangaoan, Wada, Palghar, Bhivandi, 1 -15 acres, road, electricity, river touch. 8169656303/ 9892062495
0071055799-1

PERSONAL

CHANGE OF NAME

I Pillai Varsha Radhakrishnan, D/O of Radhakrishnan, R/O C-84, 3/1, PanchavatiCHS, Sec-6, Kalamboli, Navi Mumbai, have changed my name to Varsha Radhakrishnan vide affidavit No. 69AB 001031 for passport issuance and other future purposes.
0050295627-2

I, hereby declare that my name mentioned wrongly in passport as Sapna Rajesh Nagballu, on Aadhar-Swapna Rajesh Nagballa, read my name all purposes as Swapna Rajesh Allu according to Maharashtra Gazette No. M-2513728, April 2025
0071055703-1

I have changed my Name and Date of Birth from K Muthumani, 01/07/1963 (old name and date of birth) to Muthumani K, 03/01/1955 (new name and date of birth) as per Affidavit no. 99AB539967, dtd. 13 Aug 2026.
0071055697-1

"IMPORTANT"

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EXPRESS special

SIR forms of 4 out of 10 voters could not be collected in 25 seats – all urban

17 in Mumbai region; names not collected will not be in draft roll

Vallabh Ozarkar
Mumbai, August 20

IN MAHARASHTRA'S 25 of 288 Assembly constituencies, all of which are urban, the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) forms of over 40 per cent voters could not be collected — their names would not find place in the draft roll that would be published on August 31.

An analysis of constituency-wise data accessed by *The Indian Express* has found that of the 25, 17 are in the Mumbai Metropolitan Region, seven in Pune and one in Nagpur.

These 25 constituencies have 1.10 crore electors, of which about 48.11 lakh, or 43.65 per cent, could not be traced. This account for nearly a quarter of all uncollected forms in the state.

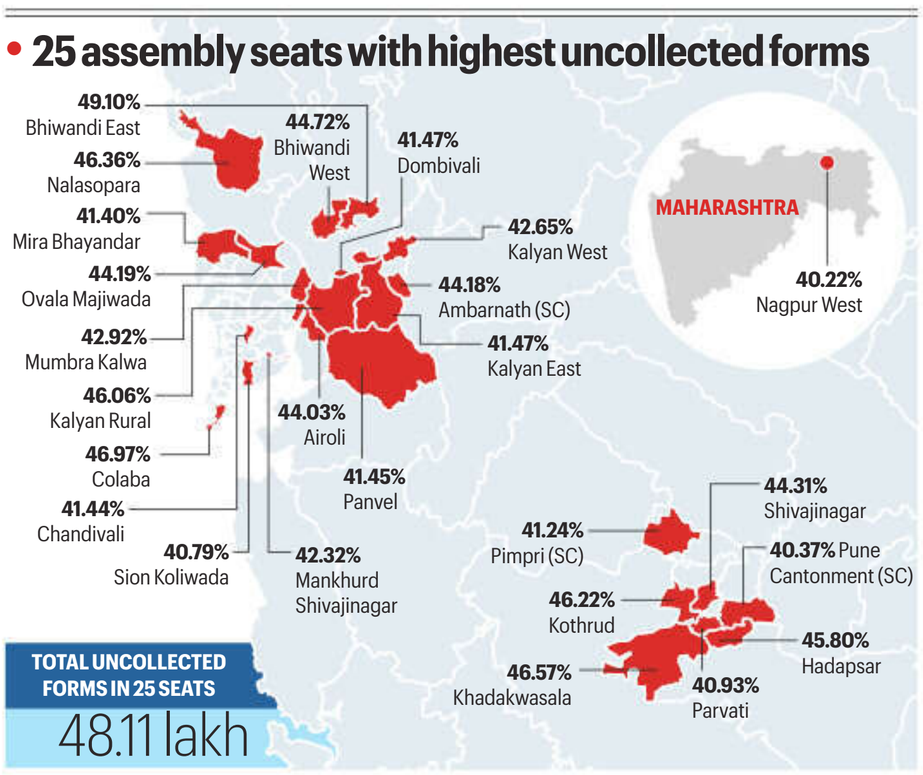
Statewide, forms of 2.07 crore of Maharashtra's 9.78 crore electors, or 21.15 per cent, could not be collected. Those voters are liable to be left out of the draft roll and will then have to file a claim to get their names back on it.

Bhiwandi East seat recorded the highest rate, 49.10 per cent, nearly two-and-a-half times the state average.

Forms of almost half its electoral (1.84 lakh of its 3.76 lakh voters) could not be collected. Colaba seat follows at 46.97 per cent, Khadakwasla at 46.57 Nalasopara at 46.36 and Kothrud at 46.22.

Kalyan Rural and Hadapsar complete the list of seven seats where forms of more than 45 per cent of voters went uncollected.

Rate and volume tell different stories.



Booth Level Officers check and collect enumeration forms as voters arrive to submit them for the special intensive revision. FILE

Nalasopara has the largest number of uncollected forms anywhere in the state – 3.07 lakh of 6.62 lakh voters – because its electorate is far bigger. Hadapsar follows with 2.98 lakh, Panvel 2.83 lakh, Khadakwasla 2.78 lakh and Kalyan Rural 2.52 lakh.

Many Booth Level Officers blame the urban concentration on the difficulty of reaching voters.

Dense housing clusters, high-rise buildings and a highly mobile population make door-to-door verification harder.

In Mumbai, Thane and Pune, residents have reported BLOs not reaching individual homes, with forms left at building gates instead.

Maharashtra Chief Electoral Officer S Chockalingam said the high percentage of uncollectable forms in urban areas was also linked to population mobility.

"People keep shifting from one place to another and their electoral records are not always updated. Another factor that needs to be considered is that this intensive revision is being undertaken after a gap of more than 24 years. The previous SIR was conducted in 2002 and the electoral rolls have not been comprehensively updated since then. We also have to take into account around 34 lakh names of deceased voters," he said

Chockalingam also said the draft roll was not the final voter list. Eligible voters can seek correction through Form 8 or apply for inclusion through Form 6 during the claims and objections period.

The worst-hit seats cut across party lines.

Of the seven above 45 per cent, the BJP won Colaba, Khadakwasla, Nalasopara and Kothrud in the 2024 Assembly election, the Shiv Sena won Kalyan Rural and the Ajit Pawar-led NCP won Hadapsar. Bhiwandi East went to the Samajwadi Party.

Several of the worst-affected seats, including Bhiwandi East, Mankhurd Shivajinagar, Chandivali, Mumbadevi and parts of Malad, have large Muslim and Scheduled Caste populations and extensive informal settlements. Colaba, Sion Koliwada, Dharavi and Worli take in the city's traditional fishing settlements.

The list is not uniform. Malabar Hill and Colaba, among the wealthiest constituencies in the state, record rates close to those in Mankhurd Shivajinagar. Kothrud and Khadakwasla, middle-class strongholds in Pune, are in the top five statewide.

The pattern, therefore, cuts across income groups and neighbourhood types, from dense informal settlements to high-rise and middle-class areas.

Three SC-reserved seats are among the 25 above 40 per cent: Ambarnath at 44.18 per cent, Pimpri at 41.24 and Pune Cantonment at 40.37. Nagpur North (SC) is at 36.59 per cent, Dharavi (SC) at 36.54 and Boisar (ST) at 34.35.

The house-to-house exercise ran from June 30 to August 18. Claims and objections open once the draft roll is published on August 31, and the final roll is scheduled for November 4.

NO DEARTH OF FUNDS

Haemophilia patients struggle for life-saving medicines

Purnima Sah
Mumbai, August 20

FOR 47-YEAR-OLD Rajan Ganpat Sankpal, a haemorrhagic stroke and seizures quickly became a medical emergency. A CT scan showed extensive bleeding inside his brain, and doctors urgently sought 8,000 IU of anti-haemophilic Factor VIII. Sankpal, who lived with haemophilia A, died by the end of July.

His case has brought into sharp focus concerns over access to life-saving clotting-factor medicines for nearly 5,500 haemophilia patients in Maharashtra, including around 1,000 in Mumbai. Patient groups say shortages of Factor VIII at government hospitals have persisted despite Rs 146 crore being allocated for haemophilia treatment this year. Haemophilia is a genetic bleeding disorder in which the blood does not clot properly, making timely access to clotting-factor medicines essential to prevent prolonged bleeding and serious complications.

"This year Maharashtra received Rs 55 crore under the Centre's National Health Mission (NHM), while another Rs 91 crore had been allocated by the state this year, taking the total to Rs 146 crore. Despite the funds being available, procurement remains stalled," said Jigar Kishore Kotecha, West Regional Council Chairman and Advocacy Head of the Hemophilia Federation of India, Maharashtra. The Hemophilia Society Maharashtra, in a representation to state health authorities on August 3 and 5, flagged shortages of Factor VIII at civil hospitals in Mumbai, Pune, Aurangabad, Dhule and Nagpur. Patient groups warned that interruptions in supplies could result in recurrent joint bleeding, permanent disability and, in cases involving brain bleeds or serious accidents, risk to life.

> **"Despite funds being available, procurement remains stalled"**
> JIGAR KISHORE KOTECHA
> WEST REGIONAL COUNCIL CHAIRMAN AND ADVOCACY HEAD OF THE HEMOPHILIA FEDERATION OF INDIA, MAHARASHTRA

Dr Sunil Lohade, vice-president of the Hemophilia Society of Maharashtra, said a six-year-old child had to travel nearly 400 km to Pune after suffering a head injury because Factor VIII was unavailable at Aundh District Hospital. "The Hemophilia Society had to mobilise the medicine," he said.

Lohade also cited the case of a 45-year-old man with a brain bleed who died about two weeks ago after a delay in getting the factor, and said a one-year-old child with a brain bleed faced a shortage last week.

"Patients have also been demanding extended half-life clotting factors for the past three years," he said.

The government, however, said the issue was not a lack of funds.

Dr Suhas Mohnalkar, Director of the State Blood Transfusion Council, said districts could use funds through the District Planning and Development Committee for direct purchase of medicines, while patients could be registered under the Mahatma Jyotirao Phule Jan Arogya Yojana, through which treatment costs are covered by the government. "If they are not using these mechanisms, the fault lies at the district level," Mohnalkar said.

He said funds released by the Centre under NHM first go to the Finance Department, after which requirements are assessed, files prepared and approvals obtained before they are sent to the Maharashtra Medical Goods Procurement Authority (MMGPA) for tendering. "The latest purchase guidelines were received a few days ago and the files will now move through the process," Mohnalkar said.

MMGPA CEO Bapu Gopinathrao Pawar said there was no procurement issue despite the earlier rate contract having expired. Government agencies could still procure Factor VIII at existing rates if they submitted a requirement, he said.

"We have not received any requests so far. If we receive one, we can arrange the purchase at the existing rates," Pawar said.

Announced in April, Rs 2,000 aid for girl students still awaits GR

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 20

FOUR MONTHS after Maharashtra announced a plan to provide girl students in higher and technical education up to Rs 2,000 a month under the 'earn and learn' scheme, the proposal is yet to be implemented, with the government still to issue a Government Resolution (GR).

Higher and Technical Education Minister Chandrakant Patil reiterated the proposal on Wednesday, prompting student organisations to question why the scheme had not moved ahead since its first announcement in April.

Pradeep Sawant of Yuva Sena, the youth wing of Shiv Sena (UBT), called the announcement an "election gimmick".

"After Gen Z protests, the government is currently on damage control to repair their image among youngsters. And in that effort, this announcement is made again, without providing a detailed plan of its implementation," Sawant said.

Taiwan FM blames Chinese disinformation for opposition to Indian workers, backs FTA

Alok Deshpande
Taipei, August 20

TAIWAN'S FOREIGN Minister Lin Chia-lung has blamed what he called "manipulation of information" by the Chinese Communist Party for opposition in Taiwan to the recruitment of Indian workers, saying it had created a "wrong concept" about Indian labour. He also backed a Free Trade Agreement (FTA) with India, saying stronger economic ties could help Taiwanese companies expand their manufacturing supply chains in the country.

Lin said Taiwan's foreign and labour ministries were working to resolve the issue of Indian workers, and that the government was willing to consider individual proposals as special projects until the 2024 India-Taiwan labour agreement is fully implemented.

"I personally, of course, support Taiwan-India cooperation, including introducing labourers and talent. I hope that we can settle that issue as soon as possible," Lin said while interacting with a group of journalists at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs headquarters here as part of Taiwan's New Southbound Policy.

"The reason behind the disputes is mainly the manipulation of information by the CCP. Therefore, our people have some improper or wrong concept about Indian labour," he said, adding that the foreign ministry supported implementing the memorandum of understanding (MoU) at the earliest and would coordinate with Taiwan's labour ministry.

Taiwan and India signed the MoU in February 2024 to facilitate the limited recruitment of Indian workers in sectors such as manufacturing, agriculture and construction. The initial proposal envisaged a pilot involving about 1,000 workers.

The move, however, has faced opposition in Taiwan. Earlier this year, a local politician put up a billboard in Siaogang district featuring a man in a turban alongside an inverted Indian flag and promising to ban Indian immigration. The billboard drew criticism from residents of Indian origin, who said it reinforced stereotypes about migrant workers.

More than 40,000 people have also signed an online petition opposing the government's proposed pilot scheme to recruit Indian workers. At present, only around 3,500-4,000 Indians work in Taiwan, even as the island faces growing labour shortages.

Lin sought to counter concerns over Indian workers, pointing to the performance of Indian migrants and professionals in other countries.

"I want to emphasise that India has many outstanding talents, including Indian migrant workers. They have a wonderful performance in various countries," he said. "If there are any Taiwanese businesses that would like to introduce Indian labourers, we can handle that as a special case or project."

Taiwan already relies heavily on migrant workers from countries such as the Philippines, Indonesia, Vietnam and Malaysia. An ageing population and labour shortages have increased the demand for younger migrant workers.

Lin also linked the labour controversy to what he described as a wider Chinese campaign of hybrid warfare against Taiwan, citing cyberattacks, disinformation and economic coercion.

"China has continued to exert pressure on the region through hybrid warfare," he said, adding that such actions had become a "shared security concern across the Indo-Pacific". He rejected Beijing's claims over Taiwan and said the island stood on the "democratic front line" against China's authoritarian expansionism.

On economic ties with India, Lin said Taiwan hoped to pursue an FTA to address trade and investment barriers faced by Taiwanese companies before they expand their operations in India.

(The reporter is in Taiwan at the invitation of the Taiwanese government)

14-POINT ENFORCEMENT ORDER ISSUED

Sale of loose edible oil banned in Maharashtra

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 20

THE MAHARASHTRA Food and Drugs Administration (FDA) has issued a 14-point statewide enforcement order banning the sale of loose edible oil and the reuse of single-use containers, while tightening checks on adulteration and repeatedly heated frying oil.

The order, issued by FDA Commissioner Tukaram Mundhe, covers the entire supply chain.

The FDA said inspections had detected unlicensed operations, adulteration with cheaper oils, unauthorised blending, relabelling, repackaging of near-expiry oil and use of non-food-grade packaging. The FDA also tightened controls on repeatedly heated frying oil. Oil with total polar compounds (TPC) above 25 per cent cannot be used, while used oil must be handed over to authorised RUCO collectors.

Six-year-old boy dies after being 'beaten up' by school teacher

Hyderabad: A six-year-old boy died after being allegedly beaten up by his school teacher on Thursday morning over homework.

According to police, CCTV footage from a camera in the classroom that shows the teacher slapping the boy. The incident occurred at around 9 am. "After a few slaps, the boy started crying and then collapsed unconscious in the arms of the teacher. She tried to wake him up and then went to get help... The cause of death will be known if a postmortem is conducted, but the boy's parents are against it," an official said. ENS

NRC protests: Manipur shuts schools and colleges

Express News Service
Imphal, August 20

SCHOOLS AND colleges in Manipur will be shut for three days starting Thursday due to the prevailing law and order situation over the National Register of Citizens (NRC).

The government's decision comes amid heightened tensions over the ongoing agitation in the state demanding the implementation of the NRC.

Just and Fair Delimitation (JFD), which has been spearheading the agitation, on Wednesday also announced a boycott of all government offices.

JFD convener Jitendra Ningomba said that the boycott will not disrupt essential services like health, water supply, electricity and education.

Ningomba also called for torch rallies at various places, urging people to participate in large numbers in support of the demand.

Amid the protests, Manipur Chief Minister Y. Khemchand Singh, on Thursday, met with a delegation of students representing 10 schools and colleges.

During the meeting, the students submitted a charter of demands, including the implementation of NRC in Manipur before the Census to identify illegal immigrants, reopening of educational institutions, and sought that the issue be discussed in the Assembly.

Khemchand reportedly assured the delegation that the state government would move to discuss NRC implementation in the upcoming Assembly session, scheduled to begin on September 2.

Chief Minister Singh also informed the students that the state government supported the implementation of NRC in the state.

WESTERN RAILWAY REGULARISES TRAIN NO. 04712/04711 BANDRA TERMINUS ⇌ BIKANER WEEKLY SPECIAL

REGULAR TRAIN NO.	ORIGINATING & DESTINATION STATIONS	DATE W.E.F.	DEPARTURE	ARRIVAL
14712	BANDRA TERMINUS – BIKANER (Weekly)	27.08.2026	19:25 hrs (Thursday)	23:55 hrs (Next Day)
14711	BIKANER – BANDRA TERMINUS (Weekly)	26.08.2026	13:30 hrs (Wednesday)	15:50 hrs (Next Day)

Halts: Borivali, Vapi, Valsad, Surat, Bharuch, Vadodara, Godhra, Ratlam, Nagda, Shamgarh, Ramganj Mandi, Kota, Sawai Madhopur, Durgapura, Jaipur, Ringas, Sikar, Lachhmangarh Sikar, Fatehpur Shekhawati, Churu, Ratangarh, Rajaldesar and Sri Dungargarh stations in both directions.

Composition: AC 2-Tier, AC 3-Tier, Sleeper Class and General Second Class Coaches.

For detailed information regarding stoppages, timings and composition, passengers may please visit www.enquiry.indianrail.gov.in.

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PUBLIC NOTICE ON AUCTION OF PLEDGED GOLD ORNAMENTS

The borrower/s in specific and interested bidders in general, are hereby informed that on account of non-repayment of the Banks due by the borrowers as under despite the payment notice and recall/auction notice issued by the Bank, the gold ornaments pledged with the bank security by the respective borrowers for the loan availed by them will be sold in public auction on "as is where is" and "non-recourse" at branch premises on **15th September 2026 at 10.30 AM**. The auction may be adjourned to any other later date at the discretion of the bank upon publication of the same in the Bank's notice board. The borrowers are hereby further inform that the gold ornaments will be disposed of by Public auction/e-auction, if the auction is not successful and if there is a further balance to be recovered thereafter, legal action will be initiated against the borrower/s for recovery of the balance amounts due to the bank. "In case of Deceased borrower, all conditions will be applicable to legal heirs."

S. No.	Auction Center CSB Branch	Account Name	Client ID	No.of Acc.	Bal. Outstanding as on 17-08-2026	Weight (grams)
1	Chembur - Mumbai	Aniket Machindra Jagdhane	10324214	001	6,25,744.37	74.18
2	Chembur - Mumbai	Poonam Shivkumar Naidu	10321671	001	9,78,773.52	110.61
3	Pune	Vijay Parshuram Sable	10018655	001	38,526.23	6.00
4	Mulund	Deepak Gulab Wankhade	04345407	001	18,85,647.64	288.80
5	Mulund	Deepika Pratik Jain	04027409	002	41,36,134.47	633.60
6	Mulund	Sunil Baliram Nalawade	04245085	002	14,58,437.42	172.90
7	Vashi	Ifthaikar Shahid Kazi	03479832	001	39,350.42	9.60
8	Ramwadi	Kunda Pappu Bhandare	04479979	001	8,11,971.23	88.60
9	Ramwadi	Nirmala Narsimma Balki	08158499	002	31,36,730.91	276.40
10	Ramwadi	Renuka Abhijit Gandhi	04872974	001	1,52,529.15	29.10
11	Ramwadi	Shubham Shantaram Sawant	08254447	003	1,00,35,199.64	916.30
12	Ramwadi	Umesh Tukaram Chalekar	10134195	002	32,20,269.19	285.40
13	Kalyan	Rekhabai Arun More	08212092	001	1,33,425.53	21.99
14	Kalyan	Rupesh Ramakant Shelar	04118612	001	4,18,532.35	45.50
15	Kalyan	Vijay Ramchandra Torpe	10076602	001	5,61,786.77	57.75
16	Kalyan	Yugal Prakash Jain	04927347	003	6,46,623.94	77.18
17	Kalyan	Zobia Akhtar Hussain Mulla	04176014	002	9,37,734.62	107.21
18	Vasai - East	Izrail Pasha Sayyed	10207678	001	82,903.70	13.50
19	Thane	Lekha Sunil Kumar	02668650	001	6,31,587.09	63.29
20	Thane	Santosh Verma	10243224	001	4,57,364.50	46.29
21	Thane	Sarjerav Vitthal Chormare	04584416	001	37,366.56	4.50
22	Vile Parle	Priyanka Karpan Devendra	10097828	001	3,27,768.69	35.60
23	Nerul - Navi Mumbai	Piyush Fattehlal Jain	08165118	001	1,11,595.32	14.80
24	Ulhas Nagar	Jagdish Mavji Parmar	05028438	003	16,99,861.15	186.10
25	Ulhas Nagar	Usha Milind Pawar	05066968	001	3,44,869.25	38.60
26	Nasik	Priyanka Manik Chavan	07681917	001	1,08,265.61	11.00
27	Nasik	Ramesh Santu Kandekar	10198733	006	27,20,471.16	289.70
28	Aurangabad	Sushma Kishor Chavare	10016156	001	20,93,902.15	293.30
29	Satara	Madhuri Vaibhav Chavan	04480622	001	5,69,554.95	74.20
30	Virar	Seema Jandas Pawar	07654399	001	10,45,529.76	101.50
31	Kolhapur	Anamika Amit Karande	04152477	006	10,45,593.61	141.02
32	Kolhapur	Asiya Tofik Maner	03711798	001	42,118.29	6.90
33	Kolhapur	Avdhut Subhash Bhopale	04965724	001	3,62,977.66	36.90
34	Kolhapur	Ruksana Shafik Jamadar	08178460	001	70,697.09	7.20
35	Kolhapur	Sagar Vijay Bhalekar	04937235	005	20,10,552.67	182.02
36	Kolhapur	Sanjay Namdev Kumbhar	04004049	003	64,32,195.98	596.55
37	Ratnagiri	Arun Raghunath Salvi	07774796	002	11,47,748.12	142.10
38	Ratnagiri	Sunil Krushna Baperkar	04422667	001	7,66,068.82	78.57
39	Akola	Abhishek Gajanan Dandage	10017448	001	3,17,385.75	44.45
40	Akola	Nagesh Babulal Jaiswal	07269344	002	13,02,100.68	114.80
41	Akola	Rambhau Ramkrushn Ghorad	10016967	001	2,36,559.67	38.45
42	Birangudwadi	Anil Kashinath Shinde	04799115	001	11,17,538.89	116.00
43	Varkute	Subhash Ganapat Bhong	04485258	001	1,85,840.94	20.23
44	Varkute	Swati Khanderav Rajguru	10088014	002	7,22,303.37	73.50
45	Market Yard	Mokale Pavan Vasant	10157311	001	96,54,443.59	947.40
46	Market Yard	Sameer Sanjay Mahadik	07705813	001	13,46,669.05	118.70
47	Sadesatranali	Prithviraj Bhagwat Khedkar	10133615	001	14,46,778.73	149.67
48	Sadesatranali	Ravi Prasad	10210940	001	96,468.76	9.80
49	Narande	Sandeep Shivaji Garje	04765398	001	1,33,429.67	23.00
50	Dugaon	Suvarna Sachin Bhagwat	04880046	001	94,098.12	9.60
51	Rui	Amol Baban Lokhande	10022410	005	5,77,706.33	67.90
52	Rui	Ghadge Mahendra Krishnarao	07999169	001	6,55,278.79	69.90
53	Rui	Sachin Dadaso Ghule	08306983	001	70,302.38	11.32
54	Rui	Satav Santosh Madhukar	07468366	001	7,20,981.24	126.50
55	Rui	Umesh Pandurang Bhapkar	04936749	002	3,28,987.72	42.00
56	Sangli	Sanjay Pandurang Nagthane	04496023	002	3,43,154.53	56.00
57	Badlapur	Dileep Kumar Mayashankar	04818243	001	3,84,752.70	66.18
58	Solapur	Sagar Anand Chavan	04876386	002	1,77,796.09	24.90
59	Pandharpur	Ganesh Pundlik Abhangrao	04563412	003	12,56,949.82	124.10
60	Pandharpur	Sanket Sanjay Malashetti	10209515	001	1,13,226.54	11.50
61	Pandharpur	Vaibhav Bhikaji Asabe	10209627	001	11,51,026.19	117.10
62	Pandharpur	Vijay Sopan Patil	10207783	001	1,97,062.47	20.00
63	Pandharpur	Yashwant Laxman Khandekar	10016634	002	1,68,228.56	18.30
64	Akluj	Bhajandas Arjun Magar	08198111	002	17,31,084.43	199.00
65	Akluj	Sangita Dilip Ingale	07967949	003	16,96,574.11	276.20
66	Akluj	Vasant Keraba Nanavare	04609409	002	4,78,792.32	50.10
67	Erandwane	Poonam Ravindra Wagh	07803448	002	10,77,583.71	93.75
68	Dhavalgaon	Devikar Abhishek Narayan	10047871	002	9,26,894.17	93.70
69	Dhavalgaon	Devikar Vinod Narayan	04807503	001	6,23,267.10	66.70
70	Dhavalgaon	Santosh Bhanudas Katore	05067614	002	5,74,989.67	61.20
71	Dhavalgaon	Sunil Ghoraknath Waghmare	07549003	002	6,39,347.39	77.80
72	Talegaon	Sudha Suresh Potdar	10174246	001	4,60,947.35	47.40
73	Talegaon	Tejas Suresh Potadar	10211572	001	97,012.09	9.90
74	Donawade	Amit Bajirao Patil	08249512	001	1,89,182.27	30.80
75	Donawade	Krushant Pundalik Patil	08240477	001	24,33,415.62	328.76
76	Donawade	Pradeep Prakash Desai	07941669	001	2,38,573.74	42.10
77	Donawade	Uttam Balawant Sutar	10018669	001	2,28,255.86	29.70
78	Kedgaon	Archana Sachin Gund	10208011	001	2,05,134.33	22.19
79	Kedgaon	Bhausaheb Namadev Tambe	10208482	001	1,23,598.21	12.70
80	Kedgaon	Nikhil Diganbar Thorat	10207130	001	4,37,193.45	47.60
81	Kedgaon	Shubham Dattatray Bankar	07446106	001	4,24,738.84	43.85
82	Kedgaon	Surwanta Dhananjay Handal	08194634	001	55,331.50	9.21
83	Palus	Mayur Mohan Pawar	04715081	001	55,843.28	5.70
84	Kavitgaon- Kandar	Prashant Chandrakant More	07674063	001	95,285.23	15.50
85	Pirangut	Priyanka Manish Gaikwad	10272165	003	9,04,558.58	80.42
86	Jalgaon	Anil Atmaram Londhe	10196793	001	1,04,545.57	11.38
87	Jalgaon	Patil Kiran Sudhakar	10017477	001	82,439.22	13.70
88	Baner	Gonge Dyanoba	04704650	001	1,97,625.84	21.40
89	Baner	Laxman Shivaji Manjulkar	10210478	001	2,28,746.34	25.40
90	Baner	Vikas Dinkar Patil	10021130	002	9,17,156.62	98.30
91	Kandivali	Rakesh Anand Dalvi	10207326	001	4,84,431.10	58.65
92	Hinjewadi - Pune	Jyoti Vitthal Wable	08324800	002	21,47,145.80	192.35
93	Malad West Orlem	Mahanarayan Yadav	10210185	001	40,184.30	37.02
94	Kharghar - Navi Mumbai	Fazal Kadir Surve	10003535	001	96,175.95	15.20
95	Kolhapur 2 - Mahalakshmi	Prasad Mahadev Bhosale	08222355	001	5,97,142.70	63.90
96	Kolhapur 2 - Mahalakshmi	Sanjay Namdev Kumbhar	04004049	001	3,78,157.47	38.39
97	Kolhapur 2 - Mahalakshmi	Snehal Akshay Kamble	10210215	001	4,62,854.26	47.90
98	Belapur	Runali Dhopavkar	10208187	001	97,660.10	15.10
99	Kondhwa	Rakesh Ramesh Bansode	10207831	002	2,24,919.31	23.20
100	Chiplun	Avinash Shantaram Tatkare	10209921	001	1,10,493.92	11.30
101	Chiplun	Fazal Kadir Surve	10003535	001	6,49,984.07	86.00
102	Chiplun	Grishma Shekhar Shinde	04813784	002	7,63,174.87	77.50
103	Chiplun	Mahesh Dayanand Mohite	10210898	001	1,32,303.97	13.45

For more details/account wise information borrowers/interested bidders may contact respective branches and for participating in the auction

MAHARASHTRA | 21.08.2026

Sd/- Authorized Officer, CSB Bank

DELHI CONFIDENTIAL

Happiness Masterplan

DELHI'S MUCH-AWAITED Masterplan 2047 was unveiled on Thursday by Union Minister Manohar Lal Khattar, who was flanked by Lieutenant-Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta. Kicking off the press conference, the minister, who had a sore throat because of the flu, said he too had been hit by the ongoing "viral system of Delhi". He said he would make up for his heavy voice with happiness as the masterplan was being revealed.

Straight Talk

DELIMITATION, WHICH was at the core of the NDA government's unsuccessful legislative push for women's reservation in April this year, did not remain limited to official deliberations led by Union Home Minister Amit Shah at the 31st Southern Zonal Council in Tamil Nadu. Shah broached the topic again while lunching with chief ministers and representatives of South Indian states, according to party sources. The senior BJP leader took the opportunity to underline the key benefits that the delimitation exercise would bring to the region, as his audience sipped soup and sampled the salad while awaiting the main course.

THREE-LANGUAGE POLICY

English indigenous or foreign language? Supreme Court for examining constitutionality

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, August 20

THE SUPREME Court on Thursday wondered whether it's correct to treat English as a "non-indigenous" language under the CBSE's three-language policy, given its "roots into Indian society", and said the constitutionality of doing so will have to be examined.

The court made the observation while hearing petitions challenging the CBSE's decision to introduce the three-language formula under the National Education Policy (NEP) from 2026-27.

A three-judge bench, presided by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, also asked the Board to clarify if the current batch of Class 6 students can be given a reprieve and the policy be introduced from next year, given that the infrastructure is still not adequately in place.

During the hearing, some of the petitioners pointed out that the three-language policy considers English a non-native language and this is making life difficult for the students.

Responding to the concern, Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati, appearing for CBSE, told the bench: "English is an official language under the Constitution. That status no one can take away... it's not treated like a foreign language, but it can't be treated like a native language also. Language is the vehicle of a culture..."

> **English is an official language under the Constitution. That status no one can take away... it's not treated like a foreign language, but it can't be treated like a native language also. Language is the vehicle of a culture"**
> **AISHWARYA BHATI,** ADDITIONAL SOLICITOR GENERAL APPEARING FOR CBSE

Justice Bagchi said, "If we have to examine that issue as to the extent to which English can be considered as a non-indigenous language, first, I personally have a serious reservation about the expression used 'native'. It has a very colonial import. It should be 'indigenous'. Secondly, if you see the historical perspective of English and the extent of its roots into Indian society, it would be, I think in a final decision making process, although it's your policy, you would take the final call, but then on the constitutionality angle, we have to see whether English can be classified as a non-indigenous language or an indigenous language. Because if you do that, to a large extent these rough edges can be taken care of."

Bhati said "non-native is an expression coming from the new education policy".

"That is why the framers of the new policy ought to have been conscious of the words they choose," according to Justice Bagchi.

The three-language policy requires students to learn three languages in school, with at least two being "native Indian languages" (*Bhartiya Bhashas*).

On concerns of class 6 students, Justice Bagchi said: "The second thing which is really troubling the petitioners is whether the 6th standard can also be given a reprieve from taking the final test in Class 10. Because when you see the option, the option is 23 languages in theory, but in reality...only around 4% of schools are under CBSE and 96% are under State Boards... There are asymmetries in compliance of National Council for Teacher Education rules. Now, compounded with that, if suddenly you have another indigenous language to be taught...You would have to give some time not only for the students but also for the infrastructure of schools to come on par...If that can be reconsidered by the Council with regard to the admissibility of these classes."

The judge said, "It is a very good policy of the National Education Policy to start a child with the mother tongue and then move to another indigenous language. And a third language, maybe indigenous, maybe a foreign language... However, if it can be scaled down to that lower standard, that gives a greater elbow space for the students and their parents to take a call. Secondly the school administration can also absorb the administrative compliance regimes. They will require a compliance regime because if you see even with regard to...language, there are not adequate numbers of B.Ed qualified teachers. If you put Sanskrit here, how many Sanskrit teachers are B.Ed qualified? They may be very learned in Sanskrit. So if this can be reconsidered." Bhati said she will put it to the experts and appraise the court.

Remembering Rajiv

Senior Congress leaders Sonia Gandhi, Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra pay tributes to former prime minister Rajiv Gandhi on his 82nd birth anniversary at Vir Bhumi in Delhi on Thursday. ANIL SHARMA

PM: Need greater engagement between youth, govt & varsities

New Delhi: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday called for greater engagement between government departments, universities and young people to bring fresh perspectives in policymaking.

Chairing the third high-level meeting with Secretaries to the Government, he emphasised the need to strengthen India's defence industry further and make it more competitive at the global level. Modi also sought effective use of AI while ensuring human intervention and judgement. PTI

Matching Islamabad's action, Delhi brings down structures outside Pak High Commission

Unauthorised structures demolished outside the Pakistan High Commission in New Delhi, Thursday. PTI

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, August 20

IN A tit-for-tat move, some temporary structures and barricades outside the Pakistan High Commission in New Delhi were removed on Wednesday, days after the Indian High Commission in Islamabad faced similar action.

According to sources in Delhi, the Pakistan authorities on Monday removed some barricades and structures that had been put up outside the Indian High Commission in Islamabad. These structures, including parking poles, had been put up to manage the queues of visitors and visa applicants, said sources. The Indian side had requested the Pakistan authorities not to remove these structures.

On Wednesday, the Indian side carried out similar action outside the Pakistan High Commission in the Capital's Chanakyapuri area. A section of unauthorised structures outside the Pakistan High Commission was demolished. A JCB machine was deployed to remove the structures and barricades erected along the lane outside the compound, including those for queue management near the visa section, sources said.

Visuals of the action showed that it left a trail of rubble outside the mission, with broken metal railings and gates, twisted metal frames, roofing sheets, bricks, and chunks of concrete and plaster strewn across the paved area. The visa section remained visible amid the debris. Broken fencing and construction material were seen lying around the counters.

This comes at a time when ties between India and Pakistan are at a low point, after Operation Sindoor in May last year, following the Pahalgam terror attack. Both the High Commissions have been functioning at the level of the Charge d'affaires for the last seven years, with reduced diplomatic strength and visa services mostly limited to pilgrims on both sides.

EXPRESS special

Karnataka 'poacher' killings: Forensics indicate men shot from close range, witness 'missing'

Kiran Parashar
Mariyamangala (Chamarajanagar), August 20

HE IS reminded of the time Veerappan ruled the roost in the area 20 years ago, says Perinayaka, 78. With his son Anthony Swamy among the three alleged poachers killed in an encounter in Hanur in the Cauvery Wildlife Sanctuary, he says: "There was violence then and fear, bullets prevailed... Now, after two decades, it is haunting us again. We fear for our lives."

All the three who were killed, in the wee hours of August 15 — Anthony, 50, his brother-in-law Sebatian David Kumar, 35, and John Rose Peter, 43 — belonged to Mariyamangala, a small hamlet with less than 25 houses located on the fringes of the wildlife sanctuary. The one who survived and a witness to the incident, Joseph Mahima Das, was found admitted to a hospital later, and is now "missing".

In a video featuring him that emerged on Tuesday evening, Das is seen pleading for help and saying he feared for his life.

As a magistrate-led investigation, mandatory in the case of any encounter, looks into the incident, sources said initial findings, including forensic, indicate that the three were killed by a single shotgun, fired at close range. An official told *The Indian Express:* "A guard carrying a slide-action (pump-action repeater) gun loaded with cartridges (minimum 6 rounds at a time) reacted in panic. He pulled the trigger hard and because he held it down, the weapon discharged all its loaded rounds in rapid succession." The families deny the Forest Department's claim that the men were poachers, insisting they had gone to search for their cattle. While officials claim to have seized two country-made weapons from the men, apart from 34.25 kg of deer meat from near the spot, the families have said the weapons did not belong to the men.

While only Das among the three had previous cases of violation of forest and wildlife laws against him, Anthony's family members had faced similar cases in the past, sources said.

Forest, Ecology and Environment Minister Ramalinga Reddy told the state Assembly on Monday that bullets were fired from a single shotgun issued to one of the forest guards. He said the forest staff had tried to convince the poachers to surrender, but they attacked them. "The poachers were at a higher altitude. The forest staff fired three rounds from a slide action gun... Since the hunters were not clearly visible, the bullets hit them in the upper torso," the minister said, adding that there was "no malicious intent".

On the injuries suffered by the victims, Reddy said. "The cartridge from this gun consists of small pellets and gunpowder and scatters when fired. This caused injuries to various body parts of the accused."

Family members of John Rose Peter who was killed in an encounter in Hanur in Cauvery Wildlife Sanctuary on August 15. KIRAN PARASHAR

Officials say that late on August 14 evening, the Forest Department received "actionable intelligence" of poachers entering the forest. A group of 10-15 personnel were assembled and split into two teams to search for the poachers.

Mariswamy, the Assistant Conservator of Forests (ACF), Hanur Wildlife Division, told The Indian Express that the men were there with the "intent of poaching". "A warning was issued, but they did not pay heed. The suspects fired but it was a misfire, causing a flash. At this time, our people opened fire. If they had not, our staff would have been the victims."

Adds Mariswamy: "They had items required for hunting. They were also deep inside the forest. What was the need to venture so deep with two country-made weapons if all they were doing was searching for lost cattle?" In a video statement released from hospital, before he "disappeared", Das agreed with this sequence of events, but denied that it was they who fired first. He says he ran away when the foresters opened fire. "After 5 minutes, there was no sound. I was tired, unwell and had a stomach ache so I reached home and got myself admitted to a hospital."

With the area still tense, the Forest Department claimed Wednesday that several anti-poaching camps inside the Cauvery Wildlife Sanctuary were "blown up" by "miscreants". Mariswamy told The Indian Express that gelatin sticks and dynamite were used to attack the camps. Several days after the incident, Mariyamangala remains angry over the killings and tense about police action that may follow.

While the Forest Department says it has registered a case against Das and he is "absconding", police say he is not in their custody. Mary says officials have also been dropping in at their house, including late in the night, to ask about Das. "We are scared." In the video that came out Tuesday evening, Das says he and the others were sleeping when gunfire erupted around 5 am. "They (the forest officials) walked up to us and started shooting. I froze. When they aimed at me, I just ran towards the town." Accusing police of intimidating others to put pressure on him, Das says: "You must look after me and protect me."

At 156 km in length and 10 km in width, Hanur is one of the largest forest sub-divisions in Karnataka. It was here that sandalwood smuggler Veerappan had almost a free run from the 1990s till 2004, when he was shot dead by the Tamil Nadu Police's Special Task Force.

Since his death, dozens of smaller groups of poachers have emerged from the villages surrounding the forests, inhabited primarily by migrants from Tamil Nadu.

Restoration of J&K's spl status remains priority for NC: Farooq

Press Trust of India
Srinagar, August 20

NATIONAL CONFERENCE president Farooq Abdullah on Thursday said restoration of J&K's special status, revoked by the Centre in 2019, remains at the top of the party's agenda and it will never abandon the struggle for it.

In a statement, Abdullah said the special constitutional status accorded to Jammu and Kashmir reflected its distinct and unique constitutional relationship with the Union, a legacy that remained central to the NC's political vision.

The supremo of the ruling NC said even though the constitutional provisions relating to J&K had been "altered unilaterally", his party would continue its struggle for its restoration. "The issue remains at the top of the party's agenda. The people of J&K have a right to raise their voice for restoration of their constitutional rights," he said.

Shah hails southern states: 'Biggest contributor to nation's development'

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 20

STATING THAT India's southern region was very important for the development of the country, Union Home Minister Amit Shah hailed the states for their high literacy rate, trained manpower and technical expertise in the utilisation of deep seas, which, he said, has made South India "the biggest contributor to the country's development."

Shah discussed a host of issues — from Mullaperiyar Dam to basic interstate coordination and cooperative federalism — as he chaired the 31st meeting of the Southern Zonal Council (SZC) in Tamil Nadu's Mahabalipuram on Thursday.

Chief Ministers and other representatives of the southern states and UTs also put forth their points at the meeting. While Tamil Nadu CM C Joseph Vijay and his Karnataka counterpart DK Shivakumar urged that the existing number of seats in Lok Sabha be frozen, and women's reservation be accommodated within the current number of seats, Kerala CM VD Satheesan sought a more equitable and flexible funding approach for centrally sponsored schemes.

Andhra Pradesh CM N Chandrababu Naidu said the Southern economy could reach $10 trillion by 2047 while Telangana Deputy CM Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka said his state sought no special privilege but only its fair entitlement through the legal mechanisms already established with respect to Krishna waters.

According to the Ministry of Home Affairs, Shah, in his address, sought to underline that the southern region was key to the development of the country and had always contributed to each sector such as literature, Research and Development (R&D), space, IT, AI, industrial development and agriculture.

Shah said the development journey of South India was based on three pillars — high literacy rate, trained manpower and technical expertise in the utilisation of deep seas, which had made South India "the biggest contributor to the country's development." India needed to learn from the south with regard to innovation and revenue generation.

In a 5-4 ruling, Supreme Court for tweaking the definition of industry, exempts pending matters

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, August 20

UNDERLINING THAT the essential framework of its 1978 interpretation of what constitutes an "industry" has withstood the test of time, the Supreme Court on Thursday, in a 5:4 ruling, said that the definition needs modification.

"We have felt that some of these constituent elements could have been articulated differently so as to better reflect the scope and contours of Section 2(j) (of the Industrial Disputes Act, 1947)," Chief Justice of India Surya Kant said. CJI Kant, Justices Alok Aradhe, SC Sharma, Vipul Pancholi and PS Narasimha formed the majority while Justices BV Nagarathna, Dipankar Dutta, Ujjal Bhuyan and Joymalya Bagchi wrote dissenting opinions.

A fine print of the ruling prescribing the new formulation of the definition is awaited. The definition of an "industry" – earlier under the erstwhile Industrial Disputes Act, 1947 and now under the Industrial Relations Code, 2020, which is set to replace it – determines employees under which workplaces are entitled to statutory protections. The wide net cast by the 1978 definition enabled workers to have a legal recourse regarding wages, working hours, strikes and protection against arbitrary dismissal, among other things.

The majority ruling said that while pending disputes under the Industrial Disputes Act will continue to be decided under the framework laid down in its landmark 1978 Bangalore Water Supply and Sewerage Board v A Rajappa judgement, prospective cases will be governed by the modified definition. However, even the modified definition will not apply to pending cases.

"It is not intended to displace the governing legal position in respect to the pending process. Consequently, all matters presently pending before courts, governors, labor authorities... under the Industrial Disputes Act, 1947 may be adjudicated in accordance with the triple test as laid down in Bangalore Water Supply. We have not disturbed that because it will create artificial discrimination..." CJI Kant said.

In the 1978 ruling, the Supreme Court laid down what came to be known as the "triple test" for identifying an industry. It held that an undertaking would qualify as an industry if there was "systematic activity", "organised by cooperation between employer and employee", "for the production and/or distribution of goods or services calculated to satisfy human wants and wishes." The court said it did not matter whether the activity is driven by profit, though purely spiritual or religious activities would not be covered.

With differences in how this judgement was interpreted in subsequent rulings, the case was referred to a nine-judge bench for reconsideration.

The majority opinion on Thursday held that the reference questioning the correctness of the 1978 ruling was maintainable.

Justice Bagchi held that he disagreed with the majority opinion on the reformulation of the triple test.

Justice Nagarathna found that the 1978 ruling did not require any interference or modification. The judge said that merely because a function is performed by the State, it cannot be exempted from the definition of "industry."

"Social welfare activities and schemes or other enterprises undertaken by the government departments or their instrumentalities can be construed to be industrial activities for the purpose of section 2(j) of the Act depending on the nature of the activities. Because the government is doing these activities per se they cannot be excluded from the definition of industry. Hence, the test of who carries out the activity is not relevant. Rather, what is the nature of the activity and all other relevant factors of the activity have to be considered to determine whether the activity is an industrial activity or not," Justice Nagarathna said.

Sajjan Kumar, ex-Cong MP jailed in 1984 riot cases, dies

Asad Rehman
New Delhi, August 20

THE MOST prominent Congress leader to be convicted in an anti-Sikh riots case, Sajjan Kumar died on Thursday. Kumar, 80, was a three-time MP who had been serving a life sentence in Tihar Jail since 2018.

Kumar, whose association with the party had ended by the time of his conviction, was allegedly present at, addressed, or directed mobs in parts of West Delhi during the communal violence that engulfed the national Capital following Indira Gandhi's assassination by her Sikh bodyguards on October 31, 1984. On Kumar's role in the violence, the Justice Nanavati Commission of Inquiry said, "Many witnesses have stated about the involvement of S/Shri Sajjan Kumar, Balwan Khokar, Pratap Singh, Maha Singh and Mohinder Singh."

In 2018, the Delhi High Court sentenced Kumar to life imprisonment in connection with the killing of five members of a Sikh family during the anti-Sikh riots. Jagdish Kaur of Raj Nagar, whose husband and son were among those killed, had told the Nanavati Commission that she heard Kumar tell people gathered near Mandir Mangolpuri, "Sardar saala koi nahi bachna chahida (no Sikh should be spared)". Kumar had moved for parole in the Supreme Court, citing his age and medical condition, as well as the medical condition of his wife. His appeal against his 2018 sentence was scheduled to be heard on Thursday. However, after his health deteriorated, he was moved from the prison to Safdarjung Hospital, where he was declared dead. "He was a known case of high blood pressure and Parkinson's disease and had a history of multiple hospital admissions in the past," read the hospital statement. Kumar, who used to be a bakery owner, was a close confidant of Sanjay Gandhi and rose through the party ranks after being elected councillor in 1977. He was known for wielding influence in the outer Delhi region and was first elected to the Lok Sabha in 1980 from the Outer Delhi seat. Though the anti-Sikh violence and his role in it continued to shadow him, Kumar remained an influential political figure and won the Outer Delhi Lok Sabha seat in the 1991 polls and again in 2004.

Sajjan Kumar was serving a life term in Tihar Jail. PTI

A trial court acquitted Kumar in 2013, refusing to convict him solely based on the eyewitness testimony of Jagdish Kaur. But as the law caught up with him with the 2018 conviction — the court clarified that imprisonment for life means "the remainder of his natural life" — Kumar resigned from the Congress that had, by then, distanced itself from him.

Following the High Court verdict, Prime Minister Narendra Modi took a dig at the Congress, saying years earlier, before the BJP came to power, no one could have imagined that a Congress leader would get convicted for the "1984 Sikh massacre".

In 2025, Kumar was sentenced to life imprisonment in a separate case linked to the riots. He was found guilty of leading a mob that burned alive Jaswant Singh and his son Tarundeep Singh in Saraswati Vihar on November 1, 1984, and was also found guilty of looting and destroying their homes.

Earlier this January, Kumar was acquitted in a case related to inciting violence in Delhi's Janakpuri for which an FIR was lodged in 1992. He was the only accused in the case.

WITH INPUTS FROM NIRBHAY THAKUR

EXPRESS special

Kerala having fewer kids — that's bad news for teachers

6,114 recruited as teachers in govt lower primary schools; however, only 239 appointed

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, August 20

In the lower primary segment, the teacher-student ratio is 1:30. EXPRESS

FOR 40-YEAR-OLD S Valarmathi, making the rank list for lower primary teachers in government schools in Kerala was supposed to be a step towards a job she had long dreamed of.

Instead, with only a fraction of those on the 2025 rank list getting jobs, that dream has turned into a 41-day indefinite agitation in front of the state secretariat, where she has joined fellow rank holders demanding that the government give them their due.

The state government's Public Service Commission (PSC) recruited as many as 6,114 people as teachers in government lower primary schools for a period of three years starting June 2025. However, only 239 candidates have been appointed so far.

And since each such ranklist is for a maximum period of three years, and the existing one expires in May 2028, aspirants say time is ticking.

Stakeholders cite one key reason teachers are not being placed despite making the rank list: the fall in student enrolment, particularly at the lower-primary level, linked to the state's declining birth rates.

"I passed the teachers' training course (TTC) 16 years ago, in 2010. In between, I worked in government schools for a few years on daily wages. This job has been my dream. I am a single parent of two children, who are with my mother in Palakkad as I sit on protest here. As 40 years is the upper limit to apply for a government job in Kerala, age is not on my side," said Valarmathi.

Balkis K F, 27, completed the TTC in 2017 and has worked in various schools on a daily-wage basis. She figured in the 2019 supplementary rank list but did not secure a job as no appointments were made at the time.

"I completed my TTC when I was 18. My husband is a farm worker. Aided school managements are demanding huge sums, ranging from Rs 30 lakh to Rs 40 lakh, and candidates like me cannot afford to pay that much to get a job in the sector," she said.

Similarly, hope is slowly giving way to frustration for 36-year-old Manzoor, who worked as a salesman in the UAE for 14 years before returning to Kerala and clearing the recruitment process — only for the job to remain elusive.

Dwindling enrolment

At the start of each academic year in June, the Education Department conducts a process called staff fixation in all government and aided schools based on the number of students enrolled. In the lower primary segment, the teacher-student ratio is 1:30.

When a teacher retires, that vacancy can be filled only if that particular school continues to have the required number of students. If it does not, the junior-most teacher can be shown the door.

According to Kerala School Teachers' Association general secretary T K A Shafi, scores of teaching jobs in the government sector have disappeared over the years for want of students. "As per the government decision, teachers who joined schools until 2022 are protected, meaning they can be redeployed if needed. But those appointed after 2022 are at risk of job loss, and have to wait until a new vacancy emerges. Unfortunately, such vacancies are also rare," he said.

An analysis of student strength in Kerala's government and aided schools between 2021-22 and 2025-26 shows that the system lost 3.33 lakh students in four years – with the figure dipping from 38.68 lakh to 35.35 lakh.

And, as per data presented in the Assembly, 2,06,706 students enrolled in the first standard in government and aided schools that follow the state board syllabus this year. In the last academic year, this figure was 2,34,476.

Kerala's crude birth rate was 17.67 in 1992 and stayed around that level for several years. It slipped to 16.63 by 2006 and 15.75 by 2010. The rate fell below 15 for the first time in 2016, at 14.48, before dropping again to 13.79 in 2019. It then declined by 1.02 between 2019 and 2020, and by 0.83 between 2020 and 2021.

Apart from the declining birth rate, another factor is that many parents are opting to send their children to private CBSE schools.

Criminal lawyer Vijay Aggarwal held in London over sexual assault charges

Vineet Bhalla
New Delhi, August 20

PROMINENT INDIAN criminal lawyer Vijay Aggarwal, known for representing high-profile clients in major financial scam cases, has been arrested and charged with multiple counts of sexual assault in London.

The London Metropolitan Police confirmed to *The Indian Express* that the 57-year-old advocate was taken into custody from a property in Mayfair, an affluent area in the city's West End.

According to a statement shared by the police, officers attended a residence on Brick Street following reports of sexual assaults that allegedly took place on May 26 and August 9.

Along with Aggarwal, a 41-year-old woman identified as Manpreet Kaur — believed to be his personal assistant — was also arrested from the same address.

While Aggarwal faces four counts of sexual assault, Kaur has been charged with two counts of "intentionally encouraging or assisting the commission of an either way offence".

Under the UK legal system, an 'either way offence' refers to a crime that can be tried in either a lower magistrates' court or a higher crown court, depending on the severity of the allegations.

Both accused appeared before the Westminster Magistrates' Court shortly after being charged. They were subsequently remanded in custody and are directed to appear at the Southwark Crown Court on September 10.

The police investigation into the Mayfair property also led to the arrest of two other individuals – a 23-year-old man and a 43-year-old woman. However, the Metropolitan Police noted that they have been "bailed pending further enquiries".

The Indian Express reached out to Aggarwal's wife via phone and WhatsApp for comment, but received no response.

Bihar: Amid TRE-4 rollback demand, students plan Raj Bhavan march

Patna: Students protesting over the rollback of the two-tier Teacher Recruitment Examination-4 (TRE-4) on Thursday gave a call for a Raj Bhavan march on August 22 to express solidarity with PhD scholars and researchers who have been agitating for 17 days, demanding the withdrawal of proposed new recruitment rules for assistant professors. Separate groups of students are also pressing for the filling of vacancies for music teachers and librarians. "We have given a call for a gherao of the Raj Bhavan or Lok Bhawan on August 22," said Kumud Patel, convener of the All Ph.D. Holders and Research Scholars Association of Bihar. **ENS**

With social media plan, 14-point checklist, Yogi govt responds to students' concerns

Maulshree Seth
Lucknow, August 20

WITH STUDENT protests over basic school facilities mounting across Uttar Pradesh, the state government has directed officials to track complaints posted on social media, verify them and address genuine issues.

Alongside this, the UP Education Department has issued a 14-point checklist for 40,000 basic and secondary schools, asking officials to check whether essential facilities — from drinking water and toilets to electricity, cleanliness, food and safety — are available and functioning.

Over the past month, students across at least five districts have staged protests — blocking roads in Lucknow and Unnao, marching to a Collectorate in Hamirpur and locking themselves inside a hostel in Kannauj — until officials heard them out. Their demands included more teachers, better food, drinking water, functioning fans, cleaner campuses and better infrastructure.

The department has instructed officials to track social media handles and posts carrying information may be misleading, while ensuring that factual information is communicated appropriately.

"Any complaint received through social media, mass media or other medium should be promptly checked and inspected and its authenticity and factual status should be presented on the social media handles of the District Magistrate of the district concerned," said the directive.

The instructions have also been sent to divisional and district-level education officials for "strict and regular compliance".

Officials have been asked to ensure that schools have and maintain essential facilities including safe drinking water, separate toilets for boys and girls, hand-washing arrangements, blackboards, mid-day meal kitchens, electricity connections and functional electrical equipment. Schools have also been asked to use available composite grants for minor repairs and maintenance.

For Kasturba Gandhi Balika Vidyalayas, the department has prescribed additional checks: a secure environment, availability of women security guards, hygienic toilets apart from other essentials.

Lucknow man shoots wife dead outside bank; less than an hour later, kills sister, takes own life

Police outside ICICI Bank where Manas Bajpayi allegedly killed his wife in Gomti Nagar, Lucknow, Thursday. VISHAL SRIVASTAV

Bhupendra Pandey
Lucknow, August 20

AT 12.15 pm on Thursday, a 39-year-old man allegedly shot his wife outside the private bank where she worked in Lucknow's upscale Gomti Nagar. Less than an hour later, he allegedly killed his sister at their home and then shot himself.

Minutes after the shooting, police said the man posted a WhatsApp status in which he alleged he killed his wife because she "cheated on him". The three were identified as Manas Bajpayi, his wife Divya Mishra (34) and his sister Tulika (29).

According to police, Bajpayi reached the bank around noon and called Divya outside. She walked out through the main gate and the two stood talking about 10 metres from the bank.

Mid-conversation, security guards told police, Bajpayi suddenly pulled out a pistol and allegedly shot Divya in the head and chest from close range. As Divya slumped to the ground and the security guards rushed towards her, Bajpayi ran towards the main road and vanished within seconds.

Divya, a relationship manager at ICICI bank, was rushed to Lohia Hospital by staff but was declared dead on arrival.

As the police began investigating the shooting — the bank is barely 500 metres from the Gomti Nagar police station — around the same time, a wireless message alerted them to two bullet-riddled bodies of a man and a woman inside a house around 3 km away in Viram Khand.

Divya Mishra and her husband Manas Bajpayi. Both of them were bankers.

DCP (East) Deeksha Sharma, who was at the bank, rushed to the house along with other officials. The two bodies were identified as those of Bajpayi and his sister. Tulika had suffered two gunshot injuries, while Bajpayi had a bullet injury to his temple.

Police said Bajpayi's neighbour, Akash, rushed to his house after seeing his WhatsApp status. He found the door bolted from inside. By then, neighbours had gathered outside after hearing gunshots.

They forced the door open to find Bajpayi and his sister lying in a pool of blood. The police were alerted thereafter.

Neighbours said Bajpayi was employed with a nationalised bank. Police found an ID card at the house, which showed Bajpayi worked as a senior assistant with SBI in Lucknow's Jankipuram area.

During their preliminary probe, police said Divya's colleagues claimed she was living separately in the Alambagh area for over a year following a marital dispute with her husband.

Mall staffer run over by Aston Martin in Hyderabad, Andhra MP's son booked

26-year-old had stepped outside the mall for lunch when she was run over on August 16; no arrests so far

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, August 20

HYDERABAD POLICE has named Andhra Pradesh Rajya Sabha MP Lingamaneni Ramesh's son, Lingamaneni Sanjush, as an accused in a case related to rash and negligent driving that allegedly led to the death of a 26-year-old sales executive of a mall in Hyderabad last week.

Lingamaneni Ramesh is an MP of Jana Sena Party, which is in a coalition government led by the Telugu Desam Party in Andhra Pradesh. When contacted for comment, Jana Sena spokesperson was unavailable.

Bharati Mukhi, 26, who worked as a sales executive at the Lifestyle store in Inorbit Mall, was killed after being run over by an Aston Martin while crossing the road opposite the mall around 3 pm on August 16, according to the FIR in the case. The police have registered a case against Sanjush under sec tion 106(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS).

Sales Executive Bharati Mukhi

As per the complaint filed by her store manager Panjala Ashwin Kumar, Mukhi and her colleague Pooja Ashok had stepped out to get food when the accident took place. The FIR stated that Sanjush was driving the car at a high speed, and in a rash and negligent manner, and hit Mukhi while she was crossing the road. The woman suffered a bleeding injury to the head, the FIR stated. As per the FIR, Mukhi was shifted in the same car to Apollo Hospital, Jubilee Hills, where doctors declared her brought dead.

When contacted, Madhapur Police told *The Indian Express* that no arrest has been made because the case is "not under a remandable section". "The accused was not driving under the influence of either alcohol or drugs. He has no prior cases too," a police officer, who spoke on the condition of anonymity, told *The Indian Express*.

Sanjush, 21, according to his public profile, is a "director with Black Ridge Energy Private limited" – an energy company. He studied BS Computer Science at the University of Texas, Dallas, it stated.

"There is no arrest in the case because road accident falls under the negligence case, punishment for which is below seven years and it is bailable (offence)," a police officer said.

Section 106(1) of the BNS deals with causing death by a rash or negligent act not amounting to culpable homicide, and leads to imprisonment of up to five years besides a fine.

Madhapur Police confirmed to *The Indian Express* that a notice has been served to the accused in the case.

When contacted, the mall managers said they did not wish to comment on the case. "She was a good girl, always eager to work," a colleague of the deceased told The Indian Express. Mukhi originally hailed from Odisha and was living in Hyderabad with her mother.

'Brewer' among the dead as Gujarat spurious liquor toll reaches seven

Brendan Dabhi
Ahmedabad, August 20

POLICE TEAMS continued to be in damage control mode even as the official death toll due to consumption of spurious liquor in Bhavnagar district reached seven on Thursday.

However, *The Indian Express* has learnt that two more suspected victims have died, but their toxicology and post-mortem reports were awaited.

Bhavnagar District Collector Manish Kumar Bansal on Thursday evening confirmed that seven people who consumed the methanol-laced liquor had died, 32 were still under treatment, and nine others had been discharged from hospitals.

Meanwhile, the police have arrested 13 of the 21 individuals named as accused in the case. As one of the accused fell victim to the spurious liquor and died at a hospital, the police were on the lookout for seven individuals.

The deceased include Upendrasinh Chandrasinh Gohil (25), Kartik Ashwin Makwana (40), Ghanshyamsinh Jaypalsinh Jadeja (49), Kanaksinh Hanubha Gohil (37), Narendrasinh Yadav (47), Jay Jitu Bhatti (35), and Hitesh Dileep Parmar (42).

The latest confirmed death, at the time of writing this report, was on the night of August 19, when police found the body of Hitesh Parmar, a teacher, slumped over in the sitting position by his bed, with a glass of the poisonous liquor spilled on the floor before him. In the kitchen of his one-bedroom apartment in Bhavnagar city, the police found half a bottle of the same brand of IMFL (Indian Made Foreign Liquor), which is said to have been duplicated and filled with the noxious batch of liquor.

Narendrasinh Yadav alias Doctor, one of the seven who died by methanol poisoning, is a co-accused, along with Raees (another brewer) and Gautam Solanki (a Gujarat-based bootlegger and the alleged ringleader of the liquor racket), in the case. Yadav and Raees hail from Madhya Pradesh. Details of their roles were meticulously noted in the FIR filed at Vartej police station on Wednesday.

The FIR, based on a complaint by Inspector SB Padheriya, booked a total of 21 individuals with culpable homicide not amounting to murder among other charges under BNS sections, and provisions of the Prohibition Act.

It stated that Solanki met Raees through an unknown suspect. "Thereafter, Gautam, Raees and Zubair (a resident of Ujjain) went to Ahmedabad to purchase raw materials to make liquor. There, they bought a white liquid, methanol, bottles and stickers, and transported them back to Bhavnagar. The three then made 51 cartons of liquor in the first round, which was sold by Gautam and his brother-in-law Jatin."

It further said, "After destroying the second batch of liquor for its quality, Raees consulted Narendrasinh Yadav to make the third batch, in which they used methanol. They made 25 cartons of this methanol-laced liquor and distributed it among several bootleggers. Gautam Solanki gave six cartons to Paras, three to Sanjay, two to Jaydeep Jivraj Makwana, 13 to Bhargav Kaniyalal Bhatt, and 11 to Vivek Arjan Algotar."

Notably, Yadav, who had brewed the methanol-laced liquor, consumed it himself and died at the Ved Hospital in Bhavnagar on August 18. This was confirmed by the district collector and an investigator from the police's State Monitoring Cell (SMC).

The forensic testing showed that one of the 'IMFL' bottles seized contained 38.59% methanol and only 0.94% ethanol. Methanol is highly toxic to the human body and is not an ingredient in licensed liquor.

The FIR in this case states that this particular batch of methanol-laced liquor was filled into 25 cartons and then distributed by retail bootleggers. At a dozen bottles per carton, the number comes to 300 bottles.

Tarun Tejpal moves SC against conviction in 2013 rape case

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 20

FORMER EDITOR-IN-CHIEF of *Tehelka* magazine, Tarun Tejpal, on Thursday moved the Supreme Court challenging his conviction and 10-year jail term for the 2013 rape of a woman journalist.

The Goa government too had moved the Supreme Court earlier this week seeking an enhancement of his punishment and a life term.

On August 6, the Bombay High Court in Goa had reversed Tejpal's acquittal by a trial court and convicted him for aggravated rape and related offences and awarded him the sentence. It gave him four weeks to surrender.

The case dates back to November 2013. The survivor accused Tejpal of sexually assaulting her on two separate occasions inside the lift of a hotel in Goa while the two were alone during a literary festival. She confided in colleagues the same night and, a week later, emailed a complaint to Tehelka's managing editor seeking an apology and an internal inquiry.

Tejpal responded with two apology emails before the matter became public and a First Information Report was registered. He was tried on charges including rape by a person in a position of trust and dominance, along with assault, sexual harassment, wrongful restraint and confinement.

In May 2021, Tejpal was acquitted of all charges by an additional sessions court in Mapusa. It said the woman's messages to the accused established that she was "neither traumatised nor terrified" and that this "completely belies" the prosecution's case. The Goa government appealed to the high court, which reversed the trial court's conclusions.

The high court, while convicting Tejpal, said that "the trial court proceeded on a notion that a victim of sexual assault must behave in a stereotypical manner". It said the trial court ignored the reality of human coping mechanisms by expecting a survivor to be constantly miserable, meek or visibly broken. "We believe in her plight as a victim who has suffered sexual assault by her superior, whom she has known for many years...," the judgement pointed out.

The high court noted that the appreciation of evidence by the trial court was "not only unreasonable but perverse" and criticised it for permitting an "invasive, humiliating cross-examination into the victim's past sexual history, moral views, and personal WhatsApp messages, directly violating statutory embargoes... that prohibit questioning a victim's character or past relationships".

In its appeal before the Supreme Court, the Goa government called the sentence "manifestly inadequate" and "grossly disproportionate to the nature and gravity of the offences committed". The state said the high court had imposed only the minimum sentence of 10 years' rigorous imprisonment for each of the two aggravated rape convictions, with the sentences to run concurrently.

It urged the Supreme Court to enhance this to imprisonment for life, or such sentence as the court may deem fit, with the same not running concurrently. It also pointed out that the high court had "inter alia, relied upon the fact that 13 years had elapsed since the commission of the offences and that both the victim and the respondent had moved on with their lives, while imposing the minimum sentence and directing the sentences to run concurrently".

It said "such reasoning is untenable" and "the passage of time cannot operate to the benefit of the offender or become a premium for the delay in the administration of justice, particularly at the cost of the victim".

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On J&K, US envoy says it like it is

US AMBASSADOR to India Sergio Gor said in Srinagar that "Kashmir is an important part of India". Washington would consider removing the travel advisory against US citizens visiting J&K, he also said. The substance of his statement can be seen as being in line with Washington's Jammu and Kashmir stand for the better part of three decades. His words, though, must also be read in the current geopolitical context and the ebb and flow of India-US ties in the aftermath of the Pahalgam terror attack and Operation Sindoor. Gor is also US President Donald Trump's Special Envoy for South and Central Asian Affairs and his statement and visit to Srinagar — the first standalone trip by a US ambassador since the abrogation of Article 370 — will be parsed in both Islamabad and Beijing. The Pakistan government has summoned the US chargé d'affaires to express its chagrin at Gor's statement.

Islamabad's attempt to internationalise Kashmir is a tired old trope that has been roundly rejected. Its sponsorship of terror from across the border remains an enduring concern. Between the lines of Gor's message is also an acknowledgement that the India-US relationship will be sensitive to Delhi's concerns about the region. The easing of the travel advisory will send a message about the security gains made post August 2019. Gor's statement also comes after Trump has said, repeatedly, that he played a role in the ceasefire post Op Sindoor — a claim denied by Delhi — and imposed some of the steepest tariffs on India.

The pushback from Pakistan and its lobbyists in Washington is likely to grow. It is important for India not to overreact to this. Notwithstanding the recent turbulence, India-US ties remain deeply consequential for both countries. Neither Delhi nor Washington needs to view the bilateral relationship through a Pakistan-tinted lens. On Kashmir, India's position is clear and unwavering. In fact, just before his meeting with Gor, CM Abdullah put the claims of a US role in the region in perspective: "Our matters are not going to be resolved in Washington; they will be resolved by the government of our country." At the same time, he underlined the many opportunities for cooperation with the US in the local economy. He posted on X that he spoke to the ambassador about "the possibilities that exist to widen & deepen the engagement between J&K & the United States of America, particularly in areas like tourism, horticulture & the new economy".

Buffalo meat exports boom: Read the message

INDIA'S BUFFALO meat exports are booming, hitting a record $5.1 billion in 2025-26 and set to cross $6 billion in the current fiscal year. Credit goes to the industry that has built a market in countries from Southeast and West Asia to Africa and, more recently, Uzbekistan, Russia and Georgia. Moreover, unit value realisations have gone up from sub-$3,000 to $4,000-plus per tonne over the last two-three years, amid concerted efforts at raising the product profile of Indian buffalo meat, and not selling it as just a cheaper alternative to regular cattle beef. This has been helped by adherence to internationally recognised quality and hygiene standards and exports being allowed only through government-approved abattoirs and processing plants.

But equally important is how the buffalo meat industry has been complementary to India's dairy sector. The buffaloes that are culled are mostly animals not giving enough milk or those that happen to be male. For farmers, the fodder, feed, water and labour that go towards maintaining them has a direct as well as an opportunity cost — in terms of the loss of potential output from not allocating the same resources to more productive bovines. By creating a market for unproductive buffaloes, the meat plants have enabled farmers to replace low-yielding/ageing animals with high-milking/fresh stock. Such regular herd turnover is essential for any viable dairy enterprise. The very fact that the buffaloes going to the slaughterhouse aren't competing for scarce resources with the ones giving milk makes this a more sustainable model. Unlike in Brazil or the US, where cattle are reared separately for milk and beef, here the meat is from "spent" buffaloes that have outlived their usefulness as milkers.

Consumption of milk, especially high-fat, is growing in India on the back of rising incomes. The support to buffalo milk production from meat exports is, therefore, welcome. But buffalo milk yields are lower compared to that from crossbred cows. Their age at first lactation and inter-calving intervals is also longer. To that extent, buffaloes alone cannot supply India's increasing milk requirement from a medium-to-long-term perspective. All the more reason why a scientific approach to culling unproductive animals — whether for breeding and reproductive efficiency or redirecting finite resources to higher-yielding stock — is necessary in cattle, too. The political leadership cannot run away from taking that call.

This season, EPL heralds a new era

THE ENGLISH Premier League is unlikely to pause to shed a tear for the past. The nostalgia induced by the farewell of Pep Guardiola, the most influential manager of his era, and the exodus of his midfield stars, or the departure of Mohamed Salah, one of the finest wingers of all time, will be overtaken by the excitements of the season that unfolds from Saturday night. It will seem like a new product; nine new managers, and a raft of impressionable young footballers who have switched clubs or taken the plunge in the world's most competitive league.

This season will witness the making of themes and narratives that will define the league in the next half a decade, the filling of voids, a sense of renewal and a quest for the new order. The abiding narrative will be whether Arsenal can defend their title and build a success story like Manchester City. The Gunners have bolstered their midfield and back-line, but there are more lethal front-lines in the league. Both the Manchester neighbours — City and United — have exhilarating attack options. Chelsea, Liverpool and Tottenham Hotspur have acquired experience-rich players who could pose stiff hurdles for Arsenal. The unglamorous posse of Brighton, Aston Villa, and Bournemouth makes the league more competitive and interesting.

Most of the top six are transitioning, the league is moving on from the Guardiola era, new managers will instil fresh tactics, making the edition the most unpredictable and presumably most open campaign in recent times. Picking an outright favourite would be foolish. Arsenal could be the slight favourites, given their core's stability and experience. But this season has the vibe of a new era. The field is set, let the winning begin.

Modi-ism must evolve into institution-centred nation-building

AMARINDER SINGH

EVERY POLITICAL era eventually acquires a name. "Modi-ism" is India's name for the political and governing order built around Narendra Modi: A commanding leader, disciplined party organisation, civilisational assertion, centralised decision-making, technology-driven welfare, infrastructure-led development, high-energy national security and direct communication with citizens. It is a method of acquiring power, exercising authority and defining the nation. Its central promise is unmistakable: A strong leader, a purposeful state and a stronger India.

Its political achievement cannot be disputed. Modi transformed the BJP from a major national formation into the central axis of Indian politics. He expanded it beyond its traditional geographical and social constituencies and made leadership itself the principal electoral proposition. In 2024, however, the BJP fell to 240 seats and required its NDA partners to form the government. That verdict did not reject Modi. It qualified his mandate. The country chose continuity, but also restored the relevance of consultation, coalition and restraint.

Modi-ism has produced visible public gains. Infrastructure construction, digital public platforms, direct benefit transfers, financial inclusion, sanitation, housing, electrification and welfare delivery at scale have strengthened the state's capacity to reach citizens. It has also contained somewhat the undue proliferation of regional politics. NITI Aayog estimated multidimensional poverty at 11.28 per cent in 2022-23, compared with 29.17 per cent in 2013-14. The methodology may be debated, but the improvement in delivery cannot honestly be dismissed.

Its appeal rests equally on political clarity. Modi-ism speaks in the language of aspiration, national confidence and civilisational recovery. For citizens long frustrated by delay, indecision and fragmented authority, a government promising speed and scale has obvious appeal.

Yet effectiveness cannot be the only test of democratic government.

The more consequential question is whether Modi-ism remains securely anchored in the country's constitutional settlement. Its critics allege that the Modi era seeks to weaken pluralism, dilute socialism, replace rights with governmental charity, capture institutions and ultimately alter the Constitution. Its supporters dismiss these charges as partisan hostility towards Modi or resistance to India's cultural resurgence.

Both positions are too absolute. The constitutional character of a government must be judged through the actual exercise of power, not through slogans or unevidenced perceptions.

Elections continue to be fiercely competitive. Governments change in the states. Opposition parties govern substantial parts of the country. Courts continue to examine executive action and enforce fundamental rights. In November 2024, the Supreme Court rejected petitions challenging the inclusion of "socialist" and "secular" in the Preamble. It would therefore be inaccurate to claim that the country's constitutional order has been dismantled.

But a Constitution can be weakened without its words being formally deleted. Institutions may remain intact on paper while their independence, credibility and conventions erode. Democracy is sustained not merely by periodic elections, but by restraints on power, respect for dissent, parliamentary accountability, federal balance and equal citizenship.

The concern about pluralism is not that religious freedom has been legally abolished. It is that majoritarian mobilisation and inflammatory language can make minorities feel conditionally accepted. Cultural nationalism is constitutionally legitimate; cultural supremacy is not.

The country may proudly acknowledge its Hindu civilisational inheritance. But the republic belongs, without qualification, to every citizen. Equal citizenship cannot depend upon religion, political loyalty or conformity with a preferred account of national identity.

Socialism also requires a more intelligent debate. Our constitutional socialism does not demand a return to the licence-permit raj, hostility to private enterprise or indiscriminate state ownership. It requires social and economic justice, equality of opportunity and protection against degrading deprivation.

Many Modi-era welfare programmes advance these constitutional purposes. The problem begins when statutory entitlements are politically presented as personal gifts from a leader. Food support, employment guarantees, housing, scholarships and social security are not acts of generosity. They are public obligations, financed by citizens and delivered under law.

Rights-based governance must, therefore, complement, not be displaced by, beneficiary politics. Technology can reduce leakage and accelerate delivery. But citizens excluded by failed authentication, inaccurate databases or administrative discretion must have accessible remedies. Welfare requires enforceable standards, grievance redress, social audits and legislative scrutiny.

A citizen must remain a rights-holder, not be reduced to a grateful beneficiary.

The allegation of institutional capture must similarly be examined with evidence rather than rhetoric. Every elected government is entitled to govern, make lawful appointments and implement its programme. But institutional autonomy depends not merely upon technical legality. It also requires transparent appointments, procedural fairness and visible distance from partisan command.

Here the record raises legitimate concerns. During the seventeenth Lok Sabha, 58 per cent of bills were passed within two weeks of introduction, and only 16 per cent were referred to parliamentary committees. On average, around 80 per cent of the Union Budget was voted without discussion between 2019 and 2023.

The SC decision striking down the electoral bond scheme established that secrecy in political funding had crossed a constitutional boundary. The law governing the appointment of election commissioners, which gives the executive a majority on the selection committee, has similarly raised concerns about perceived independence. These concerns do not establish that every institution has been captured. But they demonstrate why independence must be protected not only in fact, but also in public perception.

> Parliament must recover serious deliberation, committee scrutiny. Federal consultation must precede major decisions affecting the states

Should Modi-ism continue? Its productive core should.

The country needs decisive and strong leadership, national confidence, infrastructure, digital innovation, credible defence capability and measurable delivery. But Modi-ism must now evolve from leader-centred mobilisation into institution-centred nation-building.

That transition requires clear corrections. Parliament must recover serious deliberation, committee scrutiny and control over public expenditure. Federal consultation must precede major decisions affecting the states. Appointments to constitutional and regulatory bodies should command cross-party credibility. Investigative agencies must be demonstrably even-handed. Welfare delivery must be joined to enforceable rights. Political discourse must replace habitual polarisation with constitutional fraternity. Development's next phase must create productive employment, competitive manufacturing, stronger small enterprises, higher farm incomes, quality public education, accessible healthcare, liveable cities and climate resilience.

The BJP itself must institutionalise its success. No durable national party can remain indefinitely dependent upon one personality, however formidable. It needs empowered ministers, credible regional leaders, internal debate and an orderly culture of succession.

Modi-ism has given India energy, ambition and a stronger international voice. Its historical value, however, will not be measured by one leader's dominance or one party's electoral reach. The choice is not between Modi and the Constitution. It is between a Modi-ism disciplined by the Constitution, and one that seeks to rise above it.

The country does not need a weaker government. It needs strong leadership restrained by stronger institutions, serving citizens who are equal in dignity, secure in their rights and confident in their common future.

The writer, former chief minister of Punjab, is in the BJP

Why some brands fade away, why others don't

MADHU BHAVARAJU

CAMPA COLA, a soft-drink brand from the 1980s now owned by Reliance, is giving Coke and Pepsi a run for their money. Onida of "Neighbour's Envy, Owner's Pride" is apparently planning a big comeback. Whereas "Chal Meri Luna" or "Gold Spot — The Zing Thing" are just memories of a past era. The world of business is littered with names that evoke nostalgia, but the brands are no longer there or are shadows of their past glory. Regulations, technology, economics or culture can kill brands. There are fascinating examples of this in India.

The Luna story is about economic change. There was a time when it was India's multi-purpose two-wheeler — from the local businessman carrying his goods to a family of four rushing to work or school. This made enormous sense as incomes were low and cars were not easy to buy. As the economy grew, more people could afford motorcycles or cars. Luna's value proposition was lost.

Dalda represents a different kind of decline. Vanaspati once stood for affordability and convenience and, although this may be hard to believe today, a modern way of cooking. Nutritional science evolved, consumers grew suspicious of hydrogenated fats, and the product's cultural setting changed.

BPL, Videocon, Solidaire and Onida were consumer electronics giants in India at one time, commanding a huge market share. But global supply chains, Korean brands, falling prices of electronics and rapidly evolving technology changed that competitive structure. I really hope Onida makes a comeback, but the technology gap between an LG or a Samsung and Onida will take time to bridge.

Then there is the Ambassador. For years it represented the Indian automobile, status, power and bureaucracy. Then came the upstart Maruti, and eventually global carmakers with better technology, reliability and efficiency. Hindustan Motors kept chugging away, but eventually struggled in this new competitive environment.

Regulations can create an artificial ecosystem which collapses as soon as the regulations are lifted. The Ambassador might not have survived if not for India having a closed economy. The same is true for Gold Spot or a Citra. The soft drink brands of India in the 1970s and '80s were a direct byproduct of India not allowing Coke and Pepsi to operate. Once Coke and Pepsi entered India again, these brands quickly faded away.

There are, of course, exceptions. Campa Cola went the same way as Gold Spot or Citra until Reliance took over. There was some brand equity even after decades of decline, which Reliance identified and used to enter the soft beverages market in India.

Thums Up and Limca survived. My theory is that these two beverages were unique. Thums Up's extra punch and cult following made it difficult for Coca-Cola to drop. Limca is a unique cloudy lemon drink unlike clear lemon drinks such as Sprite or 7 UP.

These exceptions may just be one-offs. Nostalgia alone is not enough, though; both Campa Cola and Onida need a strong reason to exist today in the 2020s.

Some brands evolve and move to new categories. Kinetic Motors, the makers of Luna, launched the Kinetic Honda in the 1980s, a very popular two-wheeler. The Kinetic Honda was more powerful, had storage and an electric starter, which was an evolution from the very basic Luna.

The mistake successful brands make is assuming that yesterday's success proves something permanent about the brand. Often, it only proves something about that moment in time. Consumers, technologies, regulations and aspirations change. The brand that survives is the one that keeps finding a reason to be relevant.

> The mistake successful brands make is assuming that yesterday's success proves something permanent about the brand. Often, it only proves something about that moment in time

The writer is founder, The Brand Ignition Co

Climate resilience starts with the health workforce

PRIYANKA TOMAR

FLOODS IN Kerala and Assam have once again exposed the challenge of protecting lives during climate-related disasters. The immediate focus shifts to rescue operations, relief camps and rebuilding damaged infrastructure. Less visible, but equally critical, is the work unfolding within public health systems. Hospitals are preparing for medical emergencies, surveillance teams are monitoring disease outbreaks, labs are testing water quality, community health-workers are reaching vulnerable households, and public-health officials are coordinating responses across departments. It is the health workforce that prevents a natural disaster from becoming a prolonged public-health crisis.

The resilience of health systems ultimately depends on the workforce that delivers adaptation. States have begun to strengthen surveillance systems, develop region- and city-specific heat action plans, improve emergency preparedness, and integrate climate considerations into several public-health programmes. Kerala's response to the floods illustrates how health departments are increasingly incorporating public-health measures into disaster response. As climate-related hazards become more frequent, can these capacities be sustained across all states, districts, and levels of the health system? How can these surge capacities be developed, given the severe shortage of health workers across India? Are these capacities being embedded across the health workforce, or do they continue to depend on individual relief-specific programmes and emergency mobilisation?

Many of the foundational competencies required for climate adaptation already exist within health systems. What is changing is the context in which they must now operate. Rather than replacing existing competencies, climate change requires reorienting them through a climate lens while introducing new competencies where needed. Analysis of climate-health governance across South and Southeast Asia indicates that workforce development remains fragmented, with climate-health training largely confined to donor- or project-supported initiatives.

Building climate-resilient health systems requires moving beyond isolated training programmes towards institutionalising climate-health competencies. These should be integrated into pre-service education, professional development, supportive supervision, planning, and performance management and must be supported by sustained governance, financing, and institutional mechanisms so that knowledge can be translated into routine practice rather than activated only during emergencies.

> Analysis of climate-health governance across South and Southeast Asia indicates that workforce development remains fragmented, with training largely confined to donor- or project-supported initiatives

The writer is a health systems researcher at CSEP. Views are personal

40 YEARS AGO
AUGUST 21, 1986

INDIAN EXPRESS
Twenty-point plan re-structured
War on poverty first priority
Rail stations burnt in Pak

New 20-point plan

A NEW 20-point programme focussing emphasis on the removal of poverty in rural areas and promising new programmes for youth and women was announced by the Central Government. The restructured programme shows a clear shift in priorities from industry to agriculture.

Rail stations burnt in Pakistan

TROOPS PATROLLED troubled areas in Sindh province and anti-government protesters burnt railway stations and blocked road and rail traffic on the third day of the nationwide agitation of the opposition parties to oust President Zia-ul-Haq. The protests were also directed at last week's government crackdown on agitators, which resulted in violence and claimed more than 50 lives.

Reagan on Nicaragua

PRESIDENT REAGAN has said that unless the Nicaraguan government sought democracy, the "only alternative" for the rebels would be "to have their way and take over". This is the bluntest and most explicit statement ever made by the President about the ultimate goal of US policy in Nicaragua, the aim of the administration in aiding the Nicaraguan rebels. It was made to a Mexican newspaper during an interview conducted from the President's holiday ranch in California.

Punjab writes off farmers' debt

THE PUNJAB government has written off Rs 300 crore due from farmers as water course lining charges and remission in the jail terms of prisoners in memory of Sant Harchand Singh Longowal, the late Akali Dal president whose first death anniversary was observed at a state-sponsored function in Sangrur.

WHAT THE OTHERS SAY
Stop Smotrich before he dooms the Palestinians and the State of Israel
— Haaretz, Israel

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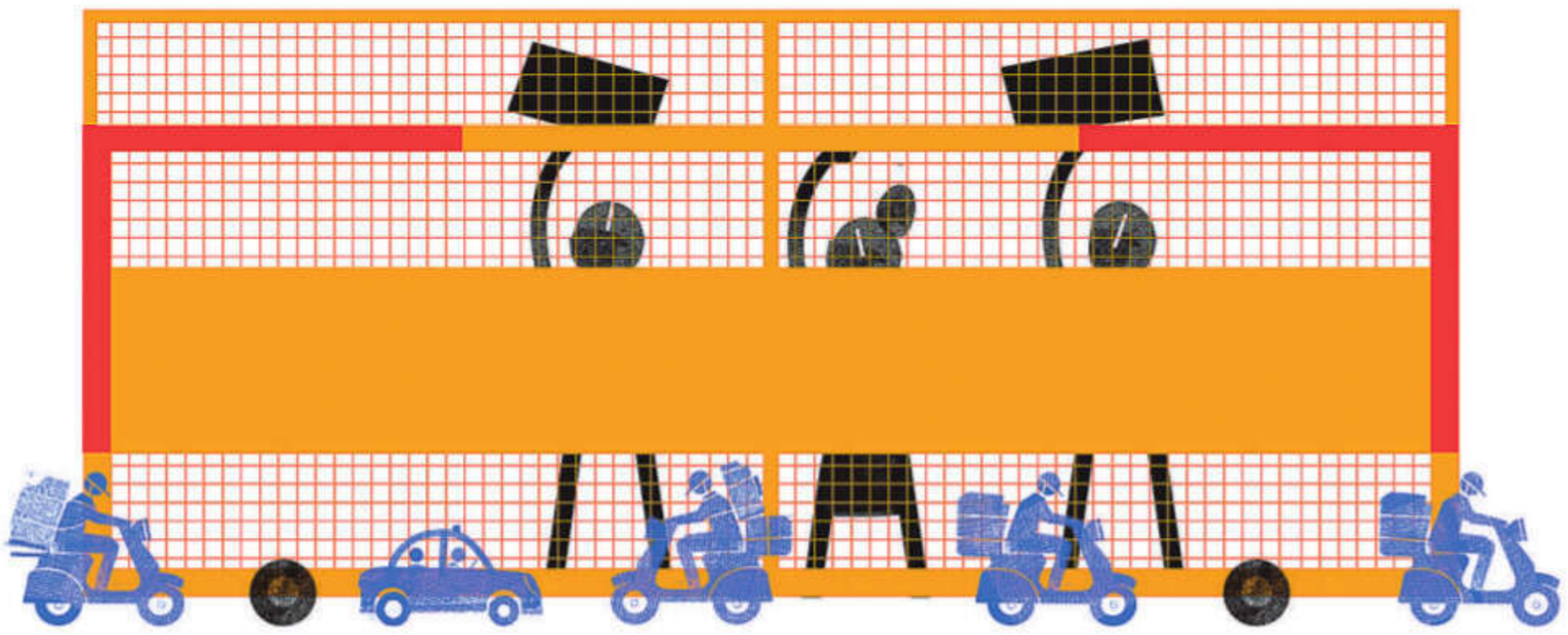

ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

A month after the march from Jantar Mantar to Parliament, looking back and ahead at Gen Z

This is not the end. They will be back

NAJEEB JUNG

AFTER 36 days at Jantar Mantar, the students wound down, leaving behind a dazed government, its leadership confused, and a police machinery exposed as brutal, lacking the sensitivity the moment required. Watching the boys and girls pack up their belongings and fold their cotton sheets, I thought of Iqbal's couplet: *maana ki teri diid ke qabil nahin huun main/tu mera shauq dekh mira intizar dekh* (Granted that I am not worthy of your sight / Look instead at my deep zeal and my endless waiting). As they moved out of Jantar Mantar, their resolve was palpable. This was not the end. They would be back.

Every major mass movement in India over the last century has organised itself around a moral authority: Gandhi, Jayaprakash Narayan, Anna Hazare. The Cockroach movement inverted this template. Its founder is a young man skilled at communications, not a moral authority. Its closest thing to a unifying figure, Sonam Wangchuk, was an ally who lent his hunger strike to a cause he did not create. What emerged instead is a distributed structure — social-media accounts, campus unions, Left student federations — moving in loose, non-hierarchical coordination. Its organisational logic makes a singular leader almost unnecessary for mobilisation. Having said that, one may eventually be necessary for consolidation.

A leaderless structure is hard for the state to decapitate. But diffusion has a cost. Coalitions without a centre struggle to negotiate coherently, to discipline internal tactical disagreement, and to convert a moment of mobilisation into an institution. India Against Corruption, unlike the Aam Aadmi Party it produced, never built that institutional layer. Whether anyone is building an equivalent beneath the Cockroach movement's surface is the most important open question.

The state fields cadre strength, a police and paramilitary apparatus, and financial resources no youth movement funded by small donations can match. When protestors tried to march on Parliament, the police response left over 100 injured and dozens arrested, with the record showing violence running in one direction only. But this did not produce the outcome coercive dominance is supposed to guarantee. Within days, the government conceded the central demand. This separates two things routinely conflated: The state's capacity to repress and its capacity to prevail. That should disprove any simple story in which coercive machinery automatically wins.

A single resignation is a low-cost concession. Systemic exam reform, large-scale job creation, or accountability for the crackdown are much harder fiscally and politically. The distinction that matters most for durability is between a movement fuelled by scandal and one fuelled by structural condition. The NEET leak was a trigger, not a cause. Underneath it sits a labour market that cannot absorb the graduates it produces, an examination and recruitment system widely perceived as corruptible, and a rural unemployment crisis that draws less media attention than its urban counterpart but is arguably deeper and more intractable.

The insult that named the movement landed because it confirmed what a generation already suspected: That the system discounts merit in favour of proximity to power and capital. On this reading, the Cockroach movement is less a single episode than a recurring condition that has, for now, found a name and a shared vocabulary. That gives it a resilience no single leader could provide.

Two conclusions follow. First, the movement has already outperformed what its lack of centralised leadership would predict. Second, extracting one concession through a low-cost demand is a different task from sustaining pressure on a structural condition with no single remediable trigger. The latter tests whether a leaderless coalition can maintain coherence and pressure over years, a capacity the movement has not yet had occasion to demonstrate.

For now, the odds favour the young. The government has shown no evident plan for handling this beyond force: A ham-handed approach paired with the hope that overwhelming pressure will deter the youth is likely to misfire, and appointing a committee whose composition is unpalatable to the protestors solves nothing. What is needed is a return to the drawing board. The alternative is a Union entering a long, dark winter of discontent with a generation it has not learned how to answer.

The writer is chairman, Advanced Study Institute of Asia, former Lt Governor, Delhi, and former vice chancellor, Jamia Millia Islamia

The Gen Z that wasn't at Jantar Mantar

PARTHA SINHA

THERE WAS something unusually photogenic about Gen Z at Jantar Mantar. Young, articulate, angry and, crucially, quotable. They understood that a placard must travel beyond the barricade, that irony survives Instagram better than ideology. The internet fell in love. Here, finally, was a generation refusing the ancient Indian instruction to the young: Wait your turn.

But there was another Gen Z missing from the photographs. He was probably delivering dinner to someone watching the protest on their phone. He is 22, financing a motorcycle on debt he doesn't fully understand, called a "partner" by an app that can deactivate him without ever meeting him. When it rains, his incentives rise, because the city has learnt to price his risk more precisely than his labour. There is a rather elegant cruelty in calling this freedom. Outside stands a security guard protecting a lifestyle he can see but not enter. In a village is a young man who can watch a Stanford lecture for free and has no idea what job he will do next year. His imagination has migrated. His life chances have not.

"Gen Z" assumes a liberal-arts student in Delhi, a warehouse packer outside Gurugram and a UPSC aspirant in Bihar share something meaningful because they were born in the same 15 years. They do. They share visibility without access.

India has never lacked inequality; what has changed is the technology of experiencing it. The farmer knew the landlord lived better; he did not begin breakfast watching the landlord's holiday in the Maldives. The smartphone abolished the rationing of comparison. Sociologist Robert Merton gave us the "reference group": The people against whom we measure our lives. A farmhand can now compare himself with a Dubai apartment and a Silicon Valley Sunday brunch, delivered more reliably than his crop forecast. Gen Z has been given the entire planet to envy. Arjun Appadurai called it the "capacity to aspire": Not merely wanting a different future, but knowing the routes to reach it. The capacity to imagine has been democratised at internet speed. The capacity to navigate has not. We have mass-produced aspiration without its scaffolding.

The sneaker, the café, the start-up vocabulary are no longer possessions. They are signifiers in a national grammar of having arrived. Consumption has become biography. You are continuously shown the version of yourself you have failed to become. Desire travels at 5G speed. Social mobility still takes the passenger train. For two decades India has spoken of its "demographic dividend", as though youth were an asset that pays out automatically. Perhaps the metaphor was wrong. A young population is better understood as a loan, capital advanced against a future that has to be built to repay it. Loans, unlike dividends, can default.

The gig economy makes this visible. The old industrial bargain was crude but legible: sell your labour, and time slowly converts into standing. The platform economy removed that mechanism and replaced it with the language of entrepreneurship. You are a "partner" whose hours convert mainly into more hours, dressed up as autonomy.

When the economic route to status narrows, another economy opens: The economy of dignity. Religion, nationalism, caste, an online tribe can provide status that a salary cannot. A young man cannot change his salary, but he can change his avatar. A society that cannot offer its young enough ladders should not be surprised when identity begins to look like one. None of this was visible at Jantar Mantar. The protesters possessed something rarer than anger: A vocabulary for it. Most anger never gets that far — there is the rider at the gate, the guard beside it, the graduate refreshing an examination-results page.

Are they unhappy? Perhaps happiness is too frivolous a diagnostic. The better question is whether they believe the future is negotiable. Every generation tolerates hardship when it looks like a corridor. The trouble begins when it starts looking like a room. The young people at Jantar Mantar had completed a journey: From disappointment to language, from anger to demand. Millions of their contemporaries are still somewhere between the first two. We have spent years celebrating young India because it is connected, ambitious and impatient. We may discover the third adjective was the important one. Jantar Mantar gave the microphone to one Gen Z. The rest are still delivering the microphones to our doors.

The writer is a senior advisory professional

Why Sergio Gor's words in Srinagar are noteworthy

AMITABH MATTOO

RARELY DOES history hinge on a few words. But when US Ambassador Sergio Gor visited Srinagar earlier this week and declared, "This is an important part of India," he was signalling the end of an era. It was his first visit to the Valley, and he had just finished meeting Chief Minister Omar Abdullah. He followed up the statement by suggesting that the US travel advisory could be reviewed by Washington because of improvements in the security situation. There was an irony no one seemed to have noticed. Seventy-three years ago, American emissaries came to the Valley to whisper the possibilities of independence to Sheikh Abdullah. On August 19, an American ambassador, with the Sheikh's grandson standing beside him, seemed to have ended all ambiguity about the American position on Jammu and Kashmir.

A statement by an ambassador is not definitive. It is not a treaty, a presidential proclamation, or even a formal repudiation by the State Department of every position Washington has espoused since 1947. But diplomacy is about vocabulary, and no objective student of Kashmir can fail to notice how far America has come. Almost exactly 73 years ago, on August 9, 1953, Sheikh Abdullah was dismissed as prime minister of Jammu and Kashmir by Sadr-i-Riyasat Karan Singh, amid mounting suspicions in New Delhi about his commitment to the accession and his growing interest in an independent Kashmir. His contacts with prominent Americans fed those suspicions and later became part of the political atmosphere surrounding what came to be known as the Kashmir Conspiracy Case.

Earlier, in 1950, Loy Henderson, the American ambassador to India, secretly met Abdullah in Kashmir twice. Henderson's secret telegram records the Sheikh making a strong case for Kashmiri independence from both India and Pakistan. Abdullah told Henderson that an independent Kashmir could survive only if it had the friendship of India and Pakistan and economic assistance from the US, directly or through the UN. Soon enough, American interest in Kashmir took on such political overtones that even Henderson's wife made it into Indian political mythology. Indian leaders suspected that Americans were holding out the prospect of independence to Abdullah.

Then came Adlai Stevenson in May 1953. Twice the Democratic Party's candidate for the presidency, Stevenson was one of the most influential American internationalists of his era. He visited Kashmir and talked to Abdullah. Those meetings sent shockwaves of suspicion through New Delhi. Indian leaders believed Stevenson may also have encouraged Abdullah to think about an independent Kashmir. American diplomatic records show that Nehru believed Stevenson's conversations had encouraged Abdullah's growing intransigence. But the point is less to revive conspiracy theories about 1953. More important is that "independent Kashmir" was then conceivable enough in American diplomatic parlance for Nehru to worry that Washington might act to encourage it.

These apprehensions were rooted in the genesis of the Kashmir problem. UN Security Council Resolution 47, which America supported in 1948, placed the dispute in an international context and anticipated a plebiscite after a process of demilitarisation. The prescribed sequence, which required Pakistan to secure the withdrawal of the "tribal invaders" from the territory under its occupation, was never implemented. But for years afterwards, the resolution provided Pakistan with the diplomatic scaffolding it wanted: J&K was not an Indian question alone; it was an international dispute to be settled. America was at the centre of that scaffolding.

In fact, American thinking went much further in those early years. Take this State Department memo from February 1950: Describing Jammu and Kashmir's accession to India as "contested", it concluded that "in our legal assessment at the time... the Maharaja's Instrument of Accession could not by itself have finally settled the state's future".

This thinking continued well after the Cold War was over. In October 1993, Robin Raphel, freshly minted assistant secretary of state for South Asian Affairs in the Clinton administration, called Kashmir a "disputed territory" and said Washington did not recognise the legal validity of the Instrument of Accession as meaning that Kashmir was forever part of India. India was aghast. Prime Minister P V Narasimha Rao called such efforts at diplomatic suasion "pinpricks and minor mischief".

But the larger fact that emerged was this: Nearly five decades after 1947, the US was unwilling to couch its discussion of Jammu and Kashmir in terms that accepted India's political description of the state without qualification. That is what makes Gor's description in Srinagar in 2026 so noteworthy. The venue matters as much as the words he used, and not surprisingly, Pakistan did not just protest, but lodged a formal demarche.

That does not mean New Delhi should start conducting itself triumphantly. Our case in Kashmir has ultimately been made most strongly by the people of J&K. And the test has always been India's ability to deepen constitutionalism, expand democracy and political reconciliation, deliver development and ensure civil liberties for all citizens. That is why Srinagar's elected government matters. And why a return to normal democratic politics and restoration of statehood is essential.

But we should not downplay what has occurred. For there is a historical arc here that is quite remarkable. It reflects India's own transformation and the gradual exhaustion of the idea that Jammu and Kashmir is best handled through international mechanisms conceived in the bloodshed of Partition. America has not overwritten history. Gor signalled something far more important: It accepts reality. For decades, Washington dealt with Kashmir as if it were a problem in search of a permanent political resting place. In Srinagar earlier this week, it implicitly acknowledged that history had already made a choice.

The writer is dean and professor, SIS, JNU and former vice-chancellor, University of Jammu

A cancellation & questions on freedom

CHAITY DAS

ADMITTEDLY, HOW many of us remember Independence Day speeches at school or on television in childhood? With children growing restless, squirming in humid classrooms and auditoriums, like in D H Lawrence's 'Last Lesson of the Afternoon', an educator sometimes wonders what it is all for. Yet, by means of a word here, a phrase there, absorbed osmotically from family, teachers, leaders, friends, children are shaped. Experiences and memories etch themselves. A republic is moulded.

So, when an Independence Day speech in a school is cancelled, students of all ages ask: Why? Undeniably, nothing is more important than the well-being of children. Students concur. Guardians of all hues of beliefs and opinions, though troubled about the future, understand.

Meanwhile, in buses, outside the school as children walk past you, in homes through the evening, comes the next question. Why is our security an issue? By then they have heard the news from friends, read the press reports. Internet searches are conducted on who was supposed to have delivered the speech. They discuss it with friends, learn that it had to be cancelled due to some individuals unrelated to their institution objecting to the guest's presence. With more information, they now exchange views with peers. Intense debates ensue. Their curiosity — *jigyasa* — is aroused, certainly more by the incident than by what the speech itself may have generated. Something momentous and without precedent has happened.

In the morning, unaware of these facts, they have sung patriotic songs, watched the flag being hoisted, joyously sung the national anthem and participated in a significant collective ritual. Student leaders have spoken movingly of the freedom struggle. Anecdotally and artistically, they revive the luminous values of liberty — *jigyasa, samvaad, karuna, kartavya*.

Perhaps, prophetically, they have also spoken of the need to overcome fear. And bits and pieces of the previous morning are conjured when our Prime Minister cautions from the Red Fort to remain vigilant against the fear-mongers in our midst. Do they then not realise why the speech had to be cancelled? And when they are being reassured that fear is the enemy of truth, how are they to process the "why"?

When William Blake said, "without contraries, there is no progression", he was speaking of Western society and the hatred of opposites that stunts its greatness. In 'The Poison Tree', incidentally part of CBSE syllabi, he wrote: "I was angry with my friend;/ I told my wrath, my wrath did end./ I was angry with my foe:/ I told it not, my wrath did grow."

Arguably, this fear of opposites is a colonial legacy, heightened by the experience of modernity and how different cultures have responded to it. This has manifested itself more in political discourse than in the organic rhythms of ordinary life. Sant Kabir Das, too, spoke of the prisons of duality and the need to transcend them through experience. Silencing what appears "contrary", whether an illusion or a necessity, plants poison trees in our hearts.

This postcolonial anxiety and mechanism of polarisation of opposites enshackle our freedom in academic spaces and create an impoverished discourse where "right" and "left" are raised as spectres and imposed on the fluid stream of thought. The disturbing incident on August 14, when a speech had to be cancelled in a Delhi school, provides a unique opportunity of *samvaad* in families, classrooms and larger public spaces to inspire our children to reflect on the interminable journeys of Independence.

The writer teaches at Delhi University and is a Sardar Patel Vidyalaya parent

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Caste counting

A CASTE census can provide useful evidence for better-targeted welfare and public policy, but numbers alone cannot address social inequality ('Count caste by all means. But abandon belief that counting settles anything', *IE*, August 20). The exercise should follow uniform definitions, strict confidentiality and transparent methodology. The government should combine the data with economic, educational and regional indicators while ensuring that policies remain focused on genuine deprivation and opportunity.

Abbharna Barathi, Chennai

Party rejig

BRINGING YOUNGER leaders into organisational positions is useful, but generational change should mean more than a change of faces ('A younger BJP, but not a very different one', *IE*, August 20). Young workers should receive genuine responsibility and opportunities to shape policy and communication. The party must remain responsive to concerns over employment, education and institutional accountability. Internal consultation with students, professionals and local communities could improve its understanding of changing expectations.

S P Suganya Devi, Coimbatore

AI for teens

YOUNG PEOPLE increasingly use AI for learning, but unrestricted dependence can weaken judgement and independent thinking ('ChatGPT for Teens is step forward. It's not enough', *IE*, August 20). Schools and parents should teach students how to verify information, protect personal data and recognise misleading answers. Platforms must provide age-appropriate safeguards and clear reporting mechanisms. Schools could introduce practical AI-literacy lessons so that students learn both its usefulness and its limitations.

S M Jeeva, Chennai

Hotel fire: One held, 2 detained; Kolkata building sealed due to safety lapses

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, August 20

THE KOLKATA police made their first arrest in connection with the Mirza Ghalib Street fire late Wednesday night, as the West Bengal Fire and Emergency Services ordered the hotel building that caught fire to be immediately vacated and sealed due to inadequate fire safety measures.

The Detective Department arrested Abu Zafar, the leaseholder of hotel Shikha Inn, where the blaze led to nine deaths Wednesday morning.

The police have also detained two staff members: a manager and an employee from the neighbouring Japon Hotel. Both Shikha Inn and Japon Hotel are owned by Bireshwar Mitra, who is absconding.

Meanwhile, police on Thursday identified two other deceased. According to a statement by the Kolkata Police, two of the nine who had died in the fire have been identified as S.M Alimuzzaman (48), and Repoti Sarakar (41). Both are Bangladeshi nationals.

CJP PROTESTS AGAINST NEET PAPER LEAK

Former SC judge-led panel to probe 'police excesses' against protesters

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, August 20

FORMER SUPREME Court judge R Subhash Reddy will head the High-Powered Enquiry Committee (HPEC) constituted by the Supreme Court to look into alleged excesses and disproportionate use of force by police and security personnel at Jantar Mantar and at other locations across the country during last month's protests in the wake of the NEET(UG) paper leak.

The top court appointed former Punjab and Haryana High Court Chief Justice Ravi Shankar Jha, former Delhi HC judge Justice Shalinder Kaur, former CBI Director Rishi Kumar Shukla and retired Director General of Police, Meghalaya, L R Bishnoi as its members.

Taking into consideration the suggestions given by the petitioners and the respondents, a three-judge bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana set out the issues that the HPEC will look into.

1. Alleged use of excessive force and violence against protesters by police authorities and other agencies. The allegations include deployment of pellet guns, electric batons, lathi charges and tear gas without adequate warning or proportionality, resulting in severe bodily harm and injuries, some of which are alleged to be of "grievous and lasting nature".

2. The question of ensuring a proportionate and measured police response during protests, public gatherings, and peaceful assemblies, so as to strike an appropriate balance between maintaining public order and exercising constitutional right to peaceful dissent.

3. The desirability of banning the use of metallic kinetic projectiles or pellets fired from pump-action rifles or projectile-action guns, having regard to the grave and, at times, irreversible bodily harm occasioned by their deployment against protesters.

4. The necessity of ensuring that police and security personnel wear proper uniforms and visible nameplates at the time of effecting arrests or using force during crowd-control operations, so as to secure accountability and enable the identification of individual officers.

5. Allegations pertaining to the monitoring and surveillance of protesters by police personnel, and the extent to which such measures, if undertaken, were consistent with the protesters' constitutional rights to privacy and free assembly.

6. The alleged incidents of targeted violence, harassment, molestation and/or any secondary victimisation directed against female protesters, which, given the gravity and sensitivity of the allegations, warrant a focused and expeditious enquiry.

7. The provision of medical and other requisite support, including award of compensation, to victims of alleged police abuse, including the manner and adequacy of such support extended thus far.

8. Regulation of the issuance of blanket prohibitory orders under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023, so as to prevent their use as a routine or preemptive measure that forecloses the exercise of the right to peaceful assembly rather than as a genuine, proportionate response to a real and imminent threat to public order.

9. The establishment of strict constitutional thresholds and safeguards to prevent Section 152 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023 from being invoked as an instrument to stifle political dissent and peaceful protest, thereby ensuring that the provision remains confined to its intended purpose and is not permitted to operate as a chilling restraint upon constitutionally protected speech and assembly.

10. Alleged use of force and violence by protesters against police officers and other security personnel.

11. The damage to public property on account of the actions of the protesters during the course of the said demonstrations, including the destruction of and injury caused to government installations, vehicles, and other assets belonging to the State and to private citizens alike.

12. The injuries sustained by the police forces in the course of discharging their duties, as well as the consequent mental and emotional trauma borne by their kith and kin.

The court said the Committee should address some of the issues "on a priority basis, foremost amongst which is the matter relating to the alleged incidents of targeted violence, harassment, and molestation of female protesters...bearing in mind the sensitivity attendant upon the issues contained therein".

"Additionally, the HPEC may also examine issues pertaining to the grant of interim compensation to those injured on either side, whether police personnel or protesters..."

The court asked the Committee "to complete its inquiry and deliberations on the issues" 1 and 6 "and submit its 'First Interim Report' at the earliest".

• BRIEFLY

A fire fighter at the site in Champahati. PTI

SOUTH 24 PARGANAS

Five injured in blast at firecracker unit in Bengal, condition of 2 critical

AT LEAST FIVE people, including a woman, were injured in a blast at a firecracker unit in West Bengal's South 24 Parganas district on Thursday, police said. The explosion took place at a factory in Champahati area around noon, following which a fire broke out at the unit, said a senior officer. Two of the injured were stated to be in critical condition, while three others were treated at a nearby hospital and later discharged, officials said. A probe has been launched to ascertain the exact cause of the blast and verify whether the unit had the requisite licence, the officer said. The blast left the structure largely destroyed. Wednesday's incident comes months after a blast at a firecracker unit in Champahati in January claimed one life. PTI

Ex-bank branch manager held for 'stealing' gold

THE MUMBAI Police have arrested a former deputy branch manager of a private bank for allegedly stealing gold jewellery worth Rs 81.8 lakh from the locker of an elderly NRI, an official said Thursday. According to a complaint, Pradeep Motiram Bhatia had deposited his jewellery with the bank in 2024. He found his locker to be empty recently, police said. A probe found that Kuldeep Sahani (35), then deputy branch manager, pledged ornaments found identical to those of Bhatia's to gold-loan firms. Sahani was arrested and the gold was recovered. PTI

Home of murder suspect razed in UP's Kant town

THE HOUSE of a man accused of killing a 22-year-old Hindu youth over a love affair was demolished in Kant town on Thursday. Additional District Magistrate (Administration) Rajneesh Kumar Mishra told *PTI* that the structure illegal and notices had been issued to owners Amiran, Naseem Jahan and Salma. After they failed to respond to the notices, the Nagar Panchayat sought permission to raze it, he said. The demolition came weeks after the killing of Gautam Maurya, allegedly by Sameer Ali, a resident of Kant town, over a love affair. PTI

Student activists clash with police personnel outside Jadavpur University in Kolkata on Thursday. EXPRESS

SFI and ABVP activists clash over general body meet at Jadavpur varsity

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, August 20

A HEAVY police force was deployed outside Jadavpur University in Kolkata on Thursday after violent clashes between members of the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) and the Students' Federation of India (SFI), over an initial altercation on Wednesday night.

Although the police tried to stop the ABVP march near the Jadavpur police station, protesters broke through barricades to reach the university's outer gates. Meanwhile, as the police barricaded SFI demonstrators near the 8B bus stand; the activists breached the barrier, leading to a scuffle with police.

University sources said the incident occurred over the general body meeting of the Faculty of Engineering and Technology Students' Union.

"During the meeting, Left-wing supporters reportedly attempted to constitute the Union unilaterally. This was opposed by ABVP supporters, namely Diptiman Kar and Nikhil Das (ABVP president)...an altercation reportedly occurred between the two groups on the campus. The injured ABVP members, Nikhil and Diptiman, were taken to KPC Hospital," the Kolkata police said.

The ABVP alleged that the SFI and the Democratic Students Organisation (DSO) and the Democratic Students' Federation (DSF) — both Left-leaning student groups — were holding the meeting when its supporters went to object. The ABVP also claimed SFI members assaulted them.

The DSO alleged the ABVP brought outsiders and resorted to vandalism. They claimed ABVP members barged in with sticks, attacked SFI and DSO members along with other students, tore down SFI banners, wiped out slogans, and set flags on fire.

Rapid Action Force (RAF) was also stationed outside the gate on Thursday.

ABVP supporters were seen climbing the university's locked main gates. while shouting "Vande Mataram". Inside, SFI and DSO activists stood behind banners, alleging that ABVP members threw eggs and water bottles at them over the gates.

EXPRESS special

'Day in and day out... police fire one shot and accused is hit on the knee or below': Allahabad High Court

Bhupendra Pandey
Lucknow, August 20

Court was hearing case against rape accused who "attacked" police during the May 11, 2025 encounter

ORDERING A CBI probe into the "encounter" in which a 36-year-old rape accused was shot in both legs in May last year in Shravasti district of Uttar Pradesh, the Lucknow Bench of the Allahabad High Court observed earlier this week, "... day in and day out... whenever the police apprehend a person, it often gives rise to another FIR alleging that when the accused was apprehended, he indulged into indiscriminate firing against the police team. Normally, not even a pellet touches even the uniform of any police person and all of them escape unhurt. The police fire one shot and it hits the accused on his knee or below it."

The court was hearing a police case against the accused, of "attacking" them during the May 11, 2025, encounter. In his order on August 13, Justice Subhash Vidyarthi pointed out several loopholes in the police version, including how 13 personnel were travelling in one police vehicle and the "shooting skills" of the SHO. He directed the CBI to complete the probe in three months, with the next hearing on November 23.

The court also directed the trial court to pass a fresh order on the discharge application of the convict, against the police chargesheet, after providing him adequate legal aid.

Convicted in two other cases of sexual assault, all involving minors, it is not the first time the 36-year-old has won a court case against police. Sentenced to death for the rape-murder of a child in 2014, the accused was acquitted by the Supreme Court after spending 12 years in jail.

In the latest case against him, he was sentenced to life on October 3, 2025, by Additional Sessions Judge/Special Judge (POCSO), Shravasti, for the alleged rape of a six-year-old belonging to his village. He was on the run when he was held following the encounter.

The 36-year-old was first accused in 2011 of molesting a 10-year-old girl. The District Court, Shravasti, sentenced him to four years of simple imprisonment. By then, a case had been registered against him over the rape and murder of a six-year-old girl, leading to the death sentence by the Sessions Court in 2014. This order, upheld by the High Court, was set aside by the Supreme Court in 2024.

As per police, on May 9, 2025, not long after he was acquitted by the apex court, the 36-year-old and two others abducted and raped a six-year-old and attempted to murder her. While the other two were apprehended, the 36-year-old went on the run.

As per the police chargesheet, on May 11, 2025, the then SHO of the concerned police station received information that the accused was attempting to flee to Nepal, and that they laid a trap. According to police, as they zeroed in on him, he opened fire, and in the exchange of fire, he sustained gunshot injury in both legs.

On October 3, 2025, he was convicted and sentenced to life.

In its August 13 order, High Court judge Justice Vidyarthi said the SHO, Ashwini Kumar Dubey, tried to "mislead the court". "The narration made in the FIR is that 13 persons including the SHO, five Sub-Inspectors, one Head Constable and six Constables were sitting in one vehicle. Unless the vehicle was a mini bus, it was neither physically possible nor legally permissible for 13 persons to sit in a government vehicle used by the police for patrolling and going to arrest an accused person."

Justice Vidyarthi observed: "The SHO claims that upon hearing the noise of loading of the weapon, he fired two gunshots with his service pistol in his self-defence..., and both shots fired during the night, by merely hearing the sound of loading the weapon, hit the revisionist (the accused) in both his legs."

SHO Dubey told the court he fired from about 15 metres. Justice Vidyarthi asked whether he was capable of aiming and shooting from such a distance at night, whereupon he said it was a moonlit night. Ordering a CBI inquiry, the judge said, "the shooting capacity of the complainant will also be assessed".

The High Court also questioned the "confession" made by the accused as per the police, noting that it was made "while he was lying down on the ground, injured with two gunshot injuries in his leg and surrounded by 23 police personnel".

On the conviction of the 36-year-old in the case, the High Court said "the prosecution acted with exceptional haste... and (he was) convicted in great haste". "The counsel for the revisionist has submitted that the revisionist could not contest the matter properly and he could not even file an appeal against the conviction order within time."

It further observed that all 23 police officials involved in the encounter have been rewarded for their "good work", and suggested: "The apparent cause of annoyance of the police against the revisionist may be the observations made by the Supreme Court against the prosecution in the judgment acquitting the revisionist in the earlier matter."

The High Court cited the Supreme Court's observations in its 2022 order regarding the accused's financial condition and inability to hire a lawyer. "In the present case also, at the time of remand... no legal aid was provided to the applicant."

ED: Pinarayi's daughter transferred money to Dubai via hawala trail

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, August 19

A DAY AFTER the Enforcement Directorate (ED) conducted raids at eight locations as part of its probe into alleged illegal payments made by Cochin Minerals and Rutile Limited (CMRL) to the IT firm owned by the daughter of former Kerala chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan, the agency said it had found evidence pointing to the transfer of money through hawala channels.

In an official release Wednesday, the ED said Veena, daughter of Vijayan, had transferred money to Dubai in UAE Dirham as well as Indian rupees.

"Several statements and digital evidence relating to transfer of money through hawala routes were seized. Veena has been handling money beyond her known sources of income. The amounts stated in her handwritten accounts were over the amounts received from CMRL. The amount transferred to Dubai is 3.49 lakh UAE Dirham (equivalent to Rs 85 lakh). The amount maintained for Indian rupees is for about Rs 20.05 crore...," the ED said.

Veena has not reacted to the raids and subsequent developments so far.

Her husband Muhammed Riyas told media in Kozhikode that all transactions have been carried out legally. The ED probe will be addressed both legally and politically.

Earlier, the Income Tax Department had found that Veena's IT firm Exalogic Solutions had received Rs 2.78 crore from Kochi-based CMRL under the guise of IT consultancy services. Besides, Empower India Capital Investment Private Limited, operated by CMRL MD Sasidharan Kartha, had given Rs 50 lakh as a loan to Veena's firm despite the firm's failure to make repayments.

• THE BID SET A WORLD RECORD FOR AN INDIAN HISTORICAL DOCUMENT SOLD

Gandhi's set of daily reflections fetches Rs 16.2 cr at auction

'A Thought for the Day' consists of 688 dated reflections penned over 23 months

Trisha Mukherjee
New Delhi, August 20

A COLLECTION of Mahatma Gandhi's daily reflections on truth, self-restraint and non-violence — written for close associate and disciple Anand T Hingorani fetched Rs 16.20 crore at a Saffronart auction on Wednesday, setting a world record for an Indian historical document sold at auction.

Comprising 688 dated reflections penned across 23 months and compiled as a book titled 'A Thought for the Day', the archive offers an almost uninterrupted record of Gandhi's moral thought and personal guidance.

Hingorani had first met Gandhi in 1930 and went on to work closely with him at Sabarmati Ashram. He participated in the Dandi March, as well as the Civil Disobedience and Quit India movements. He later became an important publisher and custodian of Gandhi's writings. His family preserved the archive across generations. Hingorani passed away in 1999.

"Gandhi responded by setting aside time each day to write a personal thought. What began as a personal exchange soon evolved into a collaborative project. While Gandhi authored each reflection, Hingorani became the recipient, organiser and transcriber, ultimately preparing the writings for publication," Minal Vazirani, Co-founder and president, Saffronart, told *The Indian Express*. The correspondence between Gandhi and Hingorani began as "an act of compassion" after the former reached out following the death of Hingorani's wife, Vidya. According to the Hingorani family, Hingorani was also undergoing nature-cure treatment for his deafness at the time and had "shared with Gandhi the depth of his loneliness and grief".

Gandhi's *peti charkha* and two letters to Anand T Hingorani on the spiritual discipline of spinning. EXPRESS

"Gandhi is often remembered for his grand political movements but this document shines a light on the equal significance he placed on individual daily relationships," Minal said. The book was part of an 86-lot sale — Gandhi: From the Collection of Anand T Hingorani — that featured objects documenting the defining moments in India's freedom struggle as well as the friendship, mentorship and personal exchanges between Gandhi and Hingorani, ranging from letters and manuscripts to philatelic items and artefacts.

"The exceptional response to 'A Thought for the Day' reinforces its rarity and historical significance. Together, these reflections offer a rare insight into how Gandhi lived the principles he advocated publicly, making this an especially valuable record of his thought and practice," said Dinesh Vazirani, Co-Founder of Saffronart.

Other highlights from the sale included Message on God — a set of three related manuscript and correspondence items offering Gandhi's reflections on God and the Bhagavad Gita — which fetched Rs 1.68 crore; Gandhi's Peti Charkha and Two Letters on the Spiritual Discipline of Spinning, which went for Rs 1.02 crore; and a signed presentation photograph of Gandhi Writing, which sold for Rs 78 lakh.

Trapped in jewellery store and surrounded by locals, thieves dial cops for help

Kamal Saiyed
Surat, August 20

AN ATTEMPTED jewellery heist saw an unusual turn when the alleged thieves, fearing they would be beaten up by the public, called the police control room and turned themselves in after being trapped inside the store they had targeted.

The incident took place in the coastal town of Sanjan in Umargam taluka of Gujarat's Valsad district early Thursday.

The burglars, originally from Uttar Pradesh and staying in Mumbai — Dinesh Sonkar (32), of Boisar and Vipin Pathak (27), of Nalasopara — broke into BR Jewellery around 3 am on Thursday. Police said, the duo had cut the lock open to enter the store. They were packing ornaments, valuables and cash into their bags when neighbours woke up, hearing the noises. Meanwhile, a power outage forced local residents out of their homes.

A friend of shop owner Manish Sharma, who lived opposite the store, woke up to the sounds and raised an alarm, and several people gathered near the store. Meanwhile, local residents downed the shutter, trapping the thieves inside.

Scared that the public would beat them up, Sonkar called the emergency helpline 112, which led the police to the spot. Hearing the police callout, the burglars opened the shutters and surrendered and were arrested.

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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to
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• POLICY

Marathi mandate for auto and taxi drivers: Concerns over law, licences

Zeeshan Shaikh
Mumbai, August 20

THE MAHARASHTRA government has begun enforcing a requirement that auto rickshaw and taxi drivers demonstrate a working knowledge of Marathi, making it a condition for continuing work. The crackdown follows a 105-day training and assessment drive for drivers, but a large number have either failed the test or are yet to complete training. The move also revives a legal issue after the Bombay High Court had struck down a similar requirement for auto rickshaw permits in 2017, prompting questions over the legal basis of the latest action.

Why the requirement?

Officials said they have received complaints of drivers being unable to communicate with passengers in Marathi. The issue gained attention this year after a pilot inspection found several autorickshaw drivers who supposedly lacked proficiency in basic Marathi.

Transport Minister Pratap Sarnaik then announced that auto-rickshaw and taxi drivers would have to know Marathi and the department began its drive. More than 4,500 teachers trained drivers in conversational Marathi. The four-session course focused on exchanges, including asking for destinations and discussing fares. Drivers who completed the course and passed the assessment were given certificates. Of the nearly 1.25 lakh drivers who participated in Mumbai, 7,750 failed the assessment and must reappear, while more than 14,000 have not completed the training.

THE ISSUE

- The state's argument is that auto and taxi drivers interact with passengers and need to know basic communication.
- But many such drivers are migrants and older workers with limited formal education.

Why autos and taxis?

The government's argument is that auto and taxi drivers interact with passengers throughout the day and need to know basic communication. But it has also raised concerns among other driver groups, particularly because many are migrants and older workers with limited formal education. Unions have argued that the government should focus on training rather than penalising drivers whose livelihood depends on licences. Mumbai has more than 2.8 lakh autorickshaw permits and around 20,000 taxi permits, covering an estimated five lakh drivers across shifts.

What is the legal question?

In 2017, the Bombay High Court set aside a Transport Department decision requiring Marathi proficiency for auto rickshaw permits. The court held that auto rickshaws fall within the definition of "motor cabs" and that Rule 24 of the Maharashtra Motor Vehicles Rules, which prescribes language requirements for certain Public Service Vehicle (PSV) badges, specifically excludes motor cabs. These are metal badges bearing names, issued to every person authorised to drive a PSV, except motor cabs.

The court held that Rule 24 could not be used to impose Marathi proficiency as a condition for an autorickshaw contract carriage permit. It held that the government had to act within the Motor Vehicles Act and its rules.

The Transport Department has maintained that the present exercise is about enforcing existing rules. Officials have also distinguished between permits and badges, arguing that Rule 24 applies to badges and that the 2017 judgment did not strike down the language requirement for badges. The government subsequently amended rules to formalise Marathi proficiency as a condition for authorisation, permits and renewals. The draft rules were put out for objections and suggestions.

What happens to those who fail?

Drivers won't lose licences immediately. Those found lacking proficiency will first be given a notice and a month to learn Marathi. If they fail to comply, their PSV badge and driving licence can be suspended for three months. Repeated violations can result in permanent suspension.

• HISTORY

Vande Mataram: Religious imagery, political debate

Citing Gandhi, Tagore and a 1937 CWC decision, Congress said it will sing only the first two stanzas of the composition. Why are the other four controversial?

YASHEE & ASAD REHMAN

THE CONGRESS Working Committee (CWC) has decided that only the first two stanzas of *Vande Mataram* will be sung at party programmes, amid BJP attacks over the National Song's rendition at its Independence Day programme and later at an event in Goa.

The Congress's highest decision-making body cited a 1937 CWC resolution to back its stand, arguing that the leading lights of the freedom movement, including Mahatma Gandhi and Rabindranath Tagore, had backed limiting the public rendition of *Vande Mataram* to its first two stanzas.

The row comes months after Parliament made intentional attempts to prevent or disrupt the singing or playing of *Vande Mataram* an offence.

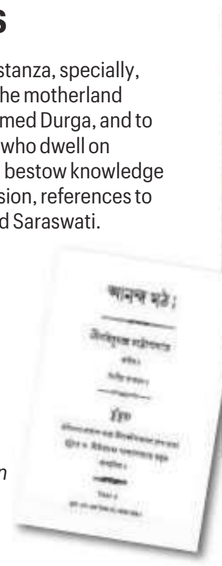
• THE FULL SONG AND STANZAS

- The first two stanzas of Vande Mataram describe the beauty of the motherland — its fertility, its waters, its greenery.
- But later on, it likens the motherland to the divine mother, and speaks of installing the mother's statues in temples.
- The fifth stanza, specially, compares the motherland to the 10-armed Durga, and to goddesses who dwell on lotuses and bestow knowledge and expression, references to Lakshmi and Saraswati.

It goes, in heavily Sanskritised Bangla,

"Tvam hi Durgā daśa-praharaṇa-dhāriṇī,
Kamalā kamala-dala-vihāriṇī,
Vāṇī vidyā-dāyinī,
Namāmi tvām namāmi kamalām

***(Roughly translated as:** You are Durga, bearing ten weapons;You are Lakshmi, who dwells upon the lotus; You are Saraswati, the giver of knowledge; I bow to you, I bow to you...")*



Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay composed Vande Mataram in 1875. Six years later, he included it in his book 'Anandamath'.

The composition

Vande Mataram (meaning 'mother, I bow to thee') was composed in Sanskritised Bengali by Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay in 1875. Six years later, it was included in his novel *Anandamath*, which tells the story of the late-18th century Sanyasi Rebellion, a series of armed uprisings in Bengal against the East India Company rule and the regional Muslim administrators.

Vande Mataram gained popularity during the Swadeshi movement (1905-08), becoming closely associated with the freedom struggle. The Muslim League, however, was against some references in the song, and also believed that "bowing to the mother" amounts to idolatry.

The 1937 CWC resolution

Within the Congress, there was a discussion about the *Vande Mataram* issue. Several people, including Subhas Chandra Bose (who supported the song wholeheartedly) and Jawaharlal Nehru, wrote to Tagore to seek his opinion.

Tagore wrote to Nehru: "To me the spirit of tenderness and devotion expressed in its first portion, the emphasis it gave to beautiful and beneficent aspects of our motherland made a special appeal, so much so that I found no difficulty in dissociating it from the rest of the poem..."

He added: "I freely concede that the whole of Bankim's '*Vande Mataram*' poem, read together with its context, is liable to be interpreted in ways that might wound Moslem susceptibilities, but a national song, though derived from it, which has spontaneously come to consist only of the first two stanzas of the original poem, need not remind us every time of the whole..." [From Sabyasachi Bhattacharya's book, *Vande Mataram: The Biography of a Song*].

In October 1937, the Congress Working Committee had decided that when *Vande Mataram* is sung at national gatherings, only the first two stanzas should be sung, as the other "stanzas of the song are little known and hardly ever sung. They contain certain allusions and a religious ideology which may not be in keeping with the ideology of other religious groups in India".

Mahatma Gandhi too, while expressing admiration for the song, said it should not be sung at gatherings where people objected to it. On July 1, 1939, he wrote in *Harijan*: "It was an anti-imperialist cry... It had never occurred to me that it was a Hindu song or meant only for Hindus. Unfortunately, now we have fallen on evil days... I would not risk a single quarrel over singing *Vandemataram* at a mixed gathering."

The song and the struggle

Vande Mataram, which gained popularity during the Swadeshi movement (1905-08), become closely linked to the freedom struggle.

•

The Muslim League was against some references in the song. It believed 'bowing to the mother' amounts to idolatry.

The same month, he again wrote in *Harijan* that "if at any mixed gathering any person objected to the singing of *Vandemataram* even with the Congress expurgations, the singing should be dropped." [*Mahatma Gandhi and the Harmony of Music*, By Teresa Joseph & AM Thomas].

The political debate

When India gained Independence, there was a demand for *Vande Mataram* to be adopted as the national anthem. In the Constituent Assembly, there was some friction on the issue. On August 14, 1947, at the Assumption of Power ceremony, Sucheta Kripalani sang the first verse of *Vande Mataram* as the opening item. On August 26, HV Kamath rose in the Assembly to say that on that day: "...Some of us in this House noticed that a number of our Honourable friends entered the Assembly Chamber — I would almost say trooped into this Hall — after the song had been sung. I would request you, Sir, to look into this matter..."

Among those who preferred *Jana Gana Mana* as the anthem were Nehru, and among the reasons he cited was that *Vande Mataram* would be difficult to set to an orchestra. On November 5, 1948, Seth Govind Das said in the Constituent Assembly: "...I would say that '*Vande Mataram*' can be our National Anthem. The history of our struggle for independence is associated with *Vande Mataram*. If it be said that is tune is not fit for orchestrisation I would submit that this is a difficulty which can be overcome by experts in orchestral music."

Jana Gana Mana was eventually chosen as the anthem.

On January 24, 1950, President Rajendra Prasad told the Constituent Assembly: "The composition consisting of the words and music known as *Jana Gana Mana* is the National Anthem of India, subject to such alterations in the words as the Government may authorise as occasion arises; and the song *Vande Mataram*, which has played a historic part in the struggle for Indian freedom, shall be honoured equally with *Jana Gana Mana* and shall have equal status with it. I hope this will satisfy the Members."

The BJP has recently made a major push to sing all six stanzas of the song. The Ministry of Home Affairs on January 28 notified the first set of protocols for singing *Vande Mataram*, directing that all six stanzas shall be sung during official functions.

The BJP has long accused the Congress of giving in to its "appeasement politics" over *Vande Mataram's* truncation.

Now, the Congress's stand comes at a time Parliament has passed the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Act, 2026, which amends Section 3 of the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971 to extend the same legal protection to the *Vande Mataram* that the National Anthem, *Jana Gana Mana*, enjoys. The amendment makes it an offence to intentionally prevent the singing of the National Song or to cause a disturbance to an assembly engaged in its singing.

Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh told *The Indian Express*: "Dr. Rajendra Prasad as President of the Constituent Assembly announced on Jan 24 1950 that *Vande Mataram* (first two stanzas) will be the national song... This was accepted by the Constituent Assembly with cheers. But in December 2025, Parliament only had a discussion and never ever adopted a resolution saying that the full *Vande Mataram* will be the national song. This was a unilateral decision of the PM and HM by notification, which does not have Parliamentary approval."

• LEGAL

Whose streets? That parking spot outside the house isn't really yours

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, August 20

AS THE Delhi Police prepares a fresh congestion-management plan, commissioner Anurag Kumar has directed every traffic circle to identify at least one "problem area" marked by encroachment, roadside parking or chronic congestion.

The exercise comes amid a broader push to improve traffic flow, strengthen enforcement and crack down on unauthorised parking that contributes to bottlenecks across the city. Does living next to a public street give a resident any special right over the parking space?

Ownership of public street

A public street does not belong to the owner whose gates open onto it. The Delhi Municipal Corporation Act, 1957 (DMC Act) defines a "public street" as "any street which vests in the Corporation".

Section 298 vests all public streets in the Corporation and goes further, stating that public streets "shall be under the control of the Commissioner and shall be maintained, controlled and regulated by him in accordance with the bye-laws".

In other words, the road outside a house belongs to the public authority, not the adjoining resident. No provision of the DMC Act gives a homeowner an exclusive right over the stretch of road outside their property. Long use of a parking spot does not create any special entitlement either.

Parking lawful, but regulated

Parking a vehicle on a public road is not, as such, illegal. Under Section 117 of the Motor Vehicles Act, 1988, the state government may determine "places at which motor vehicles may stand either indefinitely or for a specified period of time" and may also specify where public service vehicles may stop for longer periods.

Section 122 of the Act bars leaving a vehicle in a public place in a manner that causes or is likely to cause "danger, obstruction or undue inconvenience to other users of the public place or to the passengers". Section 127 allows a vehicle abandoned or left unattended in violation of parking rules to be towed or immobilised.

Curbside parking

- The road outside a house belongs to the public authority, not the adjoining resident.
- While that doesn't make curbside parking illegal, it is governed by the public authority that owns and regulates that stretch of road.

Delhi has additional rules of its own. The Delhi Maintenance and Management of Parking Places Rules, 2019, framed under the Motor Vehicles Act, prohibit on-street parking within 25 metres of an intersection on any arm of a road and bar parking in green areas, parks, footpaths, bus stops and certain other locations.

Rule 11 states: "The Area Parking Plan made by civic agencies shall include, in their scope, parking arrangements within residential areas. The plan within such areas shall be made in consultation with the residents/Resident Welfare Associations." The Rules also require residential colony roads to keep one lane free for emergency vehicles.

Similarly, the Delhi Motor Vehicles Rules, 1993 empower the District Magistrate, after consultation with the State Transport Authority, the Deputy Commissioner of Police (Traffic) and the local authority concerned, to determine and notify parking places within their jurisdiction.

In effect, curbside parking outside a home is governed by the public authority that owns and regulates that stretch of road, not by the resident living next to it.

What the court has said

The Supreme Court has weighed in directly on Delhi's parking crisis. In *M.C. Mehta v Union of India* (2019), a Bench of Justices Arun Mishra and Deepak Gupta described the issue as one arising from the "conflict between increasing number of cars and dwindling availability of land" and observed that parking management has significant implications for urban planning.

The court directed the Delhi government to notify the Delhi Maintenance and Management of Parking Places Rules, 2019, and observed that an effective parking policy contributes to reducing congestion, pollution and crime.

The court also acknowledged the practical realities of residential neighbourhoods. It noted that it was "not oblivious to the hard reality that in certain colonies and areas parking of some vehicles will have to be permitted on the roads because the number of vehicles is much more than those which can be parked inside the houses."

• POLITICS

1984 riots: How Nanavati report indicted Sajjan Kumar — and State machinery

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, August 20

FORMER CONGRESS MP Sajjan Kumar died Thursday while serving a life sentence in a murder case related to the 1984 anti-Sikh riots. Kumar and other Congress leaders were accused of instigating violence and leading the mobs during the wave of violence in Delhi that followed the assassination of Prime Minister Indira Gandhi on October 31, 1984.

In 2000, the NDA government set up a commission to examine the riots and the failure of the authorities to investigate them. Headed by former Supreme Court judge Justice G T Nanavati, it made its submissions in 2005.

The Justice Nanavati Commission of Inquiry recorded "credible material" against Kumar and concluded that he was "probably involved" in the attacks described by several witnesses. The commission, importantly, also pointed to the complicity of the State machinery in the riots.

The findings on Kumar

The report examined affidavits, police records and testimony concerning attacks on Sikhs and their properties across Delhi. It offered one of the most detailed official accounts of allegations against Kumar, describing him as a powerful local Congress leader who was allegedly present at, addressed or directed mobs in parts of west Delhi, including Palam Colony, Raj Nagar, Mangolpuri and Sultanpuri.

A key witness, Jagdish Kaur of Raj Nagar, told the commission that she heard Kumar tell people gathered near Mandir Mangla Puri: "*Sardar saala koi nahi bachna chahida* (no Sikh should be spared)".

The commission also recorded evidence that Kumar addressed a crowd in Mangolpuri and said Sikhs had killed "their Maata", after which people raised slogans calling for Sikhs to be killed. The report said three Sikh men were subsequently burnt alive in an attack on a gurdwara in the locality.

In its assessment of Kumar's role, it said: "Many witnesses have stated about the involvement of S/Shri Sajjan Kumar, Balwan Khokar, Pratap Singh, Maha Singh and Mohinder Singh." It concluded that "there is credible material against" Kumar and Khokhar (a former Congress councillor).

The police investigation

Kumar's defence before the commission relied heavily on his acquittals in criminal cases. In his reply to the commission's notice, he argued that witnesses who had filed affidavits had either not named him before the police or had not supported the allegations in court. He also produced judgments in eight cases and said that he and Khokhar had been acquitted.

Sajjan Kumar addresses a Congress rally near Red Fort in 1995. EXPRESS ARCHIVE

The commission, however, said those acquittals could not by themselves prevent it from assessing the wider material before it. "There is ample material to show that no proper investigation was done by the police even in those cases which were registered by them," the commission said.

It said many complaints were not registered, eyewitnesses were not examined, and the names of alleged assailants were omitted from statements and chargesheets.

"Why so many persons had named him and attributed acts like addressing meetings and inciting people to kill Sikhs and to loot and destroy their properties remains unexplained by Shri Sajjan Kumar," it added.

The political complicity

The Congress was in power when the killings took place and its Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi sought to justify the violence, saying: "When a giant tree falls, the earth below shakes."

Despite grave allegations against the Congress leadership, the official investigation in the aftermath of the violence did not make much headway.

The commission said the failure to properly investigate allegations against influential political figures had contributed to the collapse of cases and made it impossible to assess the evidence through a fair criminal trial at the time.

Indicting Congress leaders and workers, its report said: "Large number of affidavits indicate that local Congress(I) leaders and workers had either incited or helped the mobs in attacking the Sikhs. But for the backing and help of influential and resourceful persons, killing of Sikhs so swiftly and in large numbers could not have happened."

The commission did not merely rely only on allegations but considered evidence of mobs moving through neighbourhoods, the availability of petrol and kerosene, the use of buses to transport people and the involvement of local Congress workers.

It noted how the nature of the attacks changed from "stray" and "not at all organized" on October 31, the day of Indira Gandhi's assassination, to "systematic" in the later days. "The attacks were made in a systematic manner and without much fear of the police; almost suggesting that they were assured that they would not be harmed while committing those acts and even thereafter," the report said. "The systematic manner in which the Sikhs were thus killed indicate that the attacks on them were organized."

For decades, the 1984 riots remained associated with the gap between the scale of the violence and the limited number of convictions. The Nanavati report's account of Kumar's role was central to that history.

In 2005, Congress Prime Minister Manmohan Singh apologised in Rajya Sabha after the Nanavati report was tabled. "I have no hesitation in apologising not only to the Sikh community but the whole Indian nation... I bow my head in shame..." he said.

Police assist a resident during an evacuation from the frontline village of Bilenke, amid Russia's attack on Ukraine, on Thursday. REUTERS

Russian missile and drone barrage kills at least 17 in Kyiv

Reuters
Kyiv, August 20

RUSSIAN AIRSTRIKES killed 17 people and injured more than 40 in Kyiv and the surrounding region on Thursday as President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said a failure by Ukraine's allies to replenish its stock of air defence missiles was costing lives.

Ukraine's air force said Russia launched dozens of cruise missiles, as well as ballistic and hypersonic ones, and 168 drones, in a massive overnight attack.

The air force said that nearly 90% of the drones and most of the cruise missiles were downed. It did not specify whether any of the more deadly ballistic missiles were intercepted — having said last week that providing such information was giving Russia cause to celebrate.

The upper floors of a nine-storey residential block were destroyed in Kyiv's Solomianskyi district, where at least eight people were killed, Mayor Vitali Klitschko said. He declared Friday a day of mourning.

Outside the damaged apartment block, an elderly woman wailed as rescuers carried out the body of her grandson. She stood sobbing beside his body after he was placed on the ground, before medics came to support her.

Overall, 30 residential buildings, a school, a children's hospital and a kindergarten were among those damaged in Kyiv and the surrounding areas, Zelenskyy said.

Russia's defence ministry said that Moscow had used airstrikes and drones to hit targets in and around Kyiv, including facilities producing drone components, a military depot and a logistics hub. As Russia has escalated its ballistic strikes in recent months, Zelenskyy has pleaded with allies to replenish Ukraine's stock of Patriot interceptors - the only weapon in its arsenal capable of downing a ballistic missile.

Romanian jets hit drone near key energy project

ROMANIA SCRAMBLED F-16 fighter jets to destroy a marine drone spotted a few hundred metres from the Black Sea gas project Neptun Deep, Defence Minister Radu Miruta said on Thursday.The incident underscores the growing threat to critical energy infrastructure in the Black Sea from drones and mines linked to Russia's war in Ukraine, with Neptun Deep expected to make Romania the European Union's largest gas producer when it comes onstream in 2027.NATO-member Romania shares a 614-km (382-mile) land border with Ukraine and has seen Russian drones breaching its airspace over the last four years and mines floating in the Black Sea across key trade and energy routes.

TEHRAN CALLS FRESH U.S. SANCTIONS 'ECONOMIC TERRORISM'

US: Will impose toughest sanctions in history on Iran

Bessent: We are going to collapse this regime; Trump warns Iran backers

Reuters
Washington, Dubai, August 20

THE UNITED States will impose "the toughest sanctions in history" on Iran, US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said on Thursday.

He said he would hold a press conference on Monday to discuss details. "It is a one-two punch. We have the blockade (on Iran), and we are going to have the toughest sanctions in history," Bessent told CNBC.

"It is going to work in Iran and we are going to collapse this regime. "Earlier, President Donald Trump warned on Wednesday of economic consequences against any country that provided "any type of lifeline to Iran."

US President Donald Trump has also warned of economic consequences for any country that provided "any type of lifeline to Iran" as the US looks to resolve a war it began alongside Israel nearly six months ago.

The US and Iran have twice announced ceasefire deals, in April and June, aiming to restore the free flow of shipping through Hormuz on a path towards ending the conflict, but both quickly crumbled, even as Israel has largely withdrawn from the fighting.

In a social media message on Wednesday, Trump promised "Economic Warfare and Isolation on an unprecedented scale," although details were scant.

"ANY country that allows its financial institutions, businesses, airports, or government entities to provide any type of lifeline to Iran will itself face TREMENDOUS Economic Consequences," Trump wrote.

Iran's foreign ministry condemned fresh US economic and trade sanctions on Thursday, saying they targeted ordinary Iranians and amounted to "economic terrorism" and crimes against humanity.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araqchi called Trump's comments an attempt to divert American public opinion from domestic financial problems, including record debt and rising interest rates.

"America's economic terrorism threatens the global economy and the national sovereignty of countries around the world," he said on X.

Iran has separately been negotiating an agreement on managing the Strait of Hormuz with Oman and has said several times in recent weeks that an agreement was close.

Trump responded on Monday to those negotiations with a threat, warning he might bomb the Gulf state, a longstanding US security partner, if it "gets in the way".

Omani Foreign Minister Badr Albusaidi, speaking after meeting his Japanese counterpart, said on Thursday lasting security in the strait required a permanent peace in the region and rejected further escalation.

Iran's Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf prays as he attends a 40-day commemoration ceremony for former Iranian Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei in Karbala on Thursday. AP

Imran Khan will not confront Pak army chief if freed, says aide

Reuters
Karachi August 20

JAILED FORMER Pakistani Prime Minister Imran Khan would not confront the military or army chief Asim Munir if freed, one of his closest aides told *Reuters*, portraying Munir as able to extend a "healing hand" after a legal breakthrough this week. The comments, which came after Pakistan's top court ordered Khan to be moved to hospital for treatment, appeared to mark a significant change in rhetoric by his party, Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf, or PTI.

Its supporters have for years rallied against Munir, who is seen by them as the man who jailed Khan in 2023 after he fell out with the military leadership. Khan himself has described Munir as "mentally unstable".

In an interview on Wednesday, Khan aide Zulfikar Bukhari, a PTI spokesperson, sent one of the strongest signals so far that the party was willing to reconcile with the military even as doubts remained whether Khan himself shared that wish.

"If Imran Khan was released tomorrow, hypothetically, he wouldn't do anything that would effectively damage the country," Bukhari said, describing him as "magnanimous".

Former Pakistan Prime Minister Imran Khan

A quiet channel between ICE and Iran shaped deportation flights, show newly released mails

Safiyah Riddle
Los Angeles, August 20

US IMMIGRATION officials worked with Iran to deport Iranians in 2025, newly released emails show, revealing a working relationship between the US and Iranian governments despite tensions mounting between the countries.

Hundreds of emails exchanged between US immigration officials, which were obtained by the National Iranian American Council and made public Tuesday, offer the most transparent play by play yet of how the two countries worked together to arrange for more than 100 Iranians to be flown back to Iran on three separate immigration flights in September and December 2025 and January 2026.

The flights departed just months after the US and Israel agreed to a ceasefire with Iran

The emails show that Iranian officials had some influence over which Iranian immigrants in the U.S. were sent back to their home country, and US Immigration and Customs Enforcement officials apparently heeded some last-minute changes to deportation lists at the request of Iran. "Per request from the Iran Embassy I added a few cases," one unnamed ICE official wrote in late August, a month before the first deportation flight in September. Just over a week later, someone with the same job title moved to make another, unspecified change to the deportation list after they said they met with the "Director at the Iranian Embassy."

"Iran has requested that I amend the previous manifest and expedite the removal process," the official wrote.In a September 26 email, just three days before the deportation flight left US soil, an ICE official said in an email that the Iranian Embassy was still making requests for three additional Iranians on the flight. Iranian officials were still making requests the day the flight departed, although one official wrote that those requests were denied. Coordination of the flights remained a high priority even as ICE officials acknowledged internally that Iranians were fleeing Iran amid the deadly 12-day war with the US and Israel in June 2025, emails show.

The flights departed just months after the US and Israel agreed to a ceasefire with Iran. The new emails highlight a clear departure from a decades-long practice by the US of welcoming Iranian dissidents, exiles and others since the 1979 Islamic Revolution forced a large number of Iranians to flee.

The deportation of Iranians to a country whose government has a pattern of persecution against women, religious minorities and political dissidents has drawn significant criticism. AP

• BRIEFLY

IRELAND

Zuckerberg buys 19th-century castle near River Blackwater

Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg . FILE

META CEO Mark Zuckerberg has bought a 19th-century Gothic-style castle overlooking a river in the southeast of Ireland, 200 kilometres from his company's European headquarters, a spokesman said on Thursday.Strancally Castle was built around 1830 on land overlooking the River Blackwater and underwent extensive renovation in 2003, according to a state architectural archive.The transaction is not listed on the Irish state property price register. *The Irish Times*, which first reported the purchase, estimated the property might be worth between €20 million and €30 million. REUTERS

CHINA

Real estate tycoon Hui Ka Yan jailed for life

CHINESE PROPERTY developer Hui Ka Yan, founder of the Evergrande real estate group, has been sentenced to life in prison and the companies were fined a total of more than $2 billion, a court in the southern city of Shenzhen said Thursday. The decision marks a milestone in Evergrande's saga after it collapsed with more than $300 billion in liabilities when Chinese authorities cracked down on excessive borrowing in the real estate industry in 2020. AP

NIGERIA

Overloaded boat capsizes, at least 50 bodies found

AT LEAST 50 bodies, mostly of children, have been recovered after an overloaded boat capsized in Nigeria's northwest Sokoto state, local officials and residents said on Thursday. The accident happened near Gorau in Goronyo local government area and rescue efforts are continuing, said Abdulkadir Yusuf, an area manager at the National Inland Waterways Authority. Yusuf said around 40 children's bodies had been found so far. AP

North Korea fires 10 ballistic missiles towards sea, says Seoul

Seoul: North Korea launched a barrage of ballistic missiles toward the sea on Thursday, South Korea's military said, a day after the North shrugged off a US decision to scale back military drills with South Korea in an apparent bid to resume diplomacy.

The Joint Chiefs of Staff said the launches of about 10 short-range ballistic missiles happened from North Korea's capital region around 5 pm on Thursday. The military said the missiles flew about 300 kilometres each toward North Korea's eastern waters. The military said South Korea has bolstered its surveillance posture and was closely coordinating information on the launches with the US and Japan. South Korea's national security council issued a statement urging North Korea to halt missile launches. AP

Veteran BNP leader Alamgir Bangladesh's new President

Reuters
Dhaka, August 20

BANGLADESHI LAWMAKERS elected veteran Bangladesh Nationalist Party leader Mirza Fakhrul Islam Alamgir as the country's new president on Thursday, making the longtime opposition figure the head of state after his party came to power in a major political transition.

The BNP returned to power in February in the long wake of the fall of Sheikh Hasina's Awami League government in 2024. While the presidency is largely ceremonial, Alamgir will serve as head of state and commander-in-chief of the armed forces. Executive authority remains with the prime minister and cabinet in the South Asian nation of about 173 million people.

Alamgir, 78, defeated Oli Ahmed, a retired army colonel and chairman of the Liberal Democratic Party and candidate of the Jamaat-e-Islami-led 11-party opposition alliance, in a parliamentary vote.

Chief Election Commissioner A M M Nasir Uddin declared Alamgir the winner after the 255-to-88 vote.

The BNP and its allies hold a two-thirds majority in parliament after winning the February 12 general election, which returned the party to power after years in opposition and brought Tarique Rahman to the office of the PM.

BNP leader Mirza Fakhrul Islam Alamgir got 255 votes

Harry, Meghan returning to UK; security private matter, says PM

Associated Press
London, August 20

PRINCE HARRY and his wife, Meghan, have decided to return to the United Kingdom for an extended stay starting this fall, but they won't resume their roles as working members of the royal family, The Associated Press learned Wednesday.

The couple's children, Prince Archie, 7, and Princess Lilibet, 5, have already enrolled at British schools and will start classes in September, according to a person close to the Sussexes who was not authorized to speak publicly. The family plans to live at a private, non-royal residence outside of London, but plans to maintain their home in Montecito, California, and their vacation property in Portugal.

The *Daily Telegraph* first reported the story. When asked to discuss the reports by the AP at a roundtable event with U.S. veterans in Washington Wednesday night, Harry replied, "Nothing to say."

Harry and Meghan gave up their royal duties and moved to California more than six years ago to earn their living through lucrative contracts with Netflix and Spotify. Although relations with the rest of the royal family have soured since then, Harry has recently expressed an interest in reconciliation so he could spend more time with his father, King Charles III, who is being treated for an undisclosed form of cancer.

Charles was informed of the couple's plans on Sunday. Harry and Meghan visited the UK last month.

British Prime Minister Andy Burnham said their security would be a "private matter". "It's a matter for Harry and Meghan, and we wish them well in the move that they're making," he said.

Buckingham Palace has a policy of not commenting on speculation about non-working members of the royal family.

A representative for Harry and Meghan declined to comment.

Prince Harry and Meghan will return with their two children

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

SRI LANKA

Israel 'concerned' over stir against Jewish site

THE ISRAEL embassy on Thursday expressed concern over a demonstration against a Jewish cultural site in Sri Lanka, citing a statement by a US State Department official. Israel has no physical embassy in Sri Lanka. It is officially represented in Sri Lanka by the Embassy of Israel in New Delhi. PTI

PAKISTAN

Bodies of sailors killed in Houthi attack return

SIX PAKISTANI seafarers injured in a recent Houthi attack on a vessel in the Red Sea returned home on Thursday, while the mortal remains of the two sailors who were killed in the assault have also been repatriated. On August 11, four seafarers were killed after Tanzania-flagged vessel was targeted by the Houthis. PTI

• TREE 55 WAS WHERE AN 18-YEAR-OLD STUDENT HAD BEEN HIT BY A BMW & DIED; NOW, VIETNAM OFFICIALLY CONFIRMED THAT A FORMER COMMUNIST PARTY OFFICIAL HAD BEEN BEHIND THE WHEEL

At Tree 55, Vietnam's Gen Z demands to hold the powerful & privileged accountable

Damien Cave
August 20

A YOUNG woman in a red hoodie and wide sunglasses stopped her motorbike just past Tree 55 on Nguyen Huy Tu Street in central Hanoi. She snapped a photo with her phone. She stared at the tree again. She lingered with defiance.

No one else was parked there at lunchtime Tuesday in front of the quiet men in pairs with hints of plainclothes authority — the middle-manager dress shoes, the aviator shades.

Tree 55, as everyone likely knew, was where an 18-year-old student, Do Ngoc Phuong Thuy, better known as Mina, had been hit along with her father by a BMW. She died after being thrown from a motorbike just days before her university exams. That was 15 months ago.

On Monday night, after an eruption of Generation Z outrage and creativity thrust Memorial Tree 55, or "The Tree of Justice," into the local zeitgeist, Vietnam's national broadcaster officially confirmed what many had long insisted: A former Communist Party official, Nguyen Sy Cuong, had been behind the wheel of that BMW.

The TV report said Cuong — who had been vice chair of the foreign affairs committee in the National Assembly until earlier this year — caused the crash by illegally driving on the wrong side of the road. It also said he was not prosecuted because he had compensated the victim's relatives, and they chose not to press charges. The victim's father, with his face obscured, urged people to move on in the segment, which did not mention that Cuong's wife is Vietnam's minister of culture, sports and tourism.

Their powerful positions, some said, had kept the crash out of public view.

A street in downtown Hanoi

But in a one-party state that Harvard scholars have described as repressive but responsive, the official acknowledgment of responsibility was an extraordinary concession to public pressure. Warning against "opportunists exploiting the incident on social media," the report reflected the government's deep concerns about an unexpected youth movement pushing for accountability at a time when officials are focused on economic growth. Adding to the sensitivity, the collective action comes after Gen Z activists toppled leaders in Nepal and challenged authorities in Indonesia.

Hanoi officials had already warned state-run outlets to reduce coverage of the youth-driven "Cockroach" demonstrations rocking New Delhi, according to a written notice shared among reporters. The internal guidance said the information could be "exploited for anti-government purposes."

And yet, for now at least, Monday's careful admissions in TV form show no sign of weakening the resistance to what many see as sloppy propaganda and protection for the powerful.

On Wednesday, legal experts said the victim's family could not, simply by declining to press charges, determine whether Cuong would be prosecuted. Online, anonymous critics accused the state broadcaster of using artificial intelligence to doctor a document showing Cuong had passed a sobriety test. Others questioned if it was really the victim's father in the report. Their claims could not be independently verified. The network did not respond to requests for comment. Cuong, reached by phone Wednesday, said only "I am busy, I cannot talk" before hanging up.

By midafternoon, the original version of the news report had disappeared from YouTube.

And all that public anger is about more than the crash. It reflects a broader frustration with corruption, privilege and the mechanisms of secrecy that benefit elites in a fast-changing society that has become more bifurcated by wealth and political connections.

As one commentator wrote on Threads on Wednesday, letting Cuong sidestep criminal prosecution simply confirms that the country's legal system "creates loopholes so that the rich can stuff money and power into them, while the poor cannot."

Fury over who gets to police both behavior and expression has also fueled the backlash. Censorship, in fact, sparked its rise. NYT

SHANTI ACT DRAFT RULES

Panel to review nuclear liability caps every 5 years

• SETTING UP GUARDRAILS

- Under SHANTI Act, operators of reactors above 3,600 MWe face a maximum liability of Rs 3,000 crore, while those between 1,500 MWe and 3,600 MWe face a cap of Rs 1,500 crore
- The limits fall to Rs 750 crore for reactors between 750 MWe and 1,500 MWe and Rs 300 crore for those between 150 MWe and 750 MWe
- For reactors up to 150 MWe, fuel-cycle facilities other than spent-fuel reprocessing plants, and transportation of nuclear material, the liability is capped at Rs 100 crore

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, August 20

LIABILITY CAPS for nuclear operators under the SHANTI Act will be reviewed every five years by an expert group, which can recommend changes to the graded limits, as per the Act's draft rules released by the Department of Atomic Energy.

Rule 78 of the draft rules, which were released on August 14, provide for the Central government to constitute a group of experts in specific domains — nuclear science and engineering, actuarial science, insurance and law, along with public-interest representatives — to review the "maximum limits of operator's civil liability for nuclear damage" and propose amendments to the Act's Second Schedule. The Second Schedule of the Act introduced graded liability caps based on the size of a nuclear installation, replacing the earlier flat cap of Rs 1,500 crore under the Civil Liability for Nuclear Damage Act, 2010 (CLNDA).

Under the new framework, operators of reactors above 3,600 Megawatt-electric (MWe) face a maximum liability of Rs 3,000 crore, while those between 1,500 MWe and 3,600 MWe face a cap of Rs 1,500 crore. The limits fall to Rs 750 crore for reactors between 750 MWe and 1,500 MWe and Rs 300 crore for those between 150 MWe and 750 MWe.

For reactors up to 150 MWe, fuel-cycle facilities other than spent-fuel reprocessing plants, and transportation of nuclear material, the liability is capped at Rs 100 crore.

The review mechanism is not entirely new. Section 6 of the now-repealed CLNDA also allowed the Centre to periodically review the operator's liability and notify a higher amount. The draft SHANTI Act rules explicitly provide for a defined time period for an expert group to review and recommend amendments to the graded caps. Following the passage of the SHANTI Act, which opens India's civil nuclear sector to private players, accountability and liability emerged as key concerns among critics. One of the most contentious changes is the dilution of the operator's "right of recourse" against nuclear equipment suppliers in the event of an accident.

According to Section 17 of the CLNDA, the operator of a nuclear installation, after paying the compensation for nuclear damage, shall have the right to recourse where (a) such right is expressly provided for in a contract in writing; (b) the nuclear incident has resulted as a consequence of an act of supplier or his employee, which includes supply of equipment or material with patent or latent defects or sub-standard services; and (c) the nuclear incident has resulted from the act of commission or omission of an individual done with the intent to cause nuclear damage.

The new law retains provisions (a) and (c) but omits provision (b), which previously exposed nuclear equipment vendors to long-term and uncertain liability risk in the event of a nuclear accident.

The issue of liability cap has also reached Supreme Court as a petition challenged the Act for allowing "private sector and foreign companies to operate nuclear power plants in India, [and] has also capped the liability of these operators at an absurdly low level and exempted the supplier from any liability," in violation of the Constitution.

NET OIL AND GAS IMPORTS IN APRIL-JULY STOOD AT $57.8 BILLION AGAINST $40.3 BILLION A YEAR AGO

Iran war pushes India's oil & gas import bill up 43%

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, August 20

AMID SUPPLY tightness and elevated prices due to the West Asia crisis and stifled energy flows through the Strait of Hormuz, India's net oil and gas imports surged by 43.4% in value from year-ago levels in the first four months of the current financial year, according to provisional data from the petroleum ministry. Net oil and gas imports — arrived at deducting petroleum product exports from oil, natural gas, and petroleum product imports — in April-July stood at $57.8 billion against $40.3 billion a year ago.

In volume terms, oil and liquefied natural gas (LNG) imports were only marginally higher. As for petroleum product exports, the volumes declined, while export value rose. Petroleum product imports declined in volume as well as value, although the volume decline outpaced the fall in value, which is also reflective of high prices in the international market.

India depends on imports to meet over 88% of its crude oil requirement and about half of its consumption of natural gas, which is imported as LNG. Despite depending on imported oil and gas, India is a net exporter of petroleum products due to its massive refining capacity. The country also imports some petroleum products like liquefied petroleum gas (LPG).

Around 40% of India's crude oil imports, 60% of its LNG imports, and 90% of its LPG imports came from West Asia through the strait. Apart from grappling with physical supply tightness due to the Strait of Hormuz crisis, the resultant surge in international prices forced India to import oil and gas at extremely high rates, as the country has been prioritising supply security over price considerations.

The country's crude oil import bill surged by over 56% on a year-on-year (y-o-y) basis in April-July to $63.4 billion, even as import volumes rose slightly to 81.9 million tonnes — or about 600 million barrels — from 81.5 million tonnes, as per data from the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell (PPAC).

This translates to an average landed price of about $106 per barrel for imported crude in April-July, sharply higher than about $68 per barrel in the corresponding period of last year. The data shows that India's dependence on imported oil for the four months ended July was 88.3%, almost flat on a y-o-y basis.

As for LNG imports, while supplies rose slightly — to 11,867 million standard cubic metres (mscm) in April-July from 11,269 mscm a year ago — the import bill rose by almost a fourth to $5.6 billion, reflecting the spurt in prices.

Petroleum product imports declined 45.1% in volume terms to 9.0 million tonnes, as supply of major petroleum products that India imports — like LPG — were impacted by the West Asia conflict. In value terms, the decline in petroleum product imports was relatively lower — down 26.3% to $5.6 billion — due to high international prices.

India's petroleum product export volumes fell almost 18% y-o-y to 16.5 million tonnes in April-July as domestic fuel supplies were prioritised amid the global supply crunch. Nonetheless, exports surged almost 35% in value.

Energy imports are a major component of India's overall imports, and any meaningful increase has ramifications for the country's trade balance, current account, inflation, and the rupee's exchange rate, among others. As India annually imports 1.8-2 billion barrels of oil, every $1-per-barrel increase in oil prices bumps up the country's oil import bill by up to $2 billion on an annualised basis.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• Impact of war on energy imports

	Apr-Jul FY26	Apr-Jul FY27	Change
Oil imports (mn tn)	81.5	81.9	0.5%
Oil imports ($ bn)	40.5	63.4	56.5%
Petroleum pdt imports (mn tn)	16.4	9	-45.1%
Petroleum pdt imports ($ bn)	7.6	5.6	-26.3%
LNG imports (mscm)	11269	11867	5.3%
LNG imports ($ bn)	4.5	5.6	24.4%
Petroleum pdt exports (mn tn)	20.1	16.5	-17.9%
Petroleum pdt exports ($ bn)	12.4	16.7	34.7%
Net oil & gas imports ($ bn)	40.3	57.8	43.4%

SOURCE: PETROLEUM PLANNING AND ANALYSIS CELL (PPAC)

Strengthening India-Singapore ties

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, Commerce & Industry Minister Piyush Goyal with Singapore Prime Minister Lawrence Wong at The Istana, Singapore. X/FINMININDIA

• India's infrastructure output rises 5.4% y/y

5.4% year-on-year

Growth in India's nine core sectors stood at 5.4% in July, slower than 6% seen in June, in the second print of a revamped Index of Core Industries (ICI), according to provisional data released by the Ministry of Commerce and Industry on Thursday. With 2022-23 as the base year, the new series released last month replaced the 2011-12 base year.

Sector-wise change in prduction in July

Cement	↑13.1%
Steel	↑2.9%
Electricity	↑9%
Coal	↑7.6%
Iron ore	↑29.5%
Refinery products	↑2.7%
Crude oil	↓5.3%
Fertiliser	↓8%
Natural gas	↓3.7%

SOURCE: MINISTRY OF COMMERCE AND INDUSTRY

SEBI to launch pilot for bond tokenisation

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, August 20

THE SECURITIES and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) plans to launch a pilot for tokenising bonds "in the near future" in a bid to improve accessibility, transparency, and efficiency in the market. The regulator has been coordinating with the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on the pilot project.

"The idea is, can a shared ledger be used to enable simultaneous transfer of the security and money, thereby making settlement more efficient and reducing reconciliation costs. The pilot is expected to examine this aspect along with the feasibility of automated coupon payments and other servicing events through smart contracts," SEBI Whole-Time Member Amarjeet Singh said at an event in Mumbai on Thursday.

"Let me clarify that this is not about creating a separate trading market. It is about examining whether technology can make the existing bond market simpler, faster and more efficient," Singh said.

The comments come as the regulator has been pushing to deepen the bond market to provide capital to fuel growth in the country. It is also consulting on a "Credit Risk-o-Meter" for debt securities to improve investor protection in a market that has been gaining traction.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Transaction fees on UPI in 2 weeks

Prasanta Sahu
New Delhi, August 20

A MERCHANT discount rate (MDR) of 0.3% on UPI transactions of Rs 2,000 and above is expected to be announced within two weeks, sources said on Thursday.

The Department of Financial Services will likely issue a gazette notification within a week specifying the electronic payment modes that would continue to receive statutory protection from charges. Thereafter, the UPI and Services Steering Committee, headed by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI), will determine the MDR, its scope and structure, sources said.

MDR is a fee paid by businesses to payment processors for accepting digital payments.

The government had assured that UPI transactions will remain free for consumers. The assurance was made during a debate in Parliament on the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, which amended Section 10A of the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, to pave the way for MDR on UPI transactions above a certain threshold.

An MDR of up to 0.3% of the transaction value applied to UPI person-to-merchant transactions until December 2019. Zero MDR was introduced in January 2020 to accelerate digital payment adoption and encourage a shift from cash to digital payments.

With a massive jump in UPI transactions since the Covid-19 pandemic, banks and other payment intermediaries have ramped up investment in payment infrastructure, leading to industry calls for the restoration of charges to make the system sustainable.

The government subsequently introduced an incentive scheme to support banks and other ecosystem participants and encourage digital payments by providing an incentive equivalent to 0.15% MDR on UPI transactions up to Rs 2,000.

Reintroduction of MDR at 0.3% on UPI transactions above a threshold would still be much lower than the prevailing MDR of 1-3% on credit cards and up to 0.9% on debit card transactions.

UPI is the world's largest real-time payment system by volume, with a share of nearly 50%. UPI accounted for 85% of India's digital payment transactions by volume in 2025-26. UPI processed 241.62 billion transactions worth Rs 314.23 lakh crore in FY26.

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Finance recently called for the early implementation of a tiered MDR framework for UPI transactions, warning that delays could leave payment service providers dependent on inadequate government subsidies and weaken investment in payment infrastructure. FE

• UPI MDR REVIVAL

AN MDR of up to 0.3% of the transaction value applied to UPI person-to-merchant transactions until December 2019

ZERO MDR was introduced in January 2020 to accelerate digital payment adoption and encourage a shift from cash to digital payments

REINTRODUCTION OF MDR at 0.3% on UPI transactions above a threshold would still be much lower than the prevailing MDR of 1-3% on credit cards and up to 0.9% on debit card transactions

Export payments in rupees get trade policy benefits

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, August 20

THE GOVERNMENT on Thursday amended certain provisions of the Foreign Trade Policy to make it easier for exporters to invoice overseas sales and receive payments in Indian rupees.

The amendments cover exports to all countries, although the rules vary by destination.

Two paragraphs of the Foreign Trade Policy (FTP) 2023 have been amended "to align the provisions relating to denomination of export contracts and eligibility for FTP benefits in respect of export realisation in Indian Rupees with the Foreign Exchange Management (Manner of Receipt and Payment) Regulations 2023", the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) said in a notification. For countries outside the Asian Clearing Union (ACU), export contracts and invoices may now be denominated in any foreign currency or Indian rupees.

Commenting on the notification, economic think tank GTRI said eligible rupee payments for exports to any country other than Nepal and Bhutan will now qualify for FTP benefits and count towards fulfilment of export obligations.

Rupee earnings received through approved banking channels will therefore be treated on par with export payments received in foreign currency, it said, adding that exports financed through EXIM Bank or Government of India lines of credit may also be invoiced in Indian rupees.

The ACU is a regional payment arrangement established in 1974 to facilitate trade settlements and reduce repeated transfers of foreign exchange by periodically settling the net obligations of its members. It has nine members — Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Iran, Maldives, Myanmar, Nepal, Pakistan and Sri Lanka — represented by their central banks or monetary authorities.

India allows 1 million metric tonnes duty-free sugar imports

Mumbai: India will allow duty-free imports of 1 million metric tonnes of raw sugar, a commerce ministry notice said on Thursday, as the government seeks to bring down record-high domestic prices in the world's biggest sugar-consuming country.

The notice allows for the imports between now and October 31, ahead of India's festival season when consumption in India peaks because of demand for traditional sweets.

Sugar prices in India have risen by nearly 40% in two months as lower production has tightened supplies, forcing India to import sugar for the first time in nearly a decade.

Benchmark white sugar futures in London and raw sugar futures in New York jumped by as much as 4% after India announced plans to allow duty-free imports on Thursday. India imposes a 100% duty on sugar imports. REUTERS

Adfactors PR acquires majority stake in Australia's SenateSHJ

New Delhi: Adfactors PR, India's largest public relations firm, has acquired a majority stake in Australian communications consultancy SenateSHJ, as part of its expansion in the Asia Pacific region.

SenateSHJ will retain its existing identity, leadership and client teams, and will continue to operate from its offices in Sydney and Melbourne. Its Co-founder and Chair Angela Scaffidi AM and Chief Executive Officer Darren Behar will continue to lead the business.

Adfactors PR Chief Executive Officer Nijay N Nair, who also oversees the firm's mergers and acquisitions and global initiatives, will join the SenateSHJ board. ENS

• BRIEFLY

IRDAI bars Niva Bupa from new biz for 6 months

New Delhi: The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India has directed Niva Bupa Health Insurance not to open a new place of business for six months for violating the Expense of Management limit, IRDAI said on Thursday. PTI

NSE shares may trade on its own platform

Mumbai: The NSE may allow its shares to trade on its platform after being listed on a rival bourse, without a separate approval from SEBI, as the proposed arrangement would fall under the exchange's existing 'permitted-to-trade' framework. PTI

• MARKETS

Sensex	NIFTY	Gold ▲	US Dollar ▼
77,537.72	24,231.85	₹1,57,080	₹95.71
628.04	153.55	Silver ▲	Oil ▲
0.82%	0.64%	₹2,37,766	$93.45

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION DATA GOLD PER 10G, SILVER PER 1 KG; CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF AUGUST 19, 2026

• 'A REVIEW OF BANKS' WEBSITES FOUND SHORTCOMINGS THAT COULD AFFECT CUSTOMERS' ABILITY TO ACCESS INFORMATION AND COMPLETE TRANSACTIONS'

RBI asks banks to fix gaps in customer transaction policies

George Mathew
Mumbai, August 20

RESERVE BANK of India (RBI) Deputy Governor Rohit Jain has flagged gaps in banks' policies governing customer transactions, saying a recent review of banks' websites found basic shortcomings that could affect customers' ability to access information and complete transactions. In some cases, banks referred customers to their schedule of charges or grievance redressal policies as being "available on the bank's website" without providing a direct link, while documentation requirements for outward remittances were described so broadly that they offered little practical guidance.

Jain said these were not difficult problems to fix, and could be addressed if authorised dealer (AD) banks themselves went through the customer experience and made the necessary improvements.

Jain said a customer does not experience FEMA as an Act or a Master Direction, but through his lived experience with the AD bank in terms of the documents a branch asks for, the quoted price, the time taken, and the quality of the explanation when a transaction cannot be done.

"As part of our supervisory exercise, we have found multiple documentation requirements and cases of delay in executing cross-border remittances," Jain said while addressing the Annual Day of Foreign Exchange Dealers' Association of India (FEDAI). "Accordingly, we have advised AD banks through FEDAI to put in place a clear policy governing documentation, process and approving authority, charges, timelines, escalation, and grievance redress to be displayed on their websites and at branches offering cross-border services. The progress on this needs to be better," Jain said.

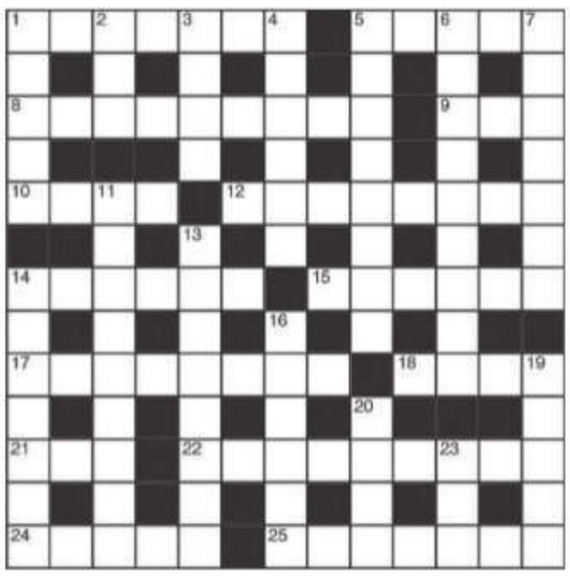
Similarly, transparency is not a one-time disclosure exercise, he said. "Policies must be complete, current, intelligible and actually followed at the bank's counter; compliance tested through internal or concurrent audit; staff trained, with proper succession planning so that capability does not sit with one officer; and customer feedback taken regularly and examined by people with requisite authority to change the process. No customer should suffer for a delay that arises from internal processing at the AD end," he said.

On Cross-border trade in local currencies, Jain said local currencies will play an ever increasing role in cross-border trade and payments. The Special Rupee Vostro Account (SRVA) framework for invoicing, payment and settlement of international trade in rupees has been implemented keeping in view the evolving dynamics of our international trade, he said.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

RBI Deputy Governor Rohit Jain said transparency is not a one-time disclosure exercise. REUTERS

• CROSSWORD 6073



ACROSS

1 Enthusiasts may wax it (7)
5 Ray is underweight (5)
8 Like to be sure; so find out (9)
9 By way of a Roman road (3)
10 He starts to appear fruitless in the bank (4)
12 Condemn a stupid person holding one back (8)
14 Having a decayed property to rent out (6)
15 Official accepts untrue story in mitigation (6)
17 Capital turn of a Pierrot (8)
18 Plant or uproot (4)
21 A dance that's not French (3)
22 Ex-prime minister happy to put on weight (9)
24 Trees newly transplanted (5)
25 Media make a stand about false statement (7)

DOWN

1 Not in the mood a number curse (5)
2 Bird watcher occupied part (3)
3 Smoke perhaps or rid yourself of the habit (4)
4 Fuhrer as heard in German songs (6)
5 Inside a solitary fellow is a capital chap (8)
6 Sent to prison but not at once (5,4)
7 One of many carried by the caddy (3,4)
11 Lock in the experts; they only pretend to work (9)
13 The bogus arrangement asked for (8)
14 Decorate from top to bottom or bottom to top (7)
16 Decoration is needed in drab conversion (6)
19 Legal actions? (5)
20 It's a mixed drink (4)
23 Sash for some of the nobility (3)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6072 ACROSS: 1 Trappist, 5 Opts, 9 Paper, 10 Trainer, 11 Part-time work, 13 Action, 14 Potion, 17 Steeplechase, 20 Ordered, 21 Reaps, 22 Torn, 23 Reveille **DOWN:** 1 Type, 2 Asphalt, 3 Paratroopers, 4 Sits in, 6 Pinto, 7 Striking, 8 Make no charge, 12 Passport, 15 Install, 16 Meddle, 18 Elder, 19 Isle

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

If we cannot end now our differences, at least we can help make the world safe for ____ - John F Kennedy (9)

IOERS

EHPSDT

DGTII

AILNVY

SOLUTIONS: Osier, Digit, Depths, Vainly
ANSWER: If we cannot end now our differences, at least we can help make the world safe for **diversity** - John F Kennedy

• OVER THE HEDGE

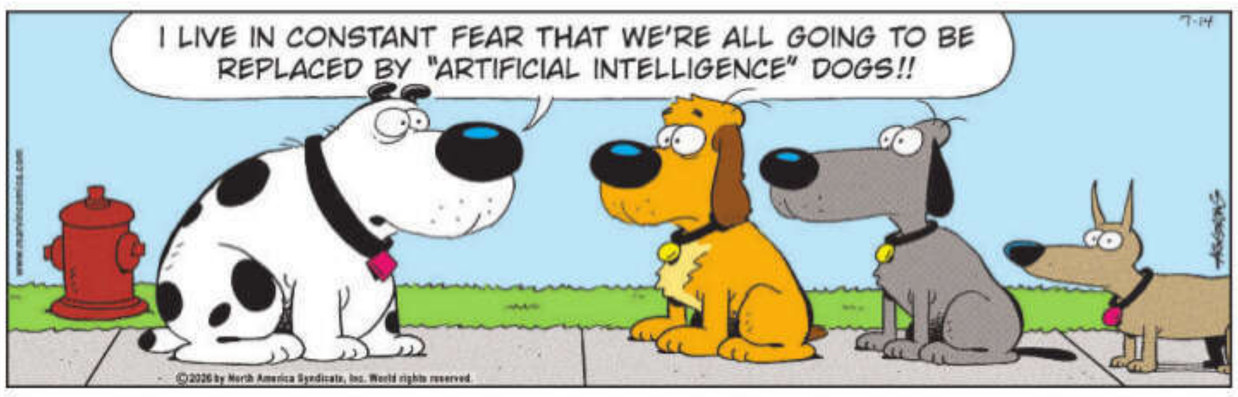
BY MICHAEL FRY & T LEWIS

• CALVIN & HOBBES

BY BILL WATTERSON

• MARVIN

BY TOM ARMSTRONG



SUDOKU 6417

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 3s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL
1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy;
3s = Medium; 4s = Hard;
5s = Very Hard;
6s = Genius

				2			4	8
		4		1	3		9	
	6	3					7	
	1	5			8			
			4			7	5	
	2					4	3	
	4		5	9		8		
7	5			6				

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6416

5	7	3	2	4	9	8	6	1
8	6	9	5	7	1	3	2	4
4	1	2	3	6	8	7	5	9
7	9	6	8	1	4	5	3	2
3	8	1	9	2	5	6	4	7
2	4	5	7	3	6	1	9	8
1	2	4	6	5	7	9	8	3
9	5	7	4	8	3	2	1	6
6	3	8	1	9	2	4	7	5

• ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Today you want adventure and stimulation. You also might make practical plans related to the law, medicine, higher education or publishing. Yet, you feel playful even though relations with someone close to you might be strained. Tonight: Learn something.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Even though relations with co-workers might be cool today, discussions about finances, money, debt and how to cover expenses at home will go well. You feel secure in practical ways. But then, when is it ever? Tonight: Check your finances.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): This is an excellent day to talk to others. Why not stand on the shoulders of those who have gone before you? Romance, as well as relations with kids, might be strained. Tonight: Be friendly.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): It might be in your best interests to listen to the advice of parents, bosses, teachers or the police. In fact, it might benefit your job as well as your earnings now or in the future. Relations with a family member or parent might be strained. Tonight: Work.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Social outings and time spent with kids, as well as romantic get-togethers, can be enjoyable. You might learn something valuable and helpful. Don't let a conversation with someone older ruin your day. Tonight: Socialise.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Although you might have financial worries today or feel pinched in the money department, family relations are warm. You might be encouraged by the offer of help — in practical or monetary terms — that can come your way. Tonight: Relax at home.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): Today is a mixed bag. You'll enjoy talking to others, especially siblings, relatives and neighbours. Groups will be supportive. You might feel disappointed in a close relationship. Tonight: A conversation.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): This is an excellent day for financial decisions and discussions with bosses and authority figures about your job. Someone behind the scenes might be critical. Tonight: Check your money.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Today the Moon in your sign is dancing with Jupiter and Saturn. This boosts your confidence, while at the same time, it makes you practical. Don't worry if things are strained with a friend or a member of a group. It happens. Tonight: You're strong.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Because relations with a parent, boss or someone in authority might be strained today, your impulse might be to pull back and hide, preferably with some food that's a wonderful guilty pleasure. If it's raining outside, seek shelter. Tonight: Enjoy privacy.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Friendships are warm and supportive today. Some are upbeat and jubilant; others are steady, practical and beneficial. Enjoy making plans and goals with someone today. Unfortunately, romance with someone different. Tonight: Be modest.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Many issues related to your job and your work are rewarding right now. In fact, many of you are in a new job or feeling fulfilment from your work. Funds from a different source might be disappointing. Tonight: You look good to others.

पीएम श्री केन्द्रीय विद्यालय वायुसेना स्टेशन कोलशेत ठाणे (प)
PM SHRI Kendriya Vidyalaya AFS Kolshet Thane (W)
कोलशेत रोड, संडोज़ बाग पोस्ट, ठाणे (प.) पिन-400607
वेबसाइट - www.afsthane.kvs.ac.in ईमेल: kvthane@gmail.com

साक्षात्कार सूचना

सभी पात्र उम्मीदवारों को सूचित किया जाता है कि पीएम श्री केन्द्रीय विद्यालय वायु सेना स्थल, कोलशेत रोड, ठाणे में प्रशिक्षित स्नातक शिक्षक, (अंग्रेजी, गणित, सामाजिक विज्ञान), प्राथमिक शिक्षक, शैक्षणिक परामर्शदाता एवं व्यावसायिक अनुदेशक पद के लिए 25.08.2026 को प्रातः 10:00 से 11:00 तक साक्षात्कार आयोजित किया जाएगा। उम्मीदवार संविदा साथी के पोर्टल' https://samvida-sathi.kvs.gov.in/ पर साक्षात्कार के पहले अपना पंजीकरण सुनिश्चित करें। अधिक जानकारी विद्यालय की वेबसाइट www. afsthane. kvs. ac. in पर उपलब्ध है।

प्राचार्य

CHITTARANJAN LOCOMOTIVE WORKS

Open E-Tender

No. LPMEDICINE2026B, Date-18.08.2026. The undersigned invites E-Tender for Local Purchase of Medicines and Surgical items Consumables items for Kasturba Gandhi Hospital/CLW/CRJ from Eligible firms for a period of Two years. The response on the prescribed format may be submitted through online **www.ireps.gov.in** on or before **07.09.2026 at 15.00 hours.**

PR1/465 ACMS/A/KGH/CLW

Like us on : www.facebook.com/clwrailways

BEFORE THE HON'BLE HIGH COURT OF KERALA AT ERNAKULAM
Crl MC No. 5737 of 2019

Reji K Joseph, Aged 61 Years Koduvirachira, Aiswarya Road, Muttambalam P.O., Kottayam-686 001. : **Petitioner**

-Vs-

State of Kerala & others : **Respondents**

To,
3rd respondent
Amit Bansal, Deloitte Touche Tohmatsu India Llp Indiabulls Finance Centre, Tower 3, 27th-32nd Floor, Senapati Bapat Marg, Elphinstone Road (West) Mumbai-400 013 Maharashtra, India.

Take notice that the above Crl MC has been posted for hearing and disposal on or after **23.11.2026**, if you or your Counsel fails to appear on that date in the Honourable High Court at Ernakulam, the Crl MC will be heard and disposed of in your absence.

Dated this the 25th day of March, 2026

(Sd/-) **Arun Thomas**
Counsel for the petitioner

The Andhra Pradesh Mineral Development Corporation Limited
Door No. 294/1D, 100 feet Road (Tadigadapa to Enikepadu Road), Kanuru, Vijayawada-521137, Andhra Pradesh, India
Tel: +91-866-2429999 Fax: +91-866-2429977 Email: contracts-ho@apmdc.in

SHORT TERM TENDER NOTICE
Tender No: APMDC/HO/P&C/Excavation and removal of overburden and Barytes (ROM) oreM'Pet/2026-27/1 Dt:21.08.2026

APMDC invites Short Term E-tender from reputed Agencies for **"Selection Of Contractor For Excavation And Removal Of Overburden And Barytes (ROM) Ore At Mangampet Barytes Project, Mangampeta (V), Obulavaripalli (M) Tirupati District, Andhra Pradesh".** For more information on the eligibility criteria, tender fees, timelines and other details, please visit e-procurement website of GoAP **www.tender.apeprocurement.gov.in**) or APMDC website (**www.apmdc.ap.gov.in**). The Tender document is available for downloading from **21.08.2026** and the last date for bid submission is **28.08.2026** by 17:00 Hrs.

Sd/-
Managing Director
The A. P. Mineral Development Corporation Limited

Place: Vijayawada
Date: 21.08.2026

R.O. No. 5350PP/CL/ADVT/1/1/2021-22 Dt.: 20/08/2026

AMARAVATI GROWTH AND INFRASTRUCTURE CORPORATION LIMITED (AGICL)
2nd Floor, APCRDA Office, Rayapudi, Thulluru Mandal, (A.P.)

NIT No. Lr. No. MAU61-USI0HB(OTH)/182/2026-HB Dated: 20/08/2026

E-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE

Name of work: APCRDA – "Engagement of Project Management Consultant (PMC) for Providing MEP like high & low side Electrical, HVAC, Fire Protection System, Lifts, Fire Alarm & Public Address System and Plumbing works, Facade with Lighting & Interiors in Integrated Andhra Pradesh State Secretariat & HoD Offices (GAD Tower, Tower 1 & 2, Tower 3 & 4) in Amaravati Government Complex, Andhra Pradesh".

The bid can be downloaded on AP e-procurement portal from **22.08.2026 to 07.09.2026** up to **14.00 Hrs.** Due date for submission of Bid is **07.09.2026** up to **15.00 Hrs,** Technical bid opening **07.09.2026 @ 16.00Hrs.** For further details Please refer to **www.apeprocurement.gov.in** and **www.crda.ap.gov.in.**

Sd/- MANAGING DIRECTOR, AGICL, Amaravati

Institute of Seismological Research
(Department of Science & Technology, Govt. of Gujarat)
Knowledge Corridor,
Raisan, Gandhinagar, Gujarat -382009

INSTITUTE OF SEISMOLOGICAL RESEARCH (Dept. of Science & Technology, Govt. of Gujarat), Knowledge Corridor, Raisan, Gandhinagar - 382009. **Special Recruitment Drive for Persons with Benchmark Disabilities (PwBD) (Advt. No.: [ISR/2026/Aug/01/CoreGroup]):** Applications are invited from eligible Indian Nationals for the post of **Scientist-B (01 Post, Regular).** Pay Scale: Level-10 (₹56,100–₹1, 77,500). Upper Age Limit: 32 Years (relaxation applicable as per rules). Essential Qualification: PG in Geophysics, Geology, Physics, Computational Seismology, Earth Science, or Geotechnical Engineering (preference to Geophysics) with 1 year of post-qualification Seismological Research experience. For more details visit www.isr.gujarat.gov.in

INF-1200-26-27

SOUTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
Follow us on X@SCRailwayindia
Details of the Tender Notices of S.C Railway can be seen on our website : www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in

S/13/Auc. Prog/26-27 Dt: 14.08.2026

E- auction Program for the month of September, October & November - 2026.

PUB/565/26

SEPTEMBER e- Auction -2026	
Date	Divisions/Depots
01.09.26	SECUNDERABAD
03.09.26	NANDED
07.09.26	HYDERABAD
08.09.26	LALLAGUDA
10.09.26	SECUNDERABAD
15.09.26	NANDED
17.09.26	HYDERABAD
21.09.26	LALLAGUDA
23.09.26	SECUNDERABAD
25.09.26	NANDED
28.09.26	HYDERABAD
29.09.26	LALLAGUDA

OCTOBER e- Auction -2026	
Date	Divisions/Depots
01.10.26	SECUNDERABAD
05.10.26	NANDED
07.10.26	HYDERABAD
09.10.26	LALLAGUDA
12.10.26	SECUNDERABAD
15.10.26	NANDED
19.10.26	HYDERABAD
22.10.26	LALLAGUDA
26.10.26	SECUNDERABAD
28.10.26	NANDED
29.10.26	HYDERABAD
30.10.26	LALLAGUDA

NOVEMBER e- Auction -2026	
Date	Divisions/Depots
02.11.26	SECUNDERABAD
04.11.26	NANDED
06.11.26	HYDERABAD
10.11.26	LALLAGUDA
12.11.26	SECUNDERABAD
16.11.26	NANDED
18.11.26	HYDERABAD
20.11.26	LALLAGUDA
23.11.26	SECUNDERABAD
25.11.26	NANDED
26.11.26	HYDERABAD
27.11.26	LALLAGUDA

Principal Chief Materials Manager/ Secunderabad
A679

For further tender conditions / details and for downloading the tender documents, Please visit website at https://www.ireps.gov.in or www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in

KARNATAKA STATE NATURAL DISASTER MONITORING CENTRE
(A Regd. Society of Govt. of Karnataka)
Major Sandeep Unnikrishnan Road, Near Yelahanka-Attur Layout, Bengaluru- 560 064. Ph.: 080-67355000

No.KSNDMC/ADM/7/2025-ADM Date: 19.08.2026

E-TENDER NOTIFICATION

KSNDMC invites tenders for the following through e-Procurement portal on **https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in** Tender is invited for **(1) Providing Manpower Services for Data Centre Support and IT Technical Services at KSNDMC** vide tender No.KSNDMC/2026-27/SE0024. Pre- bid meeting is on **01.09.2026 at 4:00 PM at KSNDMC.** Last date and time for submission is **5:00 PM of 19.09.2026 (2) Supply, Installation, Commissioning and Comprehensive Maintenance of analogue addressable fire alarm system.** Tender No. KSNDMC/2026-27/IND0005. Pre-bid meeting is on **25.08.2026 at 3.00 PM at KSNDMC.** Last date for submission of bid is **5.00 PM of 08.09.2026.** Further the tender document details can be obtained through e-procurement portal of GoK

Sd/-Director

GOVERNMENT OF TELANGANA
HYDERABAD METROPOLITAN WATER SUPPLY & SEWERAGE BOARD
O/o Chief General Manager (Engg), PCC-I, Khairatabad, Hyderabad-500004, TG.

e-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE

e-tender Notice No. and Date	Name of Work	Approximate Estimate Contract Value
EP-04/CGM (E)/PCC-I/ Malakpet-Trunk Sewer/ 2026-27, Dated: 20-08-2026	Laying of RCC Trunk Sewer Mains at Malakpet Constituency Areas.	Rs.38.79 Crores

(1) The bid documents download starts online on or after: **24.08.2026.** (2) Name and address of Chief General Manager (Engg), concerned- **Chief General Manager (Engg), Project Construction Circle-I, HMWSSB, Khairatabad, Hyderabad-500004.** (3) The contractors/firms are requested to upload the information in the 'ZIP' format preferably. (4) Further details can be seen @ **https://tender.telangana.gov.in**

Sd/- Chief General Manager (Engg), PCC-I, Khairatabad, Hyderabad-500004, TG.

Dr. Balasaheb Sawant Konkan Krishi Vidyapeeth, Dapoli, 415712 Dist.- Ratnagiri.
Website - www.dbskkv.org
email id - universityengineerdbskkv@gmail.com Phone Numbers - 02358- 282413

E-TENDER NOTICE NO. 05 (F. Y. 2026-27)

Online Tenders (etender) In "B-1"form for the work is invited by the University Engineer, Dr. Balasaheb Sawant Kokan Krushi Vidyapeeth, Dapoli Dist-Ratnagiri (Phone No. (02358) 282413 on Government of Maharashtra Electronic Tender Management System, **https://mahatenders.gov.in** from the Approriate Contractor.

Sr. No.	Name of the work	Estimated cost (Rs,)	Amount of E.M.D. (Rs.)	Period of completion	Cost of e-Tender form non-refundable (Rs.)	Class
1	Construction of girls toilet block including repairing of the existing toilet block at Vijay Krida Sankul DBSKKV, Dapoli.	Rs. 43,40,704/-	Rs. 43,500/-	180 Days (Including monsoon)	Rs, 500/-	Class 5 A & Above
2	Repairs & Renovation to toilet block and extension of toilets and bathrooms in the Sindhudurg hostel of the college of Agriculture at DBSKKV, Dapolî.	Rs. 35,87,352/-	Rs. 35,900/-	180 Days (Including monsoon)	Rs, 500/-	Class 5 A & Above
3	Repairs yo Badmintn hall & construct adjacent changing room for boys & girls at Vijay Krida Sankul under DBSKKV, Dapoli	Rs. 35,71,971/-	Rs. 35,800/-	180 Days (Including monsoon)	Rs, 500/-	Class 5 A & Above

and the details can be viewed and downloaded online directly from the Government of Maharashtra e-tendering Portal https://mahatenders.gov.in and www.dbskkv.gov.in
No, DBSKKV/WORKS/A-7/1618 /2026

Dr. .Balasaheb Sawant Kokan Krushi Vidyapeeth
Dapoli, Dist-Ratnagiri
Date : 14 AUG 2026

Sd/-
(R. B. Ghadge)
UNIVERSITY ENGINEER

DGIPR/2026-27/2396

PUNJAB STATE POWER CORPORATION LTD.
Regd. Office: PSEB Head Office, The Mall Patiala-147001.
Corporate Identity Number U40109PB2010SGC033813
Website: www.pspcl.in (Contact No. 96461-22185)

Tender Enquiry No. 387/SS(D)-II **Dated: 20.08.2026**

Dy.CE/Substation Design/ TS Organization, C-1 Shakti Vihar, PSPCL, Patiala invites E-tender for Manufacture, Testing, Supply & Delivery of 1000 nos. SCADA-Compatible 11kV Vacuum Circuit Breakers (11kV VCBs). For detailed NIT & Tender Specification, please refer to **https://eproc.punjab.gov.in** from 20.08.26 (14:00 Hrs) onwards.

Note: Corrigendum and amendments, if any, will be published online at **https://eproc.punjab.gov.in**

No. 14456/PB **C 809/26**

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER
RURAL WORKS CIRCLE, BERHAMPUR
(At/Po- Ambapua, Near Income Tax office, Berhampur-760011, Ganjam, Odisha)
E-mail:- serwbpr2004@yahoo.com, Tel No.:-0680-2404287)

25001/989/2627

NOTICE

FOR PRADHAN MANTRI GRAM SADAK YOJANA (PMGSY)
NATIONAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING THROUGH "e"-Procurement
Bid identification No. Online Tender/18-2026-27/PMGSY/BPR

The Chief Construction Engineer, Rural Works Circle, Berhampur on behalf of Odisha State Rural Road Agency invites the percentage rate bids in electronic tendering system for construction of Roads & Bridges under Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana **[PMGSY-IV (B-i)]** in the districts of **Kandhamal for 10 (Ten)** number of packages with estimated cost totalling to **Rs 7.66 Cr (Approximate)** including their maintenance for five years from the eligible contractors registered with **State PWD /CPWD/MES / Railways.** The registered bidder of outside Odisha, can also participate in this process, but shall have to subsequently undergo registration with the appropriate authority of the State Govt. preferably within a month of the deadline for bid submission, but prior to signing of the contract

Date of release of Invitation for Bids through e-procurement. **Dtd. 25.08.2026**

Last Date/Time for receipt of bids through e-procurement: **08.09.2026 upto 5.30 P.M**

(i) EMD/ Bid Security, Cost of Bid document is to be transferred through Online as per the procedure mentioned in the DTCN.

(ii) Non-submission of the information/documents through online by the bidder as per mentioned DTCN will also liable for rejection of his tender.

For further details and corrigendum (if any) please log on to **www.pmgsytenders.gov.in.**

Sd/-
Chief Constration Engineer
R.W.Circle, Berhampur

OIPR-25001/25071/1/26-27/0029

MUMBAI SLUM IMPROVEMENT BOARD
A REGIONAL UNIT OF
(MAHARASHTRA HOUSING AND AREA DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY)
Tel no. 022-66405484, E-mail - eecityslum@gmail.com
Ref no. EE/City/MSIB / e-tender / 20 / 2026-27

e-TENDER NOTICE No. 20

Executive Engineer (City) Division, Mumbai Slum Improvement Board, (Unit of MHADA) Room **No. 539, 4th floor,** Griha Nirman Bhavan, Bandra (East), Mumbai 400 051 Phone Number (022) 66405484 is inviting Open / Regular e-Tender for the **06** number of works in the form of B-1 (Percentage Rate) from the Registered contractors in the corresponding appropriate class of contractor or any Govt. / Semi Govt. organization, via online e-tendering system. The detailed tender notice and Tender Documents shall be available & can be downloaded from Government of Maharashtra portal **https://mahatenders.gov.in,** Bidding documents can be loaded on the website. The tender Document sale start on **dated 21.08.2026, 01.05 pm.** to Document sale end **date 27.08.2026, 15.00 pm.** Corrigendum / Amendments if any could be published only on the **https://mahatenders.gov.in** website. The Competent Authority reserves the right to reject any or all the tenders without assigning any reason there of Conditional offers will not be accepted.

MHADA-Leading Housing Authority in the Nation **Sd/-**
CPRO/A/647 **Executive Engineer (City),**
M. S I B Board, Mumbai

Follow us: @mhadaofficial

INDIA'S TOUR OF SRI LANKA

Pant's fastest ton: Century of sixes for the iconoclast

One every 49 balls: a career built on cricket's most dispensable shot, turned into a signature

Sandip G
New Delhi, August 20

Sixes account for 600 of Rishabh Pant's 3,662 runs, almost one-sixth of what he has scored in Tests. CREIMAS

THERE ARE glorious Test careers that pass with nominal numbers in the six column. Australia opener David Boon, at odds with the machismo of his bristling moustache and piercing eyes, struck only two sixes in 18,116 balls. English opener Mike Atherton, no less obdurate, managed only four off the 20,609 deliveries he soaked up in Test cricket. VVS Laxman, disinclined to the savage pleasure of hitting sixes, brush-stroked only five balls beyond the fence.

Unlike in the shorter formats, it isn't a handicap or an anomaly there, but a number largely irrelevant to the game. Ben Stokes, the leading six-hitter in the long form, is remembered for his nerveless heists; the six-hitting prowess is merely an embellishment. Even Viv Richards, prophet of the most brutal swipes, is deified less for his sixes than for his swaggering aura. The six is not a requisite. It is, largely, dispensable.

The premise of the six in this format is what makes Rishabh Pant's feat, a century of sixes, the quickest ever, all the more striking. He has built a career out of a Test batsman's most dispensable run-scoring option. He needed only 4,934 balls for his hundred sixes, one every 49 balls. Stokes's 138, a record now at the mercy of Pant, came at one every 90 balls. Second on the list is Brendon McCullum, whose 107 arrived at one every 93rd ball. Adam Gilchrist, the first to reach a hundred, completes the quartet, a list without room for fearsome six-hitters like Chris Gayle, Virender Sehwag and Rohit Sharma. It's a curiously absorbing list: Jacques Kallis, cricket's perceived stonewaller, has hit more sixes (97) than Brian Lara (88), Sachin Tendulkar (69), AB de Villiers (64) and Ricky Ponting (73), the entertainers of his own era.

The achievement won't be romanticised the way Don Bradman's 99.94 is, or Brian Lara's 400, or Sachin Tendulkar's 51 hundreds. Nor will it stand as a metaphor for T20 cricket's pull on the Test game (even after the Bazball boom, a six still arrives only once every 155 balls), or suddenly make the six the strongest currency in the sport. It exists instead as an exotic outlier, worth fishing up to celebrate the quirks that make Pant such an unputdownable watch, and such an improbable success in red-ball cricket.

A six is his method. It's his madness too. He plays perfectly crisp strokes along the ground; he unfurls scything cuts, drills bullet cover-drives, whips through flicks. That's often his intention, until the bowler bristles in his run-up and the blood rushes in Pant's veins. That's when instinct overrides instructed wisdom, unbothered by the situation, his own form, or the sniff of a milestone. So instinctive is his six-hitting that he struggles to break it down for an audience. "If the ball is there to hit, I'll hit it. You have to punish it, that's what I'm doing," he once said.

It's as natural to him as a cover drive was to Virat Kohli, or a flick to Mohammed Azharuddin, or the front-foot defence, ripped straight off the stylesheet, was to Rahul Dravid. It's an expression of his joy, of the way he plays the game and feels it too. The record may well be a byproduct of his aggression rather than something he ever set out to chase. But the six is his métier. It isn't merely a tool to disrupt a bowler's length, a ploy to deny him rhythm. It's the stream his runs flow through. Sixes account for 600 of his 3,662 runs, almost one-sixth of everything he's scored.

A Pant six is riveting theatre. It's unpredictable: he might hit the first ball of an innings for six, even if the situation screams for caution. It subverts logic: he takes on the fiercest bowlers, reverse-sweeping James Anderson among them. It borders on absurd: one-handed, upper body flailing, knees buckled, his whole frame tumbling in the follow-through. It finds corners captains struggle to set a field for. The technique itself fascinates: the balance, the stillness even in motion, the free-flowing swing, the extraordinary reach for a man of his height, the loose bottom hand, the hand-eye coordination, bat-swing taking precedence over raw bat-speed.

The six carries his ambition and his desire. But more than either, it carries the free-spiritedness that defines the way he plays. It's his method, and his madness.

• Number Plate

49

• Pant needed only 4,934 balls for his hundred sixes, one every 49 balls. Stokes's 138, a record now at the mercy of Pant, came at one every 90 balls. Second on the list is Brendon McCullum, whose 107 arrived at one every 93rd ball.

The many boxes Team India ticked at Galle

OVER FIVE days, India found answers to several questions that had surrounded them before the Test, while some individuals strengthened their cases in emphatic fashion.

Padikkal No. 3 claim

Devdutt Padikkal strengthened his claim to the No.3 spot, making 221 runs in the Test. The left-hander arrived in Galle after impressing in the warm-up game, where he made 142, and left for Colombo as India's standout batsman. His 167 in the first innings and patient 44 in the second showcased the technique and temperament that team management and selectors wanted to see.

Suthar spins web

Suthar's 10/131 was built on variety and persistence. He struck with his very first ball, finding Dinesh Chandimal's edge, then removed Lahiru Udara and later Prabath Jayasuriya and Lahiru Kumara in the first innings. In the second, he dismissed Pasindu Sooriyabandara and Udara before returning on the final day to break Sri Lanka's resistance, including the wickets of Sonal Dinusha, Jayasuriya and Keshara Nuwantha.

Prasidh impresses

Prior to the first Test, Shubman Gill said this was the best he had ever seen Prasidh Krishna bowl. At Galle, he backed his captain's praise with the ball. His match haul of 3/63 in 24 overs showcased hard lengths, bounce, seam and awkward lift on a surface offering little assistance to pacers. His first-innings dismissal of Niroshan Dickwella ended a 146-run partnership with Dinusha.

India crack spin Test

With India's batting against spin under scrutiny after recent struggles at home, the Galle Test offered an improvement. Rather than allowing spinners to settle into a rhythm, India challenged them with decisive footwork, sweeps and selective aggression. KL Rahul and Rishabh Pant advanced and attacked at key moments, while Devdutt Padikkal combined positive strokeplay with disciplined defence. Dhruv Jurel and Ravindra Jadeja were more restrained, showing India could absorb pressure when required. While there were some lapses — Gill fell twice to Jayasuriya — India did find solutions against spin, which hopefully holds them in good stead in Colombo.

SHANKAR NARAYAN

HOCKEY WORLD CUP

India women hold firm, draw secures progression

Bichu Devi Kharibam made a save with 41 seconds left to earn India a draw against England. HOCKEY INDIA

Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, August 20

BICHU DEVI Kharibam had already done it once in Hyderabad. Back in March, with India's World Cup place on the line against Italy, the goalkeeper produced a crucial save in the 59th minute. Five months later, she did it again — this time with India's World Cup progression hopes on the line.

With just 41 seconds left, England couldn't have asked for a better player to be on the ball inside India's 'D'. Tessa Howard, the striker who has scored nearly 50 goals combined for England and Britain, got the ball on the reverse and unleashed a tomahawk. It was headed towards the bottom corner – until a diving Bichu pushed the ball away with her outstretched left hand.

On the touchline, Sjoerd Marijne punched the air. And seconds later, the final whistle blew. No goal. No defeat. India were through.

Significant draw

A 0-0 draw is not the kind of result that usually invites grand declarations. There are no celebrations around a winner, no individual hero hogging the headlines, no scoreline that demands to be remembered. But for India, this was perhaps the most significant scoreless draw they have played in a long time.

Because three matches into the World Cup, India are still unbeaten. They have drawn with China, hammered South Africa 6-1 and now held England, the side that beat them 2-0 in the World Cup qualifiers final in Hyderabad in March. They finished their pool campaign without a defeat, with a place in the next round secured.

More importantly, India have given themselves something they did not quite have when they arrived in the Netherlands: a World Cup campaign with momentum and meaning.

There were reasons to be cautious before the tournament. This was a team in transition, still trying to establish itself under Marijne. India had to negotiate the qualifiers to get here. Their recent past had been rocky, the rebuilding process incomplete and the World Cup squad a curious blend of experience and youth.

> ***More importantly, India have given themselves something they did not quite have when they arrived in the Netherlands: A World Cup campaign with momentum and meaning.***

The first match against China, to whom they had lost each of their four meetings before the World Cup, was therefore important. That they left the pitch after a 2-2 draw with mixed feelings, knowing they could have won it, was an immediate measure of the ground this team has covered.

Then came South Africa, and suddenly there was no ambiguity. India scored six times, with six different scorers, and produced the sort of attacking performance that had been missing too often from this team.

That set up England as the real examination. It was not just about qualification. These two sides have routinely met at World Cups. India knew that England would test whether the encouraging signs of the first two matches were genuine or merely the product of a favourable start.

Tough examination

Unlike the South Africa game, India did not have the freedom to sweep forward at will. The goals did not come. Their penalty corners, which had been so productive against South Africa, failed to produce a breakthrough. There were chances, and there were moments when India could have made the game their own.

But there were also moments – quite a few of them – when they had to defend. And defend really deep. That, perhaps, is what makes the draw significant.

For too long, India's performances have tended to be judged through a familiar binary: either a promising defeat against a stronger opponent, or a convincing victory against a weaker one. What this World Cup campaign has begun to offer is something different – a team capable of adjusting to the game in front of it. Against China, they fought. Against South Africa, they attacked. Against England, when the game demanded resilience, they survived.

Team on mend

That is the larger significance of Wednesday's 0-0.

India haven't won anything yet. They have not suddenly become World Cup contenders because they drew with England. There remain harder tests ahead, and the business end of the World Cup – which begins against the mighty Netherlands on Friday, followed by a crucial game against Australia – will expose every weakness that the group phase may have allowed them to hide.

But this team came into the tournament carrying questions. Could the youngsters handle this stage? Could the attack score enough? Could India compete with the better teams? And, perhaps most importantly, could a side still in the middle of a rebuild find a way to win — or simply avoid losing — when the margins became tight?

These three matches may not have provided all the answers, but there are enough signs of a team on the mend. The midfield held tight, the back line tighter. India had two disallowed goals from penalty corners and in the penalty corner defence, they ensured that none of England's 11 attempts found the target.

When Howard, who had already scored twice in this tournament, tried to have a final say in the dying seconds, Bichu denied her with a stupendous save. And for a team that arrived with more questions than expectations, that might be the most important save of all.

PLAYING TONIGHT: World Cup second stage: India vs Netherlands (Women's), 9.30 pm, Live on Star Sports Network and JioHotstar

Root, Cox fifties help England to lead

Reuters
Leeds, August 20

Joe Root struck a fifty against Pakistan on Thursday. AP

JOE ROOT and Jordan Cox struck fifties in a 150-run partnership before being dismissed in the space of five balls as England powered into a first-innings lead over Pakistan on a weather-hit Day 2 of the first Test on Thursday.

England reached tea on 239-4 at Headingley, with Harry Brook (15) and Dan Lawrence (22) in the middle and stretching the lead to 68 runs.

Play started four hours late - at 3 p.m. local time - because of rain with England 112-2 in reply to Pakistan's 171 all out, and Cox (73) and Root (66) picked up where they left off Wednesday.

Almost matching each other run for run, Cox reached his first half-century in just his second Test appearance minutes before Root got to the milestone for the 109th time in a Test career that has seen him score more than 14,000 runs - only behind India great Sachin Tendulkar.

Chance missed

Dropped on 57 by Khurram Shahzad off a presentable caught-and-bowled chance, Cox eventually departed when he edged behind left-arm spinner Ali Usman. The batter appealed the decision, perhaps thinking he had struck his own pad, but the nick was clear.

The very next over, Root also departed when he inexplicably missed a straight one from Khurram and was trapped lbw - then wasted a review that showed the ball was hitting middle stump.

It was a great chance for England's new captain to score his national record-extending 42nd century.

Behind on runs, Pakistan was briefly in the ascendancy and it could have gotten better for tourists, only for stand-in captain Salman Agha, at second slip, to drop Brook on 1. Worse for Agha was him needing to go off the field for treatment on the finger the ball brushed past.

Lawrence was making his first Test appearance in two years and had already struck four boundaries.

> ***Almost matching each other run for run, Cox reached his first half-century in just his second Test appearance minutes before Root got to the milestone for the 109th time***

BRIEF SCORES (AT TEA): Pakistan 171 vs **England** 239/4 (**Jordan Cox** 73, **Joe Root** 66).

Grand Slams create player council to give them inputs into biggest tennis events

Brian Mahoney
New York, August 20

THE GRAND Slam tennis tournaments have created a player council, giving players greater input into matters involving the biggest events in the sport.

The Grand Slam Player Advisory Council was announced Thursday by the Australian Open, the French Open, Wimbledon and the U.S. Open. It will begin following the final major of the year, which begins next week in New York.

Players have been seeking a larger share of revenues from the Grand Slams, along with better representation, health options and pensions. Some limited their media appearances at the French Open and Wimbledon as a protest, with top-ranked Aryna Sabalenka and Coco Gauff among the stars who even threatened a potential boycott of the Slams before play began in Paris if they didn't start receiving more compensation.

"The Grand Slams are the biggest events of the year and the events that the players prioritize and focus on throughout the season," American Jessica Pegula, the No. 3-ranked woman, said in a statement. "Their impact on a player's career cannot be overstated, and that is why it is so important that we have a voice in matters at these tournaments." The Grand Slams said the goal of the council will be to strengthen the partnership between the tournaments and the players, with a focus on player input into sporting matters at the events.

The tournaments and players are currently developing the composition and structure of the council. Interested players will be invited to apply for positions. Along with matters that affect the Grand Slams collectively, the council will provide a forum for players to discuss things such as prize money and player welfare with each of the tournaments individually.

The Australian Open, French Open and U.S. Open are operated by non-profit governing bodies.

"We have listened to the players' desire for a greater voice and this advisory council is an important step toward a stronger relationship between the Grand Slams and the players," said Deborah Jevans, chair of the All England Club. "We look forward to working together to elevate the player experience, further enhance the Grand Slam tournaments and ensure the sport continues to thrive."

Alcaraz back

Carlos Alcaraz will return to competitive tennis at the U.S. Open, ending a more than four-month absence caused by a wrist injury, in a bid to defend his title in New York. The 7-time Grand Slam champion confirmed that he will play the tournament after missing the French Open and Wimbledon. **AP**

Shivpal handed 10-year ban

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, August 20

FORMER ASIAN silver medallist javelin thrower and Olympian Shivpal Singh has been handed a 10-year suspension by the National Anti-Doping Agency (NADA) Disciplinary Panel for a second doping offence after testing positive for the banned substance methandienone. At 31, it could mean the end of a career for the javelin thrower, who competed at the Tokyo Olympics.

Shivpal, whose best achievement in his career is the silver medal he had won at the 2019 Asian Championships in Doha while throwing his personal best of 86.23m, is not the only Indian athlete to face action in recent cases. Sprinter MV Jilna has been provisionally suspended for a second offence after testing positive for mephentermine.

Earlier, in 2021, Shivpal's dope sample had tested positive for a steroid in an out-of-competition test.

> We knew what was coming and we just had to keep our calm... There have been situations before when we didn't feel perfect but fought back.
>
> **CHIRAG SHETTY,** INDIAN MEN'S DOUBLES SHUTTLER

Jolly good day for doubles

Treesa-Gayatri beat World No.7 Rin Iwanaga and Kie Nakanishi to get within one win of a podium finish

Treesa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand defeated the Japanese pair of Rin Iwanaga and Kie Nakanishi 21-16, 21-12 to secure a place in the quarter-finals. AP

Shivani Naik
New Delhi, August 20

TREESA JOLLY-Gayatri Gopichand don't go looking for weaknesses in opponents, though those are very useful to know. They pick on, they prod, poke and prise open a documented strength of the pairing they face, and then go about demolishing that solidity to pieces.

World No 7s Rin Iwanaga and Kie Nakanishi wouldn't have imagined that the front-court lunge defence, a skill the Japanese could pull off in their sleep, would see them come up short. And on the biggest stage of the World Championships.

The Indians' trick? Using the conventional kill weapon - the deep smash - as set-up, and using the soft-drop to turn the knife for a 21-16, 21-12 win.

Treesa-Gayatri were leading 13-9 before the Japanese pulled the weight of their ranking with quick exchanges to get to 13-13, going on to pull the lead to 16-13 with seven straight points. For the Indians ranked World No.39, it might well have been a quiet exit from the home Worlds. But the fight was on.

A late challenge from the Japanese, allowed by the chair umpire, got the Indians agitated. They pointed it out with gusto, even giving the impression that their attention was fragmenting. But Treesa would later recall how she was completely calm and telling herself not to fall apart even if the lead had evaporated.

Coach Pullela Gopichand was completely focused on keeping the Treesa-tornado ready to fire. The Japanese Top 10s are known to be solid. It's at this point that the Indian rotation kicked in. Gayatri tracked back to stabilise the back court, absorbing in defence, and allowed Treesa to compose her rhythm on the front court. This was the holding stage of the attack.

When they rotated back, both Gayatri and Treesa started sending flatter smashes to the back court.

"We knew what to expect, and that Treesa would send smashes, but we couldn't do anything about it. Neither could we get our attack going," Iwanaga would say later. It was only the start of trouble.

For three points in a row after that, Gayatri and Treesa brought on badminton's version of boxing's 1-2 jab-punch, using the smash as a dislodging weapon to push both Japanese back, like waves on a high tide warning beach-goers back to shore. The next return would invariably be taken high and early, right after it crossed the net and plonked onto the empty front court.

> **The Indians' momentum was tremendous. And then they were helped by the crowd,"**
>
> **RIN IWANAGA,** JAPANESE BADMINTON PLAYER

The Japanese, in their crouching defensive stance, were in no position to lunge for the low retrieves they are otherwise so good at. Tangled in their toes, the torso reflexing back in dreaded anticipation of the Indian smash while the feet needing to stride forward, saw the Japanese in one right mess on the floor. Iwanaga in an attempted vertical split while Naganishi in an awkward knee fold. It would end in the Indians taking the opener 21-16.

Homework works

Japanese retrieving in women's doubles is legendary. But Gayatri is turning out to be one right puppeteer with her vision from her net perch. In the time that Treesa healed from her injury, Gayatri has upped her backcourt game with her smash not meant for a sensational kill, but for the sly sting simply to put opponents in awkward spots on the court. Treesa's soft drop-game has been evolving into a crafty variation that boggles opponents who can't fathom if a smash or drop will ooze forth. But it needs Gayatri to spin the intricate web.

"Those are very crucial shots that Gaya sets up before I take off," Treesa says. "I like setting up those shuttles for her because I know Treesa will kill them," Gayatri says. "And when Treesa kills....," she trails off; they stay killed.

Treesa would even court a yellow card for flailing the racquet mid-game. But it fired her up to drop all nuance and go smashing aggressively and without fear. Gayatri would let the hell-raiser go a little ballistic as the Indians raced to 12-4 in the second. This was their third match in four days, the first against Top-10 seeds, but the Indians had their plans pat.

"The Indians' momentum was tremendous. And then they were helped by the crowd," Iwanaga would say, even as Nakanishi was in a pool of tears fronting the media. It might've felt like a yo-yo on the end of a crazy string as the Indians threatened cannonballs on the backcourt, but razed down the ground on the front court.

World Championships medals rarely come without downing a Chinese, or four. And Treesa-Gayatri will play perhaps the biggest match of their early career, facing defending champion Jia Yi Fan who has turned up with a shuffled partner, Zhang Shu Xian in the quarters.

Women's doubles has been the preserve of Chinese, Koreans and Japanese. But Treesa-Gayatri find themselves in the Last 8 along with three Chinese combines, two Indonesians, a Korean and a pair from Hong Kong. They have the opportunity to match Jwala Gutta and Ashwini Ponappa, who started India's unbroken streak from 2011. They will need the giant killing act together again.

Satwik-Chirag overcome Malaysians, pain barrier

Shivani Naik
New Delhi, August 20

BETWEEN SHOULDERING the burden of bringing a home World Championship medal and burdening his shoulder in trying to do it, Satwiksairaj Rankireddy kept Delhi's Indira Gandhi stadium thoroughly entertained.

World badminton's most powerful smash is currently fragile due to his overused shoulder. But there was no pulling back on smashes once he committed to them, as him and Chirag Shetty battled for 82 minutes against Malaysians Junaidi Arif and Roy King Yap before reaching the quarters with a 21-23, 21-19, 21-17 back-from-the-brink win and get within one step of their third Worlds medal.

The Delhi crowd was offered something that goes beyond medals, national pride and partisanship: pure edge-of-the-seat entertainment. They wholeheartedly embraced the ups and downs that the duo offered - taped shoulder, misfiring shots, warts and all.

When they lost the opening game from 16-12 up, the crowd wouldn't have been faulted for giving up. But they stayed on. Even when things got dire at 21-23, 16-18, three points away from an exit. Satwik had been ambushed predictably by the young Malaysians who saw an opportunity to scalp a patchy, scratchy pair of Indian giants. But while tendons and bones might break, the fight never cracked. Tan Kim Her and Pullela Gopichand were on the coaching bench, with the latter forgetting his inscrutable ways and clapping, wincing, shuddering, expressing glee - not too different from what fans in the stands would.

SatChi will face Liang Weiking-Wang Chang next. GAJENDRA YADAV

Even if Satwik struggled on fast parallels, he laboured on and plodded past the pain. The shoulder felt more tense and Satwik admitted he was stressing more over his health than strategy. A surgery is imminent, but before that there is a home World Championship to honour, even temporarily forgetting the shoulder and the shooting pain it sent through his arm.

"All good," he would reassure nevertheless, not wanting to fuss.

Crossing pain barrier

Chirag took on the defensive duties on both flanks, front and back, though the Malaysians tried turning the knife in the direction of where Satwik hunched. The shoulder is busted, but the Indians refused to give up on the 1-2. First Chirag soared, then Satwik went up, knowing their attack could break the spirit of any opponent.

The Chirag swivel serve delayed the chance to pounce, and both Indians kept the shuttle in play till they could string together an attacking 1-2. Satwik was being cautious, because he was literally risking the shoulder with every hit.

The decider was earned with plenty of hard labour and chewed nails in the stands, and the duo made it unforgettable for those who had turned up, and stayed on.

They trailed 12-15 again, but they have navigated enough bad days. Satwik stepped up in time, Chirag remained aggressive as optimum smashing got the job done. "There have been situations before when we didn't feel perfect but fought back," Chirag said.

The 19-17 point was the rally of the day. The Indians were under heavy smashing attack, survived it, made the offensive transition in a long rally and eventually ended with a smash. "We decided not to complicate," Satwik added.

Sindhu's 8-0 record against China ends with defeat to Wang

Thursday's defeat to Wang Zhi Yi was Sindhu's first-ever loss to a Chinese opponent at the World Championships. GAJENDRA YADAV

Pritish Raj
New Delhi, August 20

PV SINDHU walked into the IG Indoor Stadium in New Delhi with an unblemished 8-0 record against Chinese shuttlers at the World Championships. Eighty-eight minutes later, the Indian shuttler stood aghast, world No. 5 Wang Zhi Yi finding a precise drop into the front court to win 21-11, 19-21, 21-17.

The drop didn't just end that record. It also ended Sindhu's pursuit of a sixth World Championship medal, in front of her home crowd.

"I am disappointed and sad about it. I should have converted the match, it was a close one," Sindhu said after the match.

She kept a brave face through it, but the loss will sting all the more for how close she came to winning.

In the third game, Sindhu had held her lead till 15-13, with a raucous Delhi crowd behind her. But at 17-16, Wang suffered a hard fall and called for a medical break. After it, Sindhu managed only one more point as Wang raced away with the win.

"I should have been patient in the last three points. I don't think she had an injury, this was her tactic," Sindhu said. Patient is the operative word. The last three points Sindhu gave away were unforced errors, before Wang put away the winning drop.

It isn't the first time she has let a lead slip against Wang. In their Uber Cup clash in April, Sindhu led 18-12 in the decider, only to make similar errors and lose 21-19, a pattern that points to a larger problem: an inability to close out tight matches.

"Sindhu played brilliantly in the second game. In the third, she had a good start and was leading 8-4, but allowed Wang to come back into the game by making a few unforced errors. It was a tough loss for Sindhu, but I feel she is doing many things right and, if she continues on this path, she will do well going forward," renowned badminton coach Vimal Kumar told *The Indian Express*.

> ***With Sindhu's loss to Wang, and Ayush Shetty's loss to Alwi Farhan of Indonesia, 21-19, 21-11, India's challenge in the singles categories is over at the World Championships.***

A comeback cut short

The first game was a tale of two halves. Before the mid-game break, neither shuttler gave away an easy point. Wang made Sindhu work hard on her drops, while Sindhu gave Wang no room to land a clean smash.

Wang led 11-8 at the break, but after it, Sindhu made six unforced errors and one misjudgement, and lost the game 21-11. It was clear she needed to raise her game, and she did.

The second game looked nothing like the first. Sindhu mixed smashes with dribbles and net drops, catching Wang out in the front court repeatedly, forcing her wide or into the net. But Sindhu grew impatient whenever the rallies stretched out, and the mistakes that followed let Wang stay level with her, level at 15-15.

As the crowd noise rose, Sindhu didn't disappoint them, taking six straight points to close out the game 21-15, two winners of her own among them, four Wang errors making up the rest.

"You can't win it all. Once you lose something, you have to accept it also," Sindhu said. "I need to go back, sit with my coach and figure out how to improve."

With Sindhu's loss to Wang, and Ayush Shetty's loss to Alwi Farhan of Indonesia, 21-19, 21-11, India's challenge in the singles categories is over at the World Championships.

Dhruv-Tanisha out

ANI adds: Indian mixed doubles pair Dhruv Kapila and Tanisha Crasto crashed out of the BWF World Championships 2026 after suffering a straight-game defeat to China's Guo Xinwa and Chen Fanghui in the pre-quarterfinals at the Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium here on Thursday. The Indian duo went down 16-21, 5-21 against the Chinese pair in the Round of 16, ending their campaign at the home World Championships.

● PREMIER LEAGUE

Arteta chases title defence only three managers have pulled off

Sandip G
New Delhi, August 20

TO WIN the English Premier League is hard. To defend the title is harder. In the EPL era, only three managers have managed it. Two of them, Alex Ferguson and Pep Guardiola, are the greatest to have stood on the touchline in these parts. The third, José Mourinho, marked the league's biggest paradigm shift: its leap into the inexhaustible vaults of petrodollars.

The shadows that chase and spread over Arsenal manager Mikel Arteta are both inspiring and terrifying. He is a season's triumph from soaring into that rarefied space; he is a nudge away from rolling off the title-defence cliff. He doesn't like the act being called "defending the title." "I prefer to call it attacking the title," he said before the Community Shield fixture against Manchester City.

The peculiar shape of this season should cast his side as frontrunners. All their traditional rivals are in flux, in various stages of forging a nucleus that might challenge for titles in future, rejigging in search of a winning formula. Arsenal have strengthened their squad and possess arguably the most formidable midfield in the league. The window remains open for ten more days, and they could yet make another major signing.

Arteta is also the only current manager who has felt what it is to hold the trophy aloft. He and his players know how hard that journey was, the heartbreaks that hardened them, the setbacks that refined them. "When you get a taste of how nice it is, you want to do it again," Martin Ødegaard said after thrashing Manchester City to win the Community Shield.

The version of Arsenal that turned up in Cardiff that night was frightening: crushingly authoritative, thrillingly watchable, a world away from the defensive trudges of the past two seasons. But to be intoxicated by that canter would be a folly Arteta will work hard to avoid. The league guarantees nothing. Plenty of former champions could testify to that. Since Ferguson's retirement, only Guardiola has retained the crown, and the detail behind that fact is where the difficulty lies.

Every recent champion bar City has endured a baffling reckoning while trying to defend their title. Arne Slot's Liverpool sank without a trace last season, finishing 24 points behind their winning tally, despite a $500 million war chest. The year before, Guardiola's own side, champions four years running, ended 20 points adrift of their previous total. Chelsea and Leicester City have their own versions of the same story.

Arsenal won the Community Shield by beating Manchester City in the build-up to the Premier League. AP

Managers and pundits have gone looking for answers. "A lack of desire," Slot said bluntly, after his side finished 17 points off the pace. "You look into your players' eyes and it's a bit like looking at a lover. Either you see passion and a willingness to be seduced, or you watch as the passion ebbs away," he explained.

Others with less squad depth have pointed to fatigue, injuries, pre-season scheduling. Jürgen Klopp, during Liverpool's 2020-21 collapse, when the Reds finished 30 points behind their title-winning haul the year before, put it this way: "Could anybody know how the last season of 63 games could influence this season?... Would I do anything different? I wouldn't go in the first week of pre-season to Asia."

Missing piece

Arteta's Arsenal played exactly 63 games last season too. Several of his key players are notoriously injury-prone: Bukayo Saka, Ødegaard, Ben White, Kai Havertz. William Saliba, one half of the league's meanest centre-back pairing, is nursing a long-term injury. Arsenal missed out on their preferred target, Morgan Rogers, and lost the race for Vinicius Junior, leaving their forward line less thoroughly covered than their midfield and defence. There remains a chance they land Julián Álvarez, whom Atlético Madrid would rather send to north London than to Barcelona.

Álvarez, or someone fitting his profile, could be the missing piece. Goalscoring was a genuine concern last season: Arsenal's tally of 71 goals was the lowest for a title-winning Premier League team since Leicester City in 2015-16, and only 42 of those came from open play. Their most reliable scorer was Viktor Gyökeres, with 15, a consistent rather than prolific return. They have variety across the pitch, but every dynasty in this league has had a forward good for 20-plus goals a season.

Or Arsenal will hope their midfield compensates for what the forward line lacks. Declan Rice, Bruno Guimarães, Eberechi Eze, Martín Zubimendi, Mikel Merino and Myles Lewis-Skelly can be shaped into almost any system required. Rice is an all-action presence; Zubimendi blends silk with steel; Guimarães offers bite behind his passing range; Eze is deceptive and disciplined; Merino is the Swiss Army knife; Lewis-Skelly brings the verve.

The foundations look strong. Everyone else is still building theirs. Arsenal look like the clear favourites to retain the title. But the league offers no guarantees.

OPENING MATCH: Arsenal vs Coventry City, 12:30 AM IST (Saturday). live on Star Sports Network and JioHotstar.

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